CHAO FA

Second edition · everything to print, in one file

How to print

1. Print the whole file double-sided, flip on the long edge, at 100% / Actual size (never "Fit to page"), US Letter.
2. Card stock (250–300 gsm) for the cards, tiles, standees and tokens if your printer takes it; plain paper is fine for the rest. The box pages look best on glossy or label stock.
3. Blank pages are on purpose: they keep each card back behind its front and keep single-sided sheets single-sided.
4. If your printer cannot print double-sided, print the odd pages, put the stack back in, then print the even pages.

What is on which pages

3–106	**Cards** · poker-size cards (2.5 x 3.5 in), 9 per sheet, each fronts page followed by its mirrored backs page. Card stock 250-300 gsm. Cut on the crop marks.
107–113	**Board** · 4 landscape sheets that join into one 21 x 16 in board. Trim the edges marked with scissors, overlap so the art meets, tape on the back or glue to foam board.
115–118	**Place tiles** · 16 tiles (3.3 x 2.3 in), fronts then mirrored backs; the back is also the picked-clean side. Card stock.
119–121	**Standees and tokens** · 16 fold-over standees (cut, fold at the top, fold the tabs out as feet) and 67 round tokens and markers (glue to card, coins or wooden discs). Card stock.
123–128	**Player aids** · 6 two-sided half-Letter reference cards (two per sheet, cut on the dashed line). Plain paper or card.
129–131	**Story cloth** · the 7.5 in cloth mat and the nine stories. Plain paper, or card for the mat.
133–143	**Box** · box top and back in two halves each (portrait sheets), then the four side strips (landscape sheets). Glossy paper or label stock, wrapped on an 11.5 x 8.5 x 2 in box.
145–148	**Fight tracker and Patrol card** · 2 fight trackers (3.75 x 8.5 in) with their backs, then 2 Patrol cards (3.75 x 5.5 in), face 1 (1975-76) backed by face 2 (from 1977). Card stock; laminate or sleeve for a dry-wipe pen.
149–153	**Family boards** · 6 family boards (8 x 5.25 in), two per sheet: the villager card lies in the window, the HP track and the carry slots around it. Card stock.
155–167	**Dividers, labels and insert** · 26 tabbed deck dividers (2.6 x 3.9 in), the bag labels, and the box insert diagram. Card stock for the dividers, plain paper or label stock for the rest.
169–171	**Trail diary and family record** · one of each; print as many as you play. Plain paper.
173–177	**The First Winter** · the printed first game, 4 pages: a fixed deal and one family's first year, card by card, then the one-page Your first season sheet. Plain paper, double-sided.
179–215	**Endings booklet** · what became of each villager: ten numbered endings each, the same numbers for every villager, with the lookup table on its first pages. Plain paper, double-sided, folded or stapled as a booklet.

All artwork is original to this set. The story cloth squares are drawn in the style of the cloths stitched in the Thai refugee camps, not copied from any real cloth. Second edition rules: fights use the Patrol table and the Fortune deck (2026-10-20).

Also needed

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

SENGLAO (MAYOR)

Chai

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ■■□□□

Hang clan · Mai's husband; father of Chao and Gao · cannot swim

Rally the Village

Once per season, free (it costs Chai no action), while Hope is 3 or more and not in Winter: one villager who has not acted yet this season takes 1 extra action.

AFFINITY ITEMS

Soul Lock · Silver Bar

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

TEACHER

Tou

HP ●●●○○ ATK ◆◇◇◇◇ DEF ■■□□□

Vang clan · The village teacher, Chai's oldest friend · cannot swim

Talk Our Way Past

Once per season, when soldiers find the party (not the River Patrol), Tou speaks to them in Lao: draw a Fortune card, on 7 or more there is no fight.

AFFINITY ITEMS

Book · Translator

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

FARMER

Mai

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◆◇◇ DEF ■□□□□

Hang clan · Chai's wife; mother of Chao and Gao · cannot swim

Hidden Harvest

Once per season, as an action, where anything grows this season: +4 Food, and no one sees her.

AFFINITY ITEMS

Hoe · Knife

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

KID

Chao

HP ●○○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ■■■□□

Hang clan · cannot swim

Runner

Once per season, as an action that eats no Food: Chao runs ahead and reveals 1 hidden place next to the party, the one farthest ahead. The party's next Travel needs no Danger draw: he has seen the way.

AFFINITY ITEMS

Slingshot · Tub Luj

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

KID

Gao

HP ●○○○○ ATK ◆◆◆◇◇ DEF ■■□□□

Hang clan · Daughter of Chai and Mai; Chao's little sister · cannot swim

Hush

Once per season, when a noise or foraging draw would bring soldiers, Gao keeps everyone silent in the leaves: the soldiers pass by.

AFFINITY ITEMS

Doll · Rocks

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

HUNTER

Sheng

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◆◇◇ DEF ■□□□□

Lee clan · Mai's younger sister

The Hunt

Once per season, free (it costs Sheng no action; not in Winter): draw a Fortune card. On 6 or more, +4 Food. On 5 or less the shot is heard: an Easy fight.

AFFINITY ITEMS

Bow · Hmong Gun

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

BLACKSMITH

Chong

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◇◇◇◇ DEF ■■■□□

Xiong clan · The blacksmith; Pao's cousin · cannot swim

Bamboo Armor

Once per season, as an action: make a Bamboo Armor (body, Armor 1) for a villager with a free body slot. It falls apart after it has stopped 2 bullets.

AFFINITY ITEMS

Hammer · Sharpening Stone

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

SHAMAN

Meng

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ■■□□□

Yang clan · The shaman; Pa's nephew · cannot swim

Spirits Are Here

Once per season, as an action: look at the top 3 cards of this place, put any Danger or Nothing cards on the bottom, then search here once with no noise.

AFFINITY ITEMS

Cloth Mask · Chu Neej

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

FARMER

Pao

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◇◇◇◇ DEF ■■■□□

Thao clan

River Man

Once per season, as an action, where there is water (stream, bamboo, caves, jungle, fields, Lao village, riverbank, hamlet, ferry): +4 Food. At the river, one child, elder, sick or wounded villager crosses with him: 3 better on the current.

AFFINITY ITEMS

Scythe · Carrying Basket

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

RICE FARMER, MOTHER OF TWO
Mai

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆◆◆ ◇◇ DEF ▬ ▢▢▢▢

Hang clan · Chai's wife; mother of Chao and Gao · cannot swim

Every Grain

Always on. Mai's Forage finds 3 more Food wherever anything grows.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Hoe · Knife

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

TEACHER WHO READS THAI AND LAO
Tou

HP ●●● ○○ ATK ◆ ◇◇◇◇ DEF ▬▬ ▢▢▢

Vang clan · The village teacher, Chai's oldest friend · cannot swim

Reads the Signs

Always on. Tou's own searches look at 6 cards and keep 1 (the rest go to the bottom). The first search each season by anyone else looks at 2 and keeps 1.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Book · Translator

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

SENGLAO IN EXILE
Chai

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆◆ ◇◇◇ DEF ▬▬ ▢▢▢

Hang clan · Mai's husband; father of Chao and Gao · cannot swim

Keeps the Council

Always on. The council is offered 3 laws each Winter instead of 2, and every law it adopts gives Hope +1. Every Winter, if Hope is 1 or 0, Hope +1.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Soul Lock · Silver Bar

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

CROSSBOW HUNTER
Sheng

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆◆◆ ◇◇ DEF ▬ ▢▢▢▢

Lee clan · Mai's younger sister

Fresh Meat

Always on. Sheng's Forage finds 2 more Food wherever anything grows: snares, birds, fish traps. While Sheng holds a quiet weapon (bow, crossbow, spear, slingshot) the party fires first in every fight.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Bow · Hmong Gun

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

KID, LITTLE MOTHER
Gao

HP ● ○○○○ ATK ◆◆◆ ◇◇ DEF ▬▬ ▢▢▢

Hang clan · Daughter of Chai and Mai; Chao's little sister · cannot swim

Quiet Hands

Always on. Gao is never spotted while foraging, and her searches make no noise. Everyone else's noise is 2 lower.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Doll · Rocks

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

KID, MESSAGE RUNNER
Chao

HP ● ○○○○ ATK ◆◆ ◇◇ DEF ▬▬▬ ▢▢

Hang clan · Son of Chai and Mai; Gao's big brother · cannot swim

Lookout

Always on. The party is never ambushed: when soldiers find you or catch you foraging, you shoot back from the first clash.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Slingshot · Tub Luj

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

FISHERMAN-FARMER, STRONG SWIMMER
Pao

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆ ◇◇◇◇ DEF ▬▬▬ ▢▢

Thao clan · Chong's cousin by marriage

Strong Swimmer

Always on. Pao's current draw is 2 better, and anyone swept away after Pao is across is pulled out 2 better. Forage where there is water finds 2 more Food.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Scythe · Carrying Basket

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

SHAMAN WHO READS THE BONES
Meng

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆◆ ◇◇◇ DEF ▬▬ ▢▢▢

Yang clan · The shaman; Pa's nephew · cannot swim

Reads the Bones

Always on. Twice a year, when a Season card is drawn, Meng may put it on the bottom of the deck and draw another.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Cloth Mask · Chu Neej

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

RAFT BUILDER
Chong

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆ ◇◇◇◇ DEF ▬▬▬ ▢▢

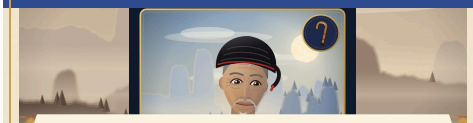
Xiong clan · The blacksmith; Pao's cousin · cannot swim

Builder

Always on. A camp Chong builds is finished in one action, and at the river the party's raft is free.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Hammer · Sharpening Stone

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA



ELDER
Blong

HP ●○○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ■■□□□

Hang clan · Chai's father; the grandfather cannot swim

The Old Road

Once per season, when the party Travels, Blong leads them by an old path: no Danger draw, and they gather 1 more Food on the way.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Cane Ring

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

SOLDIER
Cheng

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◆◇◇ DEF ■□□□□

Her clan · Bao's husband, home from the army cannot swim

Ready for Battle

Once per season, when a fight starts (not the River Patrol): the party has +2 ATK for that fight.

AFFINITY ITEMS
M-16 Hmong Knife

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

DOCTOR
Kong

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ■■□□□

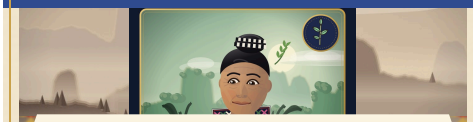
Moua clan · The doctor; Lee's son-in-law cannot swim

Field Surgery

Once per season, after a fight: the most wounded survivor heals 1 wound on the spot.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Medicine Box Scalpel

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA



MEDICINE WOMAN
Lee

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ■■□□□

Vue clan · The medicine woman; Kong's mother-in-law cannot swim

Fever Bark

Once per season, free (it costs Lee no action): cure one Sick villager and make a Healing Salve (HP +3, next fight).

AFFINITY ITEMS
Herbs Bandages

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

TAILOR
Bao

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◇◇◇◇ DEF ■■■□□

Lor clan · Cheng's wife, the tailor cannot swim

Winter Clothes

Once a year, free, in Fall or Winter: everyone draws 6 better at this Winter's Toll.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Needles Paj Ntaub

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

SINGER
Ka

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◇◇◇◇ DEF ■■■□□

Cha clan · The singer; Tou's niece cannot swim

Sing at Night

Once per season, free (it costs Ka no action): Ka sings kwv txhiaj by the fire. Hope +1, and the most wounded villager heals 1.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Qeej Tsaaj Nplaim

VILLAGER · SIDE A CHAO FA

SHAMAN
Pa

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ■■□□□

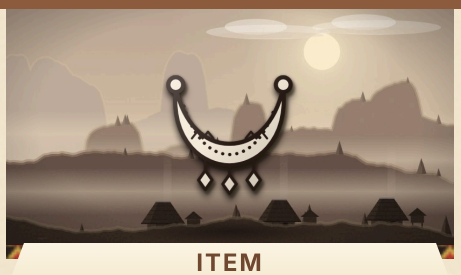
Yang clan · Meng's aunt, a widow cannot swim

Call the Soul Back

Once a year, when a villager would die in a fight, Pa calls their soul back: they live with 1 HP.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Joss Paper Incense Sticks

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA



ITEM
Soul Lock

+2 DEF for Chai; +1 DEF for anyone else.

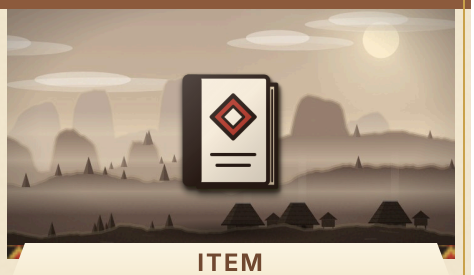
Chai's item (Senglao (Mayor))

PACK

A soul lock of ancestral origin.

Families hid silver neck rings under the floor when they fled.

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA



ITEM
Book

+2 DEF for Tou; +1 DEF for anyone else.

Tou's item (Teacher)

PACK

An old self-defense book of martial arts.

The village school was abandoned with its books on the shelf.

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

MEDIC TRAINED AT SAM THONG
Kong

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆◆ ◇◇◇ DEF ■■ □□□

Moua clan · The doctor; Lee's son-in-law · cannot swim

Field Medic

Always on. Every Rest heals 1 more wound, and when Kong nurses the Sick, the fever always breaks.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Medicine Box · Scalpel

ENDINGS P. 28 VILLAGER · 12/16

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

SGU RADIO OPERATOR
Cheng

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆◆◆ ◇◇ DEF ■ □□□

Her clan · Bao's husband, home from the army · cannot swim

Return Fire

Always on. When the party is ambushed, it still shoots back in the first clash.

AFFINITY ITEMS
M-16 · Hmong Knife

ENDINGS P. 26 VILLAGER · 11/16

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

ELDER WHO KNOWS THE OLD ROADS
Blong

HP ● ○○○ ATK ◆◆ ◇◇ DEF ■■■ □□

Hang clan · Chai's father; the grandfather · cannot swim

Knows the Hills

Always on. Every Danger draw when the party Travels is 2 better.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Cane · Ring

ENDINGS P. 24 VILLAGER · 10/16

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

KWV TXHIAJ SINGER
Ka

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆ ◇◇◇◇ DEF ■■■ □□

Cha clan · The singer; Tou's niece · cannot swim

Songs at Night

Always on. Hope never falls below 2, and at the start of every Winter her New Year songs give Hope +1.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Qeej · Tsaaj Nplaim

ENDINGS P. 34 VILLAGER · 15/16

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

TAILOR OF WARM CLOTHES
Bao

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆ ◇◇◇◇ DEF ■■■ □□

Lor clan · Cheng's wife, the tailor · cannot swim

Warm Clothes

Always on. Everyone's Winter Toll is 3 better.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Needles · Paj Ntaub

ENDINGS P. 32 VILLAGER · 14/16

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA

HERBALIST
Lee

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆◆ ◇◇ DEF ■■ □□□

Vue clan · The medicine woman; Kong's mother-in-law · cannot swim

Wild Greens

Always on. Lee's Forage finds 1 more Food wherever anything grows, every Rest heals 1 more wound, and when Lee nurses someone Sick the fever always breaks.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Herbs · Bandages

ENDINGS P. 30 VILLAGER · 13/16

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

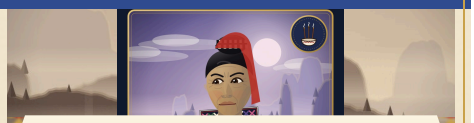
CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

VILLAGER · SIDE B CHAO FA



SHAMAN, SOUL CALLER
Pa

HP ●● ○○○ ATK ◆◆ ◇◇◇ DEF ■■ □□□

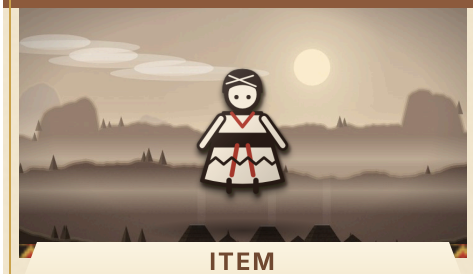
Calls the Soul Home

Always on. A death costs no Hope: Pa leads the rites. A fever Pa nurses always breaks. Once a game, the first villager the Toll would take is spared (hu plig). Winter at Hope 0 or 1: Hope +1. Once a year she reads the bones: put a drawn Season card under the deck, draw another.

AFFINITY ITEMS
Joss Paper · Incense Sticks

ENDINGS P. 36 VILLAGER · 16/16

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA



ITEM
Doll

+2 HP for Gao; +1 HP for anyone else.

Gao's item (Kid)

PACK

A Hmong doll.

A child's doll left on a sleeping platform.

THE TRAIL VILLAGE RUINS · 3/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

ITEM
Hammer

+2 ATK for Chong; +1 ATK for anyone else.

Chong's item (Blacksmith)

ONE HAND

An iron hammer.

The village blacksmith's forge still has its tools.

THE TRAIL VILLAGE RUINS · 4/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

ITEM
Ring

+1 HP, +1 DEF for Blong; +1 HP for anyone else.

Blong's item (Elder)

PACK

A very old ring with intricate carvings.

An heirloom ring in a wooden box under the altar.

THE TRAIL VILLAGE RUINS · 5/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

ITEM
Needles

+1 ATK, +1 DEF for Bao; +1 ATK for anyone else.

Bao's item (Tailor)

PACK

Needles used for sewing.

Every house has needles and thread for paj ntaub.

THE TRAIL VILLAGE RUINS · 6/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

ITEM
Paj Ntaub

+1 DEF, +1 HP for Bao; +1 DEF for anyone else.

Bao's item (Tailor)

BODY

Clothing that is used for show (flower cloth needlework).

Flower cloth folded in a chest for the New Year.

THE TRAIL VILLAGE RUINS · 7/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

LEGENDARY ITEM
Su-Kah

+1 DEF for anyone. Power: look at the top card of the search deck where you are.

PACK

A household talisman used to protect a house.

The household spirit altar on the back wall of the house.

THE TRAIL VILLAGE RUINS · 8/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

ITEM
French Silver Coins

Pays one boat seat when you have found a Boatman. Also +1 HP.

PACK

Old French Indochina silver piastres, the savings of a family.

Families sewed coins into clothes or buried them under the house.

MONEY

THE TRAIL VILLAGE RUINS · 9/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

ITEM
Iron Rice Pot

The holder finds 1 extra Food each time they Forage. Also +1 HP.

PACK

A heavy iron pot for steaming rice and boiling greens.

Every hearth had one, and few families could carry it.

THE TRAILVILLAGE RUINS · 10/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

ITEM
Village Flintlock

A hunting gun: +2 ATK.

BOTH HANDS

A long flintlock musket made by a Hmong blacksmith.

Hmong smiths made their own guns; one hung over many doorways.

LOUD

THE TRAILVILLAGE RUINS · 11/19

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

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Village Ruins

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SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

ITEM
Wood Axe

A tool and a weapon: +1 ATK, +1 DEF.

ONE HAND

A narrow-bladed axe for felling and splitting.

Every house kept one by the woodpile.

THE TRAILVILLAGE RUINS · 12/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

FOOD
Rice left in a granary

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Village Ruins.

THE TRAILVILLAGE RUINS · 13/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

FOOD
Rice left in a granary

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Village Ruins.

THE TRAILVILLAGE RUINS · 14/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

DANGER · EASY I
Soldiers searching the ruins

Easy fight now. Win and search here 1 time **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Your own village or a neighbour's, burned or abandoned when the soldiers came. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAILVILLAGE RUINS · 15/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

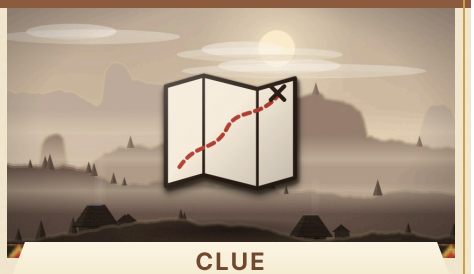
SHELTER
A standing house wall

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 DEF in the **next fight**.

A safe place to make a stand.

THE TRAILVILLAGE RUINS · 16/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA



CLUE
A Trail Map

Turn face up every tile in the next row.

A hand-drawn map of the paths to the river.

THE TRAILVILLAGE RUINS · 17/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

NOTHING
Already picked over

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAILVILLAGE RUINS · 18/19

SEARCH · VILLA... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · GUARDED
A Letter from Nong Khai

Key encounter, one step harder than easy: fight for it (Lao Clothes or a Travel Pass: **no step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A cousin who crossed last year wrote where the camp is and who helped him. **It is in the headman's burned house, and soldiers are still searching the ruins.**

THE TRAILVILLAGE RUINS · 19/19

SEARCH · SWIDD... CHAO FA

ITEM
Hoe

+1 ATK, +1 DEF for Mai; +1 ATK for anyone else.

Mai's item (Farmer)

BOTH HANDS

A garden hoe.

Hoes were left in the field huts at the end of the season.

THE TRAILSWIDDEN FIELDS · 1/17

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HOME

Village Ruins

CHAO FA

ITEM
Knife

+1 DEF, +1 HP for Mai; +1 DEF for anyone else.

Mai's item (Farmer)
ONE HAND

A garden knife.

The field knife hangs in every field hut for clearing brush.

ITEM
Slingshot

+2 ATK for Chao; +1 ATK for anyone else.

Chao's item (Kid)
ONE HAND

A slingshot made of wood and rubber bands.

Boys guarded the ripening corn from birds with slingshots.

QUIET

ITEM
Tub Luj

+2 DEF for Chao; +1 DEF for anyone else.

Chao's item (Kid)
PACK

A toy circular object that can be thrown (Hmong spinning top).

Children spun tops on the packed earth by the field huts while their parents worked.

ITEM
Scythe

+2 ATK for Pao; +1 ATK for anyone else.

Pao's item (Farmer)
BOTH HANDS

A garden scythe.

Harvest tools stored in the granary by the field.

ITEM
Carrying Basket (Kwb)

+2 DEF for Pao; +1 DEF for anyone else.

Pao's item (Farmer)
PACK

A kwb used to carry items and vegetables from the farm.

Carrying baskets are left at the field hut, ready for harvest.

LEGENDARY ITEM
Water Buffalo

+1 DEF for anyone. Power: discard a card to gain 1 Food (1 action).

SHARED BY THE PARTY

A water buffalo used to till rice fields.

A buffalo left in a burned field. It can be slaughtered for meat (4 Food, but -1 Hope).

ANIMAL

ITEM
Gourd Water Bottle

Clean boiled water: the holder draws 1 better at the Toll. Also +1 HP.

PACK

A dried gourd that carries water.

Gourds grew on the field fences and carried water to the fields.

SUPPLIES
Sack of Seed Rice

Gain 3 Food when found. (Then discard it.)

SHARED BY THE PARTY

A sack of rice kept back for next year's planting.

Seed rice was stored in the field granary.

⊘ USED SIDE

ITEM
Machete

A tool and a weapon: +2 ATK.

ONE HAND

A heavy field blade for clearing brush.

Left in a field hut when the family ran.

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

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CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · SWIDD... CHAO FA

FOOD

Ripe corn and pumpkins

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Swidden Fields.

SEARCH · SWIDD... CHAO FA

FOOD

Ripe corn and pumpkins

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Swidden Fields.

SEARCH · SWIDD... CHAO FA

DANGER · MEDIUM II

A patrol burning the fields

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times in safety (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Hillside fields of upland rice and corn, cleared by slash-and-burn. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

SEARCH · SWIDD... CHAO FA

REMEDY

Ginger and herbs from the garden

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 HP in the next fight.

Rest, medicine or care.

SEARCH · SWIDD... CHAO FA

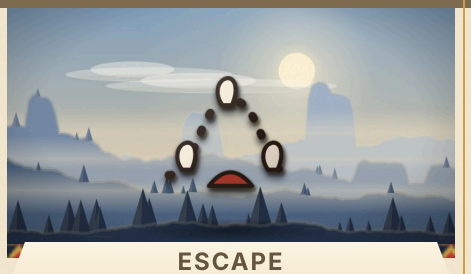
NOTHING

Burned

No effect. Discard this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

SEARCH · SWIDD... CHAO FA



ESCAPE

Smoke From the Fields

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, no fight.

A way past the soldiers in the Swidden Fields.

SEARCH · SWIDD... CHAO FA

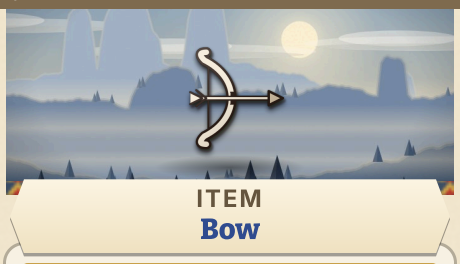
KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

Talk of the Road South

Key encounter, one step harder than medium: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight one step up). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

Farmers in the field huts know which paths the soldiers watch. **The farmers will talk, but their own children are hungry.**

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA



ITEM

Bow

+2 ATK for Sheng; +1 ATK for anyone else.

Sheng's item (Hunter)

BOTH HANDS

A bow used to hunt pheasants and small animals.

Hunters kept bows in their ridge-top shelters.

QUIET

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA

ITEM

Hmong Gun

+3 ATK for Sheng; +2 ATK for anyone else.

Sheng's item (Hunter)

BOTH HANDS

A gun with a very long barrel, used to hunt small game.

Long flintlock hunting guns were hidden in hunting shelters.

LOUD

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Swidden Fields

CHAO FA

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA

ITEM

Cane

+2 DEF for Blong; +1 DEF for anyone else.

Blong's item (Elder)

ONE HAND

A solid wooden cane for the elderly.

A straight walking stick cut from the ridge forest.

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA

LEGENDARY ITEM

Horse

+1 HP for anyone. Power: look at the top card of the search deck where you are.

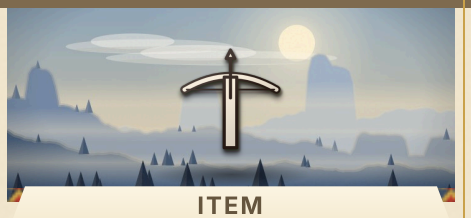
SHARED BY THE PARTY

A mountain pony.

A pony carries three loads and cannot enter the caves or cross the river. It can be slaughtered for meat.

ANIMAL

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA



ITEM

Crossbow (hneev)

Hunting: the holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage. Also +2 ATK.

BOTH HANDS

A Hmong hunting crossbow with bamboo bolts.

Hunters kept crossbows in their ridge-top shelters.

QUIET

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA

ITEM

Pine-Resin Torch

When the holder Searches, look at 2 cards and keep 1 (put the other on the bottom).

ONE HAND

A bundle of pine splinters soaked in resin.

Pine pitch burns slowly; hunters lit their way with it.

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA

ITEM

Hunting Spear

Keeps danger at arm's length: +1 ATK, +1 DEF.

BOTH HANDS

An iron spearhead bound to a bamboo shaft.

Hunters kept spears for wild pig in their ridge shelters.

QUIET

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA

FOOD

Wild mushrooms and a bird

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Pine Ridge.

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA

FOOD

Wild mushrooms and a bird

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Pine Ridge.

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA

DANGER · EASY I

A tiger on the ridge

Easy fight now. Win and search here 1 time **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

High, cool pine forest along the ridgeline above the villages. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA

SHELTER

A hunter's shelter

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 DEF in the **next fight**.

A safe place to make a stand.

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

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SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA

NOTHING

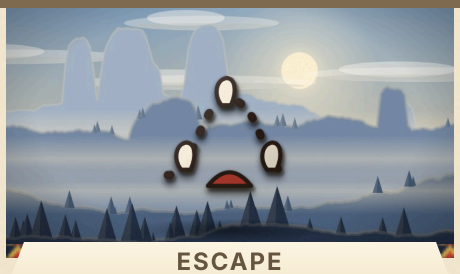
Nothing but pine needles

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAIL PINE RIDGE · 12/14

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA



ESCAPE

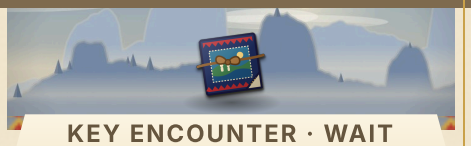
A Hidden Path

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Pine Ridge.

THE TRAIL PINE RIDGE · 13/14

SEARCH · PINE R... CHAO FA



KEY ENCOUNTER · WAIT FOR DARK

Signal Fires

Key encounter, **one step harder** than easy: take it; everyone eats 1 Food, and on a **Fortune card** of 1 to 8 a patrol comes (**one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

Resistance fighters light fires on the ridges to mark the safe way down. **The fires are lit only after dark, and the patrols watch the ridges too.**

THE TRAIL PINE RIDGE · 14/14

SEARCH · LONG ... CHAO FA

ITEM

Army Blanket

The holder draws 1 better at the Winter Toll. Also +1 DEF.

PACK

A heavy wool blanket from the war years.

Blankets came in supply drops to the hill airstrips.

THE TRAILLONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · LONG ... CHAO FA

ITEM

Transistor Radio

Look at the next Season card at any time.

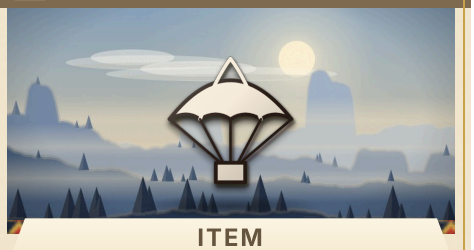
PACK

A battery radio.

Left in the radio hut at the strip. Radios carried news of patrols and of the camps in Thailand. Once a season, look at the top Season card and put it back.

THE TRAILLONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · LONG ... CHAO FA



ITEM

Cargo Parachute

A dry tent: the holder draws 1 better at the Winter Toll. Also +1 DEF.

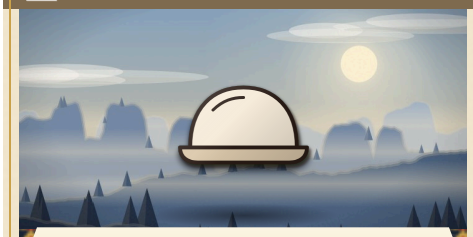
PACK

A nylon cargo parachute, white or striped.

Parachutes from rice drops lay snagged in the trees around the strips; families made tents and clothes from them.

THE TRAILLONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · LONG ... CHAO FA



ITEM

Steel Helmet

Armor 1: stops the first damage that would go to the wearer in each fight. +1 DEF. Also +1 DEF.

HEAD

An American steel helmet from the war years.

Dropped with other supplies at the hill airstrips.

THE TRAILLONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · LONG ... CHAO FA

ITEM

Flak Vest

Armor 1: stops the first damage that would go to the wearer in each fight. +1 DEF. Also +1 DEF.

BODY

A padded vest left by an aircrew.

Abandoned in a shed when the airstrip was evacuated.

THE TRAILLONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · LONG ... CHAO FA

FOOD

A torn sack of air-dropped rice

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Long Tieng Airstrip.

THE TRAILLONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Pine Ridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · LONG … CHAO FA

FOOD

A torn sack of air-dropped rice

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Long Tieng Airstrip.

THE TRAIL LONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · LONG … CHAO FA

DANGER · MEDIUM II

Soldiers watching the strip

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times in safety (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

The long dirt runway of Long Tieng, the Hmong army's old headquarters, between the karst hills. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAIL LONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · LONG … CHAO FA

SHELTER

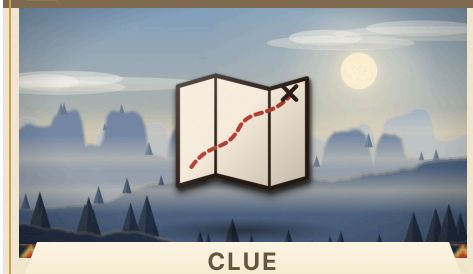
A burned-out supply hut

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 DEF in the next fight.

A safe place to make a stand.

THE TRAIL LONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · LONG … CHAO FA



CLUE

A Trail Map

Turn face up every tile in the next row.

A hand-drawn map of the paths to the river.

THE TRAIL LONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · LONG … CHAO FA

NOTHING

Bare red earth

No effect. Discard this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAIL LONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · LONG … CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · ON THE FALLEN

A Pilot's River Chart

Key encounter, one step harder than medium: take it, then his comrades ambush you at this place's level. Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

An old air chart with the Mekong fords marked in pencil. **It is in the pocket of a dead soldier by the burned huts. His patrol is close.**

THE TRAIL LONG TIENG AIRSTRIP

SEARCH · BAMB… CHAO FA

ITEM

Tsaaj Nplaim

+2 HP for Ka; +1 HP for anyone else.

Ka's item (Singer)

PACK

An instrument used to court people.

A leaf or bamboo-reed courting instrument made in the grove.

THE TRAIL BAMBOO FOREST · 1/13

SEARCH · BAMB… CHAO FA

ITEM

Bamboo Float Tubes

The holder draws 2 better crossing the river.

PACK

Sealed lengths of giant bamboo tied together.

Non-swimmers tied bamboo tubes under their arms to cross the Mekong.

FLOAT

THE TRAIL BAMBOO FOREST · 2/13

SEARCH · BAMB… CHAO FA

ITEM

Bundle of Raft Poles

Lets the party build a raft without giving up 2 items.

SHARED BY THE PARTY

Long dry bamboo poles, cut and bundled.

Giant bamboo floats well and was lashed into rafts.

RAFT

THE TRAIL BAMBOO FOREST · 3/13

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Long Tieng Airstrip

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Bamboo Forest

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Bamboo Forest

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Bamboo Forest

CHAO FA

SEARCH · BAMB... CHAO FA

ITEM
Snare Traps

The holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage.

PACK

Wire and cord snares for birds and small animals.

Hunters set snares on the rat and bird trails through the bamboo.

SEARCH · BAMB... CHAO FA

FOOD
Bamboo shoots

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Bamboo Forest.

SEARCH · BAMB... CHAO FA

FOOD
Bamboo shoots

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Bamboo Forest.

SEARCH · BAMB... CHAO FA

DANGER · EASY I
A militia patrol on the path

Easy fight now. Win and search here 1 time **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Dense groves of giant bamboo in the valleys below the ridges. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

SEARCH · BAMB... CHAO FA

REMEDY
Clean bamboo water

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest, medicine or care.

SEARCH · BAMB... CHAO FA

NOTHING
Only old bamboo

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

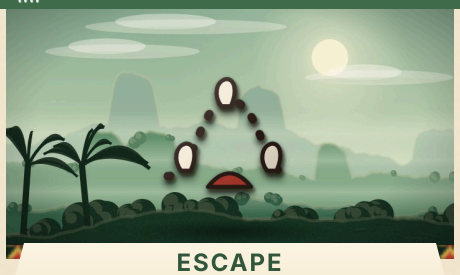
SEARCH · BAMB... CHAO FA

AMBUSH · EASY I
Soldiers waiting in the grove

Easy fight now. Ambush: the soldiers **fire first** (you deal nothing in clash 1).

Dense groves of giant bamboo in the valleys below the ridges.

SEARCH · BAMB... CHAO FA



ESCAPE
A Tunnel Through the Bamboo

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Bamboo Forest.

SEARCH · BAMB... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · MINED
Blazes on the Bamboo

Key encounter, **one step harder** than easy: take it; everyone draws a **Fortune card**, 1 to 4 = **2 wounds** (Dog: only 1). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

Families who went before cut marks in the bamboo to show the path. **The soldiers found the marks too, and mined the path.**

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Bamboo Forest

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Bamboo Forest

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Bamboo Forest

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SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

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SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Bamboo Forest

CHAO FA

SEARCH · BAMB... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

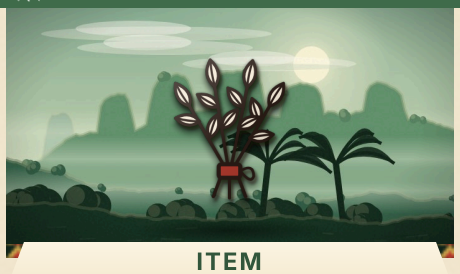
A Raft-Maker's Word

Key encounter, **one step harder** than easy: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A man cutting bamboo says which stream carries rafts down to the Mekong. **He has a family to feed and will not say for nothing.**

THE TRAILBAMBOO FOREST · 13/1

SEARCH · PHOU ... CHAO FA



ITEM

Herbs

+2 HP for Lee; +1 HP for anyone else.

Lee's item (Medicine Woman)

PACK

Various herbs that smell sweet.

Medicine plants grow wild in the deep forest.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU ... CHAO FA

LEGENDARY ITEM

Dog

+1 HP for anyone. Power: discard a card to gain 1 Food (1 action).

SHARED BY THE PARTY

A village dog used to guard a house.

A village dog that ran into the forest finds you.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU ... CHAO FA

ITEM

Rattan Rope

The holder draws 1 better crossing the river (tied to the raft or the others). Also +1 DEF.

PACK

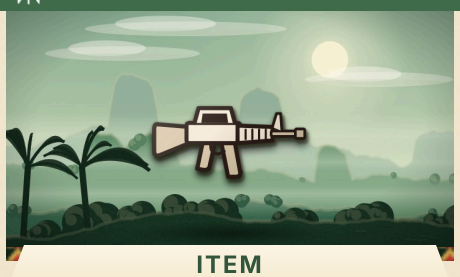
Rope twisted from split rattan cane.

Rattan vines grow in the deep forest.

FLOAT

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU ... CHAO FA



ITEM

Dropped Rifle

A strong weapon: +3 ATK.

BOTH HANDS

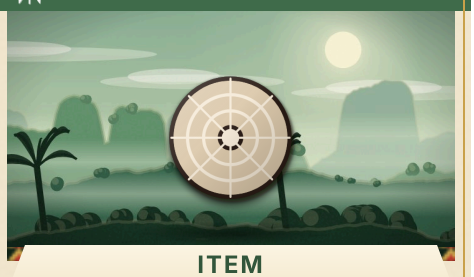
A rifle left beside the trail with a few rounds.

Soldiers of the Secret Army dropped heavy gear as they fled through the forest.

LOUD

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU ... CHAO FA



ITEM

Rattan Shield

Armor 1 and +1 DEF. Also +1 DEF.

ONE HAND

A round shield of woven rattan, hardened over smoke.

Made in the forest from split rattan cane.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU ... CHAO FA

FOOD

Wild yams and fruit

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Phou Khao Khouay Jungle.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU ... CHAO FA

FOOD

Wild yams and fruit

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Phou Khao Khouay Jungle.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU ... CHAO FA

DANGER · MEDIUM II

A sweep through the jungle

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Tall rain forest on the sandstone hills between the mountains and the Mekong, with leeches and little light. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Bamboo Forest

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

DANGER · MEDIUM II

A sweep through the jungle

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Tall rain forest on the sandstone hills between the mountains and the Mekong, with leeches and little light. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

SHELTER

A hidden hollow

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 DEF in the **next fight**.

A safe place to make a stand.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

REMEDY

Healing leaves

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest, medicine or care.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

CLUE

A Guide

Keep this card. Every Danger draw when the party moves is 3 better.

A Lao farmer, or a Hmong man who knows the trails, offers to lead you.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

NOTHING

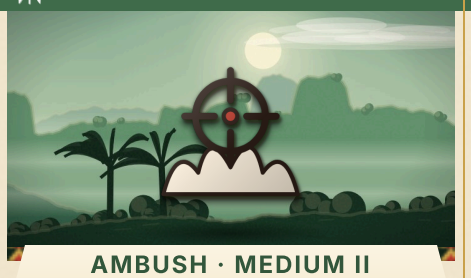
Lost in the undergrowth

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA



AMBUSH · MEDIUM II

An ambush in the undergrowth

Medium fight now. Ambush: the soldiers **fire first** (you deal nothing in clash 1).

Tall rain forest on the sandstone hills between the mountains and the Mekong, with leeches and little light.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

ESCAPE

Monsoon Rain

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Phou Khao Khouay Jungle.

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · GUARDED

A Resistance Courier

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: fight for it (Lao Clothes or a Travel Pass: **no step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A runner tells you where and when to meet the people who can help. **He is pinned down in a gully by a patrol. Free him and he will talk.**

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

A Soldier Who Deserted

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

He fought for the other side and knows where the patrols sleep. **He wants silver, or a gun, before he trusts you.**

THE TRAILPHOU KHAO KHOUAY JU

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

CHAO FA

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

ITEM
Silver Bar

+2 HP for Chai; +1 HP for anyone else.

Chai's item (Senglao (Mayor))

PACK

A silver bar used in bartering and trade.

Families hid their silver in caves before they fled.

MONEY

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 1/1

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

ITEM
Cloth Mask

+1 HP, +1 DEF for Meng; +1 HP for anyone else.

Meng's item (Shaman)

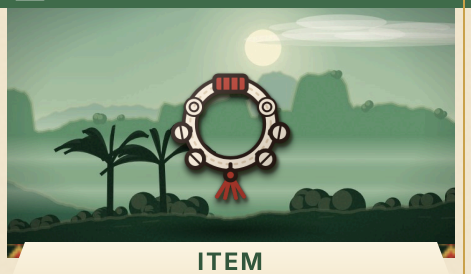
HEAD

A cloth mask used to cover your face.

The shaman's things were carried to the caves for safekeeping.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 2/1

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA



ITEM
Chu Neej

+2 DEF for Meng; +1 DEF for anyone else.

Meng's item (Shaman)

PACK

A jingle set made of iron and brass.

Shaman's rattles were hidden with other sacred things in caves.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 3/1

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

ITEM
Hmong Knife

+2 ATK for Cheng; +1 ATK for anyone else.

Cheng's item (Soldier)

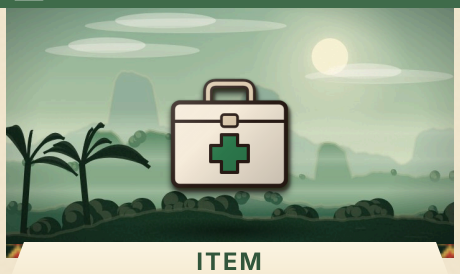
ONE HAND

A Hmong knife used in butchering animals and general use.

Resistance fighters cached knives and tools in caves.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 4/1

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA



ITEM
Medicine Box

+2 HP for Kong; +1 HP for anyone else.

Kong's item (Doctor)

PACK

A medicine box.

An aid post of the resistance kept its medicine box in a cave.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 5/1

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

ITEM
Qeej

+1 DEF, +1 HP for Ka; +1 DEF for anyone else.

Ka's item (Singer)

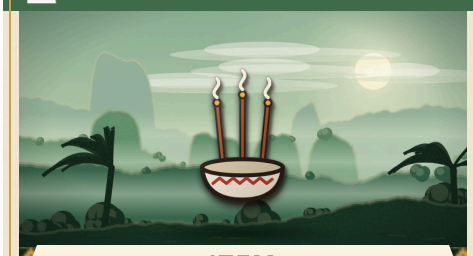
PACK

An instrument used to help call spirits.

A qeej carried up to the caves so the funeral songs would not be lost.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 6/1

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA



ITEM
Incense Sticks

+1 HP, +1 DEF for Pa; +1 DEF for anyone else.

Pa's item (Shaman)

PACK

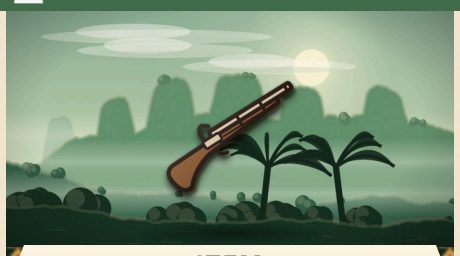
Incense sticks used to help call spirits.

Incense left at a cave shrine.

USED SIDE

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 7/1

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA



ITEM
Old Carbine

A strong weapon: +3 ATK.

BOTH HANDS

An American carbine from the Secret Army years.

Soldiers of the resistance cached weapons in caves.

LOUD

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 8/1

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

ITEM
Army Poncho

Dry in the monsoon: the holder draws 1 better at the Toll. Also +1 DEF.

BODY

A rubberised rain poncho.

Left with other supplies in a resistance cave.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 9/1

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

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Limestone Caves

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SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

CHAO FA

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

SUPPLIES

Hidden Rice Cache

Gain 4 Food when found. (Then discard it.)

SHARED BY THE PARTY

Jars of rice hidden at the back of a cave.

Families stored rice in caves to hide it from soldiers.

⊘ USED SIDE

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 10/

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

FOOD

Rice hidden in a jar

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Limestone Caves.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 11/

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

FOOD

Rice hidden in a jar

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Limestone Caves.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 12/

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

DANGER · MEDIUM II

Soldiers search the caves

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Caves in the karst towers, dry inside even in the monsoon. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 13/

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

SHELTER

A dry cave

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 DEF in the **next fight**.

A safe place to make a stand.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 14/

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

REMEDY

An aid-post first-aid kit

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest, medicine or care.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 15/

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

NOTHING

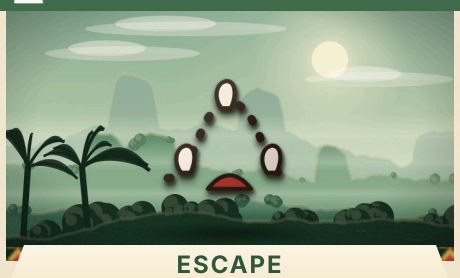
An empty cave

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 16/

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA



ESCAPE

A Back Way Out

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Limestone Caves.

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 17/

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · GUARDED

Names on the Cave Wall

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: fight for it (Lao Clothes or a Travel Pass: **no step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

Families scratched their names and the way they went into the rock. **Soldiers are camped in the mouth of the cave.**

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 18/

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

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SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

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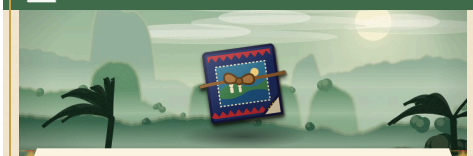
SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

CHAO FA

SEARCH · LIMES… CHAO FA



KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

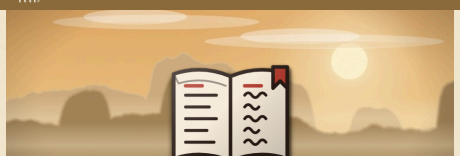
A Shaman's Blessing

Key encounter, one step harder than medium: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A txiv neeb calls the spirits to guide the family across the water. **The ceremony needs an offering: incense, paper money, a rooster, or rice.**

THE TRAILLIMESTONE CAVES · 19/

SEARCH · LAO F… CHAO FA



ITEM

Translator

+2 HP for Tou; +1 HP for anyone else.

Tou's item (Teacher)

PACK

A guide used to help translate Hmong to Lao.

Lowland traders kept Hmong-Lao word lists for doing business with hill people.

DISGUISE

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 1/2

SEARCH · LAO F… CHAO FA

ITEM

Bandages

+1 HP, +1 DEF for Lee; +1 HP for anyone else.

Lee's item (Medicine Woman)

PACK

Crudely made bandages.

Cloth bought or begged from lowland villagers.

USED SIDE

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 2/

SEARCH · LAO F… CHAO FA

ITEM

Joss Paper

+2 HP for Pa; +1 HP for anyone else.

Pa's item (Shaman)

PACK

Joss paper used as offerings for the dead.

Spirit paper sold by lowland traders.

USED SIDE

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 3/

SEARCH · LAO F… CHAO FA

LEGENDARY ITEM

Rooster

+1 ATK for anyone. Power: look at the top card of the search deck where you are.

SHARED BY THE PARTY

A village rooster meant to wake people up.

A rooster traded or caught in a lowland village.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 4/

SEARCH · LAO F… CHAO FA

ITEM

Lao Clothes

Disguise: every Danger draw when the party moves is 2 better.

BODY

A Lao sarong and plain shirt.

Dressing as lowland Lao helped families pass through villages and checkpoints.

DISGUISE

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 5/

SEARCH · LAO F… CHAO FA

ITEM

Bag of Salt

The holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage (salted food lasts). Also +1 HP.

PACK

Coarse salt from the lowland salt wells.

Highlanders bought salt from Lao traders; it keeps fish and meat.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 6/

SEARCH · LAO F… CHAO FA

ITEM

Mosquito Net

The holder draws 1 better at the Toll.

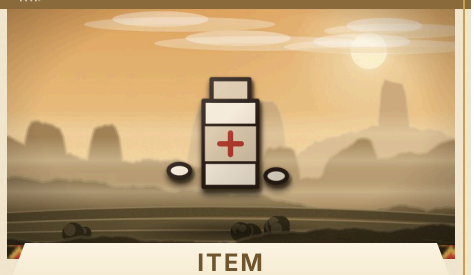
PACK

A cotton mosquito net.

Lowland traders sold nets; malaria killed many people in hiding.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 7/

SEARCH · LAO F… CHAO FA



ITEM

Quinine Tablets

The holder draws 2 better at the Toll. Also +1 HP.

PACK

A small bottle of malaria tablets.

Bought at a lowland market for silver.

USED SIDE

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 8/

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Limestone Caves

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

ITEM

Padded Cotton Jacket

Armor 1: stops the first damage that would go to the wearer in each fight. Warm: 1 better at the Toll.

BODY

A quilted jacket stuffed with kapok.

Lowland tailors sold padded jackets for the cold season.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 9

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

FOOD

Sticky rice from a kind family

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Lao Farm Village.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 10

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

FOOD

Sticky rice from a kind family

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Lao Farm Village.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 11

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

DANGER · MEDIUM II

Someone reports you

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

A lowland village of Lao rice farmers, on the way to the river. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 12

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

DANGER · EASY I

Someone reports you

Easy fight now. Win and search here 1 time **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

A lowland village of Lao rice farmers, on the way to the river. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 13

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

REMEDY

A village healer

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest, medicine or care.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 14

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

CLUE

A Guide

Keep this card. Every Danger draw when the party moves is 3 better.

A Lao farmer, or a Hmong man who knows the trails, offers to lead you.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 15

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

CLUE

A Trail Map

Turn face up every tile in the next row.

A hand-drawn map of the paths to the river.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 16

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

NOTHING

Doors stay shut

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAILLAO FARM VILLAGE · 17

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

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SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

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Lao Farm Village

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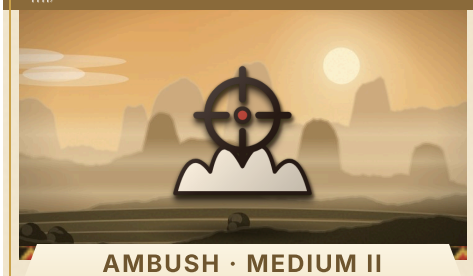
SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA



AMBUSH · MEDIUM II

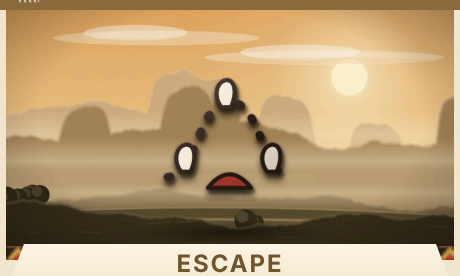
A trap at the well

Medium fight now. Ambush: the soldiers **fire first** (you deal nothing in clash 1).

A lowland village of Lao rice farmers, on the way to the river.

THE TRAIL LAO FARM VILLAGE · 18

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA



ESCAPE

A Friendly Warning

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Lao Farm Village.

THE TRAIL LAO FARM VILLAGE · 19

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

A Lao Friend's Promise

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A Lao farmer will hide you near the river on the night you cross. **He is risking his family. He asks for silver, or rice.**

THE TRAIL LAO FARM VILLAGE · 20

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · WAIT FOR DARK

Market Gossip

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: take it; everyone eats 1 Food, and on a **Fortune card** of 1 to 8 a patrol comes (**one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

At market they say which nights the river patrols change. **You must wait by the market until dark to hear it, where anyone could see you.**

THE TRAIL LAO FARM VILLAGE · 21

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · GUARDED

The Headman's Pass

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: fight for it (Lao Clothes or a Travel Pass: **no step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A stamped paper that lets a family walk the lowland roads. **The stamp is kept at the militia post at the edge of the village.**

THE TRAIL LAO FARM VILLAGE · 22

SEARCH · LAO F... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · WAIT FOR DARK

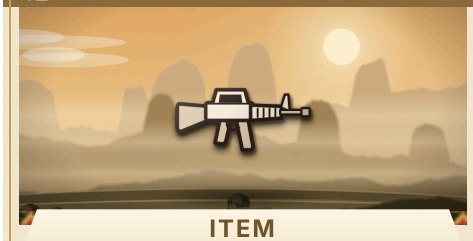
A Monk at the Temple

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: take it; everyone eats 1 Food, and on a **Fortune card** of 1 to 8 a patrol comes (**one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A Lao monk tells travellers which villages along the river are kind to strangers. **He will speak only after evening prayers, and the militia walks past the temple at dusk.**

THE TRAIL LAO FARM VILLAGE · 23

SEARCH · HIN HE... CHAO FA



ITEM

M-16

+3 ATK for Cheng; +2 ATK for anyone else.

Cheng's item (Soldier)

BOTH HANDS

An American-issued M-16.

Rifles from the Secret Army were taken at checkpoints and left in army stores.

LOUD

THE TRAIL HIN HEUP BRIDGE · 1/18

SEARCH · HIN HE... CHAO FA

ITEM

Scalpel

+2 HP for Kong; +1 HP for anyone else.

Kong's item (Doctor)

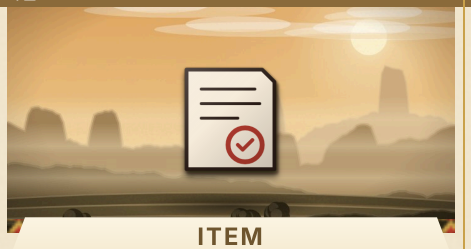
PACK

A sharp scalpel.

An army medic's kit dropped by the road.

THE TRAIL HIN HEUP BRIDGE · 2/18

SEARCH · HIN HE... CHAO FA



ITEM

Forged Travel Pass

Every Danger draw when the party moves is 2 better.

PACK

A stamped paper allowing travel to the river towns.

Passes were bought, forged or taken at checkpoints.

DISGUISE

THE TRAIL HIN HEUP BRIDGE · 3/18

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Lao Farm Village

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

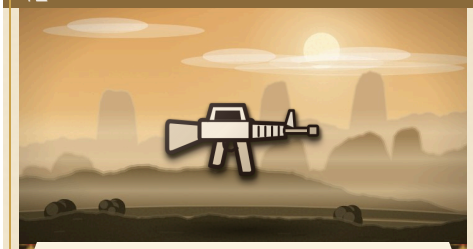
CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA



ITEM

Captured Rifle

A strong weapon: +3 ATK.

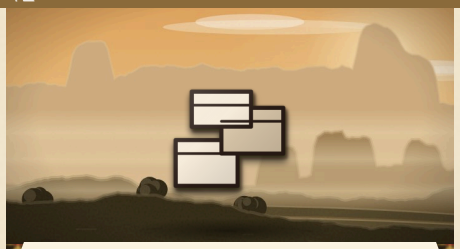
BOTH HANDS

A rifle taken from an army store.

Army posts along the roads kept weapons and ammunition.

LOUD

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA



SUPPLIES

Army Rations

Gain 3 Food when found. (Then discard it.)

SHARED BY THE PARTY

Tins of fish and bags of rice.

Supply trucks stopped at the checkpoint.

USED SIDE

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

ITEM

Army Body Armor

Armor 2 and +1 DEF. Also +1 DEF.

BODY

A heavy vest taken from an army store.

The checkpoint stores held gear for the soldiers on the road.

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

FOOD

A dropped sack of rice

+3 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Hin Heup Bridge.

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

FOOD

A dropped sack of rice

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Hin Heup Bridge.

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

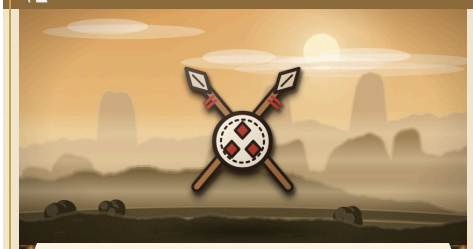
DANGER · HARD III

The checkpoint guards

Hard fight now. Win and search here 3 times in safety (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

The road to Vientiane and the bridge over the Nam Lik, with an army checkpoint at its end. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA



DANGER · HARD III

The checkpoint guards

Hard fight now. Win and search here 3 times in safety (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

The road to Vientiane and the bridge over the Nam Lik, with an army checkpoint at its end. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

CLUE

A Trail Map

Turn face up every tile in the next row.

A hand-drawn map of the paths to the river.

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

NOTHING

Too many soldiers

No effect. Discard this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

AMBUSH · HARD III

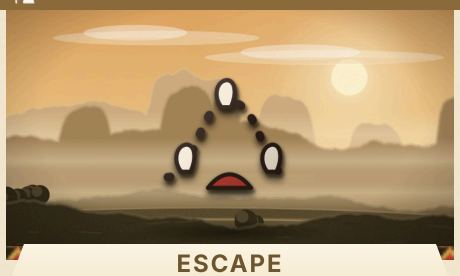
Shots from the ditch

Hard fight now. Ambush: the soldiers **fire first** (you deal nothing in clash 1).

The road to Vientiane and the bridge over the Nam Lik, with an army checkpoint at its end.

THE TRAIL HIN HEUP BRIDGE · 13/1

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA



ESCAPE

A Ditch by the Road

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Hin Heup Bridge.

THE TRAIL HIN HEUP BRIDGE · 14/1

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · GUARDED

A Patrol Timetable

Key encounter, **one step harder** than hard: fight for it (Lao Clothes or a Travel Pass: **no step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

Overheard at the checkpoint: when the trucks come and go. **To hear it you must get close to the checkpoint itself.**

THE TRAIL HIN HEUP BRIDGE · 15/1

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

A Guard Who Looks Away

Key encounter, **one step harder** than hard: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

One guard will let a family pass for a little silver. **Only for silver. If you will not pay, he calls the others.**

THE TRAIL HIN HEUP BRIDGE · 16/1

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · MINED

A Burned-Out Truck

Key encounter, **one step harder** than hard: take it; everyone draws a **Fortune card**, 1 to 4 = **2 wounds** (Dog: only 1). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

In the cab of a burned army truck, papers with the river posts marked. **The road shoulder around the truck is mined.**

THE TRAIL HIN HEUP BRIDGE · 17/1

SEARCH · HIN HE… CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

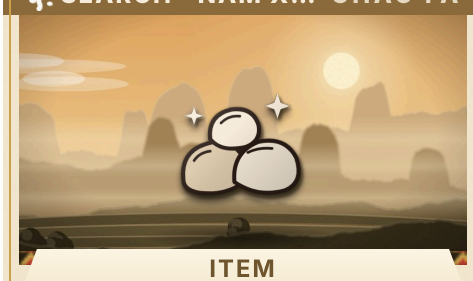
A Ride on a Logging Truck

Key encounter, **one step harder** than hard: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A driver will hide a family under the logs as far as the river road. **He wants silver first. Without it he drives on, and he has seen your faces.**

THE TRAIL HIN HEUP BRIDGE · 18/1

SEARCH · NAM X… CHAO FA



ITEM

Rocks

+2 HP for Gao; +1 HP for anyone else.

Gao's item (Kid)

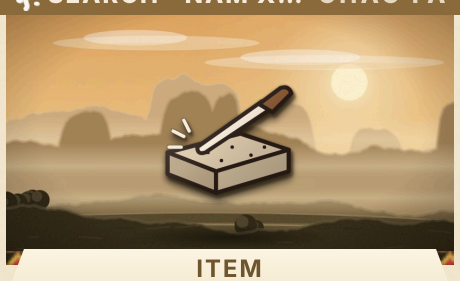
ONE HAND

A small shiny rock.

Smooth bright stones from the streambed.

THE TRAIL NAM XAN VALLEY · 1/15

SEARCH · NAM X… CHAO FA



ITEM

Sharpening Stone

+1 ATK, +1 DEF for Chong; +1 ATK for anyone else.

Chong's item (Blacksmith)

PACK

A sharpening stone used to retouch items.

The best whetstones are flat stones from a fast stream.

THE TRAIL NAM XAN VALLEY · 2/15

SEARCH · NAM X… CHAO FA

LEGENDARY ITEM

Fishing Pole

+1 ATK for anyone. Power: discard a card to gain 1 Food (1 action).

BOTH HANDS

A fishing pole used to catch fish.

A bamboo rod left by a fisherman.

THE TRAIL NAM XAN VALLEY · 3/15

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Hin Heup Bridge

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

ITEM

Cast Net

The holder finds 2 extra Food when they Forage.

PACK

A round weighted fishing net.

Lowland fishermen leave nets drying on the rocks.

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

ITEM

Clay Water Jar

The holder draws 1 better at the Toll. Also +1 HP.

PACK

A jar for carrying and boiling water.

Potters worked the clay banks of the streams.

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

FOOD

Fish and river crabs

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Nam Xan Valley.

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

FOOD

Fish and river crabs

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Nam Xan Valley.

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

DANGER · EASY I

A patrol at the ford

Easy fight now. Win and search here 1 time **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

A rocky stream running down into the Nam Xan, the river that meets the Mekong at Paksane. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

SHELTER

An overhanging rock

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 DEF in the **next fight**.

A safe place to make a stand.

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

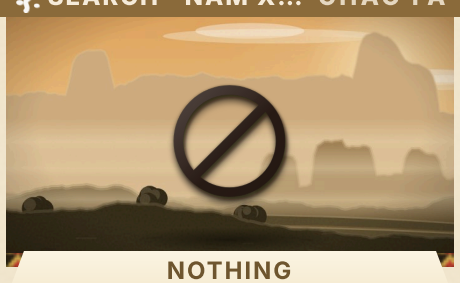
CLUE

A Trail Map

Turn face up every tile in the next row.

A hand-drawn map of the paths to the river.

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA



NOTHING

Empty water

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · WAIT FOR DARK

The Stream's Mouth

Key encounter, **one step harder** than easy: take it; everyone eats 1 Food, and on a **Fortune card** of 1 to 8 a patrol comes (**one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

Follow the water down and it meets the Mekong at a quiet bend. **The bend can only be reached at night, when the fishermen have gone home.**

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

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SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · ON THE FALLEN

Footprints in the Mud

Key encounter, **one step harder** than easy: take it, then his comrades ambush you at this place's level. Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

Other families came this way, and recently. **The trail ends at a soldier dead in the reeds. In his pack is a list of the fords, and his unit is looking for him.**

THE TRAIL NAM XAN VALLEY · 13/1

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · GUARDED

A Smugglers' Path

Key encounter, **one step harder** than easy: fight for it (Lao Clothes or a Travel Pass: **no step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

Salt and opium traders use a path through the reeds that the army does not know. **The traders guard their path, and they shoot first.**

THE TRAIL NAM XAN VALLEY · 14/1

SEARCH · NAM X... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

A Buffalo Boy's Shortcut

Key encounter, **one step harder** than easy: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A boy herding buffalo knows a dry way through the paddies to the river. **He wants rice for his family before he will show you.**

THE TRAIL NAM XAN VALLEY · 15/1

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA

ITEM

Truck Inner Tube

The holder draws 3 better crossing the river.

PACK

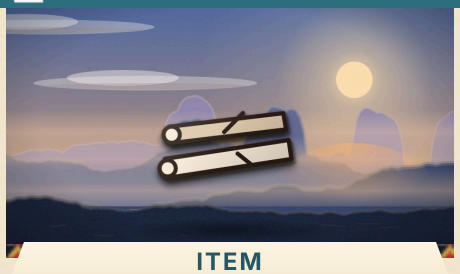
A patched rubber inner tube.

Inner tubes were the best floats a family could find.

FLOAT

THE TRAIL MEKONG REEDS · 1/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA



ITEM

Driftwood Logs

Lets the party build a raft without giving up 2 items.

SHARED BY THE PARTY

Logs washed up on the bank.

The Mekong leaves timber on every sandbar.

RAFT

THE TRAIL MEKONG REEDS · 2/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA

FOOD

Mussels and river weed

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Mekong Reeds.

THE TRAIL MEKONG REEDS · 3/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA

FOOD

Mussels and river weed

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Mekong Reeds.

THE TRAIL MEKONG REEDS · 4/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA

DANGER · MEDIUM II

A river patrol

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Reeds and mud flats on the Lao bank between Vientiane and Paksane, with Thailand across the water. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAIL MEKONG REEDS · 5/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA

REMEDY

Rest by the water

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest, medicine or care.

THE TRAIL MEKONG REEDS · 6/15

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Nam Xan Valley

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Mekong Reeds

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Mekong Reeds

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Mekong Reeds

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Mekong Reeds

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Mekong Reeds

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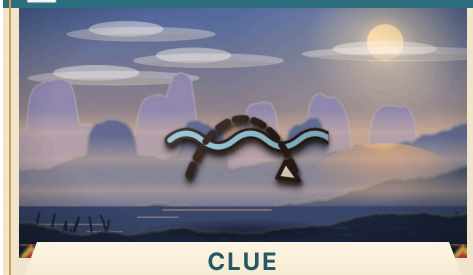
SEARCH · THE RIVER

Mekong Reeds

CHAO FA

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA



CLUE

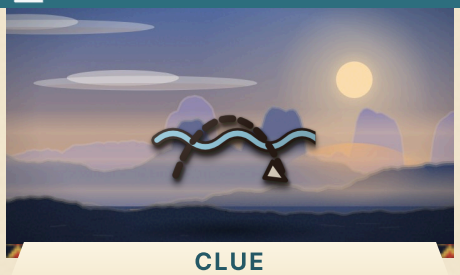
A Safe Crossing Place

Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, the current check is 3 better for everyone, and going down to the water 1 better.

A quiet stretch where the current is slower and the far bank is close.

THE TRAILMEKONG REEDS · 7/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA



CLUE

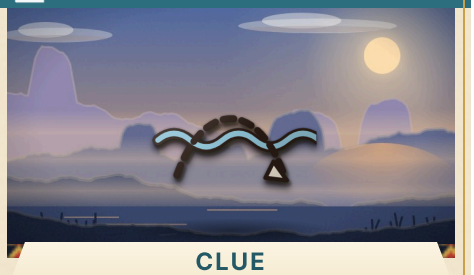
A Safe Crossing Place

Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, the current check is 3 better for everyone, and going down to the water 1 better.

A quiet stretch where the current is slower and the far bank is close.

THE TRAILMEKONG REEDS · 8/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA



CLUE

A Safe Crossing Place

Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, the current check is 3 better for everyone, and going down to the water 1 better.

A quiet stretch where the current is slower and the far bank is close.

THE TRAILMEKONG REEDS · 9/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA

NOTHING

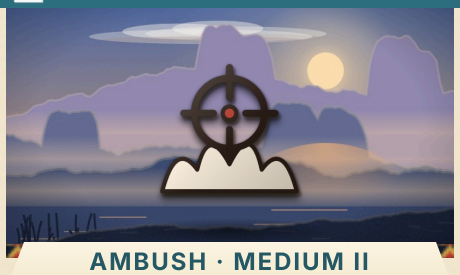
Mud and reeds

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAILMEKONG REEDS · 10/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA



AMBUSH · MEDIUM II

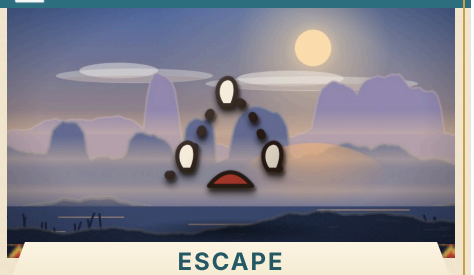
Rifles in the reeds

Medium fight now. Ambush: the soldiers **fire first** (you deal nothing in clash 1).

Reeds and mud flats on the Lao bank between Vientiane and Paksane, with Thailand across the water.

THE TRAILMEKONG REEDS · 11/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA



ESCAPE

Fog on the River

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Mekong Reeds.

THE TRAILMEKONG REEDS · 12/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · WAIT FOR DARK

Lights on the Thai Bank

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: take it; everyone eats 1 Food, and on a **Fortune card** of 1 to 8 a patrol comes (**one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

You can see the lamps of a Thai village. Now you know where to aim. **The lamps can only be seen after dark, from the open bank.**

THE TRAILMEKONG REEDS · 13/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · GUARDED

A Hidden Landing

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: fight for it (Lao Clothes or a Travel Pass: **no step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A gap in the reeds where rafts are put in at night. **A river patrol has found it and waits there.**

THE TRAILMEKONG REEDS · 14/15

SEARCH · MEKO... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

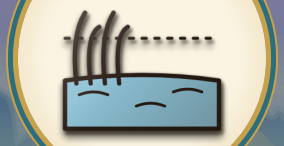
A Boatman's Son

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A boy who helps his father ferry families knows which night they go. **His father will want silver or baht for a place on the list.**

THE TRAILMEKONG REEDS · 15/15

SEARCH · THE RIVER



Mekong Reeds

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Mekong Reeds

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Mekong Reeds

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

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Mekong Reeds

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Mekong Reeds

CHAO FA

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA

ITEM

Thai Baht Notes

Pays one boat seat when you have found a Boatman.

PACK

Paper money from across the river.

Fishermen traded across the river and took baht for passage.

MONEY

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA

ITEM

Bamboo Fish Trap

The holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage.

PACK

A woven cone trap for fish.

Every fishing family has a few.

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA

FOOD

Dried fish

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Fishing Hamlet.

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA

FOOD

Dried fish

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Fishing Hamlet.

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA

DANGER · MEDIUM II

A fisherman turns you in

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

A few stilt houses of Lao fishermen with boats pulled up on the bank. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA

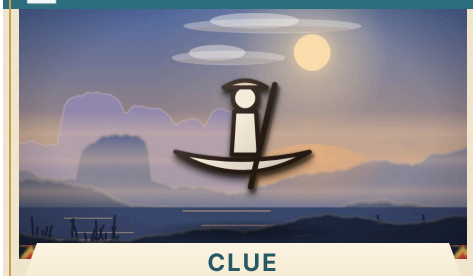
SHELTER

A friendly family hides you

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 DEF in the **next fight**.

A safe place to make a stand.

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA



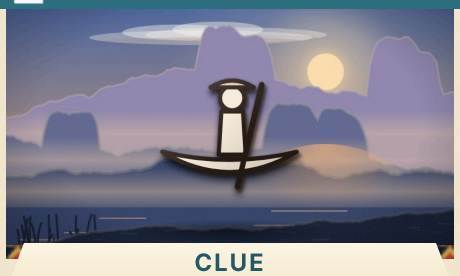
CLUE

A Boatman

Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, each silver item (Silver Bar, Ring, Soul Lock, French Silver Coins, Thai Baht) buys one boat seat.

A fisherman who will ferry people across at night for silver.

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA



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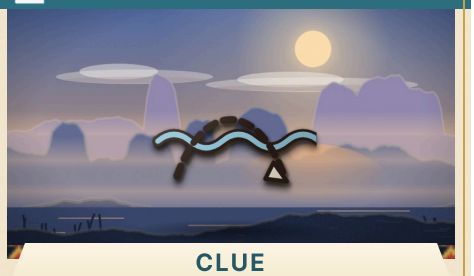

CLUE

A Safe Crossing Place

Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, the current check is 3 better for everyone, and going down to the water 1 better.

A quiet stretch where the current is slower and the far bank is close.

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Fishing Hamlet

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Fishing Hamlet

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Fishing Hamlet

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SEARCH · THE RIVER

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Fishing Hamlet

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SEARCH · THE RIVER

Fishing Hamlet

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Fishing Hamlet

CHAO FA

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA

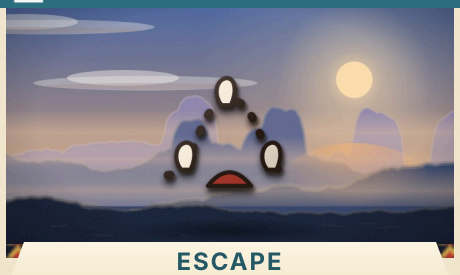
NOTHING
No one answers

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAIL FISHING HAMLET · 10/14

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA



ESCAPE
Under the Stilt Houses

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Fishing Hamlet.

THE TRAIL FISHING HAMLET · 11/14

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE
The Fisherman's Signal

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

Three flashes of a torch from the far bank mean it is safe. **The fisherman wants paying for the signal. If you will not pay, he may go to the soldiers.**

THE TRAIL FISHING HAMLET · 12/14

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · WAIT FOR DARK
A Night With No Moon

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: take it; everyone eats 1 Food, and on a **Fortune card** of 1 to 8 a patrol comes (**one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

An old woman tells you when the next dark night will be. **She tells you only after you have waited with her through the night.**

THE TRAIL FISHING HAMLET · 13/14

SEARCH · FISHIN... CHAO FA

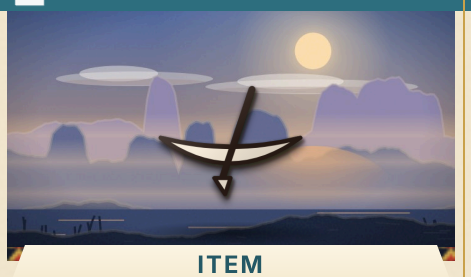
KEY ENCOUNTER · ON THE FALLEN
A Patrol Book in the Nets

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: take it, then his comrades ambush you at this place's level. Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A patrolman drowned in the nets. His book has the boat times. **His comrades are dragging the river for him.**

THE TRAIL FISHING HAMLET · 14/14

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA



ITEM
Dugout Canoe

Two people may cross by boat without paying a boatman.

SHARED BY THE PARTY

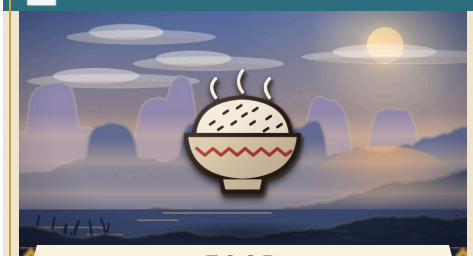
A narrow dugout canoe hidden in the reeds.

The ferrymen kept small boats near the old landing.

BOAT

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 1/12

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA



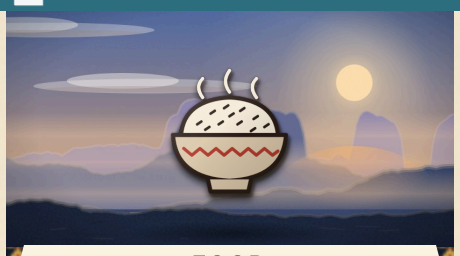
FOOD
Rice from an empty guardhouse

+3 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Tha Deua Ferry.

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 2/12

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA



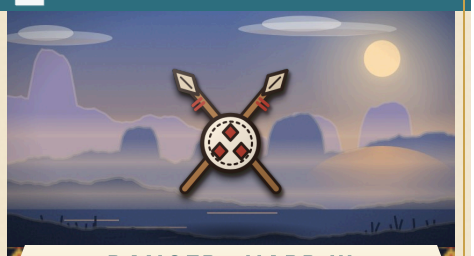
FOOD
Rice from an empty guardhouse

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Tha Deua Ferry.

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 3/12

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA



DANGER · HARD III
The guard post

Hard fight now. Win and search here 3 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

The old ferry landing below Vientiane, where the boats to Nong Khai crossed, now a guarded army post. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 4/12

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Fishing Hamlet

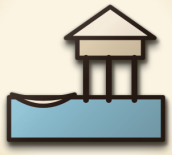
CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Fishing Hamlet

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER



Fishing Hamlet

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Fishing Hamlet

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Fishing Hamlet

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA

DANGER · HARD III

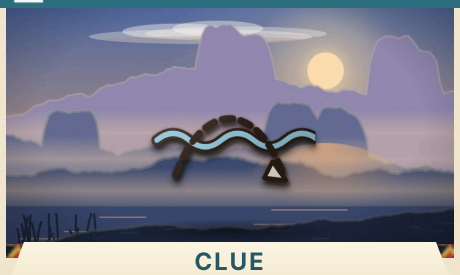
The guard post

Hard fight now. Win and search here 3 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

The old ferry landing below Vientiane, where the boats to Nong Khai crossed, now a guarded army post. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 5/12

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA



CLUE

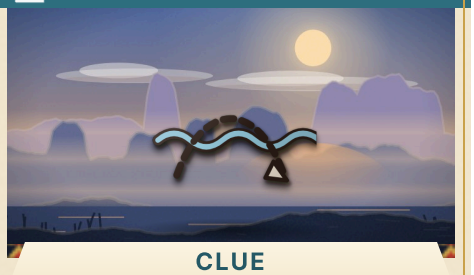
A Safe Crossing Place

Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, the current check is 3 better for everyone, and going down to the water 1 better.

A quiet stretch where the current is slower and the far bank is close.

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 6/12

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA



CLUE

A Safe Crossing Place

Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, the current check is 3 better for everyone, and going down to the water 1 better.

A quiet stretch where the current is slower and the far bank is close.

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 7/12

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA

CLUE

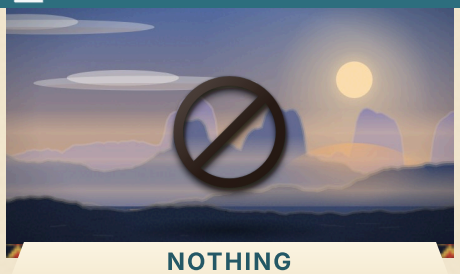
A Boatman

Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, each silver item (Silver Bar, Ring, Soul Lock, French Silver Coins, Thai Baht) buys one boat seat.

A fisherman who will ferry people across at night for silver.

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 8/12

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA



NOTHING

Searchlights

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 9/12

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · GUARDED

The Guard Change

Key encounter, **one step harder** than hard: fight for it (Lao Clothes or a Travel Pass: **no step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

For a few minutes after midnight, no one watches the landing. **You must get past the outer guards to see it.**

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 10/12

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · WAIT FOR DARK

The Ferryman's Hut

Key encounter, **one step harder** than hard: take it; everyone eats 1 Food, and on a **Fortune card** of 1 to 8 a patrol comes (**one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

An old ferryman who lost his boat knows every sandbar between here and Thailand. **He comes back to his hut only at night, past the guard post.**

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 11/12

SEARCH · THA D... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · MINED

A Boat Left Untied

Key encounter, **one step harder** than hard: take it; everyone draws a **Fortune card**, 1 to 4 = **2 wounds** (Dog: only 1). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A small boat at the end of the old pier, if you can reach it. **The path to the pier is mined and lit.**

THE TRAIL THA DEUA FERRY · 12/12

SEARCH · PLAIN ... CHAO FA

ITEM

Bomb Casing Pot

+1 Food whenever the party forages.

PACK

Half a cluster-bomb casing, blackened by cooking fires.

Families on the plain cooked in the halves of the bomb casings that lay everywhere.

THE TRAIL PLAIN OF JARS · 1/13

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE RIVER

Tha Deua Ferry

CHAO FA

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA

ITEM

Drop Tarpaulin

The Winter Toll is 1 better for everyone.

PACK

A rotted supply-drop tarpaulin, still waterproof.

Rice drops came wrapped in tarpaulin. A sheet of it keeps the rain off a shelter.

THE TRAIL PLAIN OF JARS · 2/13

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA

ITEM

Entrenching Tool

+1 ATK, +1 DEF for anyone.

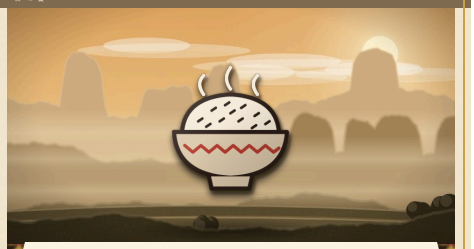
ONE HAND

A folding army shovel.

Dropped by a soldier on the plain. It digs a firing position or a grave.

THE TRAIL PLAIN OF JARS · 3/13

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA



FOOD

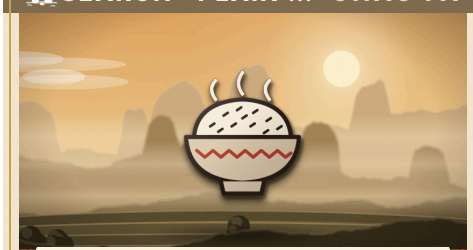
Rice from an abandoned paddy

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Plain of Jars.

THE TRAIL PLAIN OF JARS · 4/13

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA



FOOD

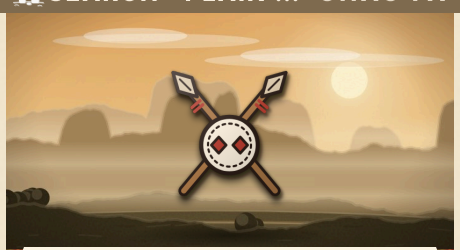
Frogs from the craters

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Plain of Jars.

THE TRAIL PLAIN OF JARS · 5/13

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA



DANGER · MEDIUM II

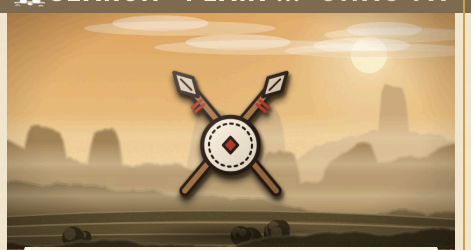
A patrol on the open plain

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Open grassland around the great stone jars, cratered and littered with old bombs. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAIL PLAIN OF JARS · 6/13

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA



DANGER · EASY I

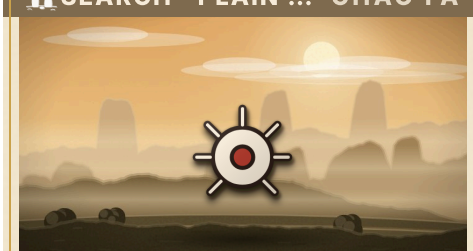
Militia at the jars

Easy fight now. Win and search here 1 time **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Open grassland around the great stone jars, cratered and littered with old bombs. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAIL PLAIN OF JARS · 7/13

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA



OLD BOMBS

Bomblets in the grass

Everyone draws a **Fortune card**: on 1 or 2, an old bomb, **2 wounds**. The Dog: only on a 1. Then discard this card.

Open grassland around the great stone jars, cratered and littered with old bombs.

THE TRAIL PLAIN OF JARS · 8/13

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA

OLD BOMBS

A crater field

Everyone draws a **Fortune card**: on 1 or 2, an old bomb, **2 wounds**. The Dog: only on a 1. Then discard this card.

Open grassland around the great stone jars, cratered and littered with old bombs.

THE TRAIL PLAIN OF JARS · 9/13

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA

SHELTER

A crater to lie in

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +1 DEF in the **next fight**.

A safe place to make a stand.

THE TRAILPLAIN OF JARS · 10/13

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA

NOTHING

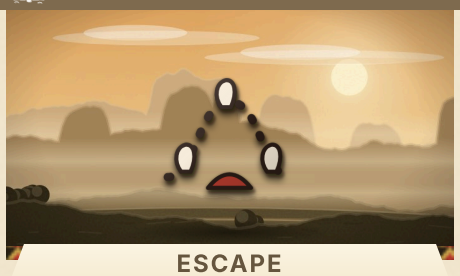
Only the jars

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAILPLAIN OF JARS · 11/13

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA



ESCAPE

Across the Plain by Night

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Plain of Jars.

THE TRAILPLAIN OF JARS · 12/13

SEARCH · PLAIN … CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

The Road Watcher's Word

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

An old man who watches the road knows which trucks carry soldiers. **He wants rice for his word.**

THE TRAILPLAIN OF JARS · 13/13

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

ITEM

Pahawh Primer

+1 DEF for anyone.

PACK

A hand-copied primer in the Pahawh script.

The Chao Fa taught the script of Shong Lue Yang in their camps. The book is their mark and their memory.

CHAO FA

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 1/14

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

ITEM

Field Dressing

Counts as medicine for nursing. Turn it face down when used.

PACK

A sealed army field dressing.

Carried by every fighter on the mountain. Counts as medicine for nursing.

USED SIDE

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 2/14

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

ITEM

Soldier's Map

Searching: look at one card more and choose.

PACK

A map case with a marked sheet of the Phou Bia massif.

The mountain fighters marked the paths and the hiding places. Searches here look one card deeper.

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 3/14

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

FOOD

A hidden camp's rice

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Phou Bia Slopes.

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 4/14

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

FOOD

Mountain roots

+1 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Phou Bia Slopes.

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 5/14

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

DANGER · HARD III

Soldiers climbing the mountain

Hard fight now. Win and search here 3 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

The high slopes of the biggest mountain in Laos, cold, steep and full of hiding families. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 6/14

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE HILLS

Plain of Jars

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

DANGER · MEDIUM II

A patrol on the ridge path

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times **in safety** (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

The high slopes of the biggest mountain in Laos, cold, steep and full of hiding families. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 7/14

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

THE CHAO FA

The Chao Fa Take You In

A band of resistance fighters shares their fire and their rifles for a while. Your next 3 fights: the party has +3 ATK. Keep it face up and turn it after the third fight.

The high slopes of the biggest mountain in Laos, cold, steep and full of hiding families.

CHAO FA

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 8/14

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

CLUE

A Guide

Keep this card. Every Danger draw when the party moves is 3 better.

A Lao farmer, or a Hmong man who knows the trails, offers to lead you.

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 9/14

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

REMEDY

A night in a Chao Fa camp

Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest, medicine or care.

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 10/1

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

NOTHING

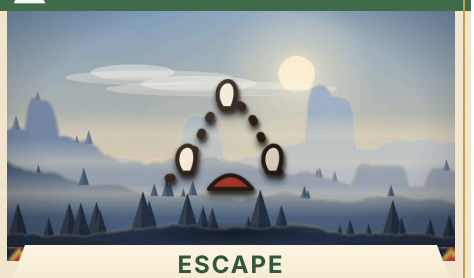
Cold, and nothing to eat

No effect. **Discard** this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 11/1

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA



ESCAPE

Cloud on the Mountain

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Phou Bia Slopes.

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 12/1

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · GUARDED

The Fighters' Trail

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: fight for it (Lao Clothes or a Travel Pass: **no step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

The Chao Fa know the way down to the river, and who is watching it. **Their camp is watched from below.**

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 13/1

SEARCH · PHOU … CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · ON THE FALLEN

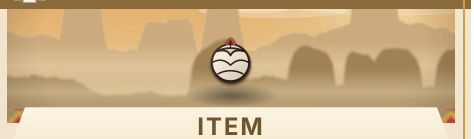
A Fighter's Last Word

Key encounter, **one step harder** than medium: take it, then his comrades ambush you at this place's level. Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A dying fighter names the crossing his family used. **He fell on the path, and the soldiers who shot him are close.**

THE TRAILPHOU BIA SLOPES · 14/1

SEARCH · VIENTI… CHAO FA



ITEM

Ball of Opium

Money: pays a Boatman, a Price, a Trade or a shakedown. Or spend it: a **Sick** villager is not **Sick** for one Winter Toll.

PACK

A fist of raw opium wrapped in leaves.

The cash crop of the mountains and the medicine chest of the sick. Money: it pays a Boatman, a Price or a Trade. Or spend it so a Sick villager is not Sick for one Winter Toll (it eases, it does not cure).

MONEY

THE TRAILVIENTIANE PLAIN · 1/14

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

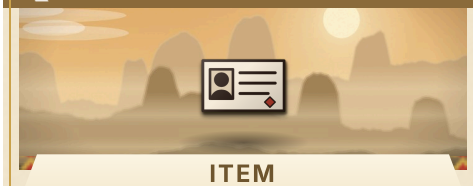
CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE JUNGLE

Phou Bia Slopes

CHAO FA

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA



ITEM

Lao Identity Card

Danger 1 better when you Travel. A disguise piece: with two in the party, no one looks twice.

PACK

A lowland Lao identity card with a stranger's photograph.

On the plain everyone is asked for papers. A card, even a stranger's, gets the party past a glance.

DISGUISE

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA

ITEM

Kerosene Lamp

Searching: look at one card more and choose.

PACK

A tin lamp with a little kerosene left.

Light to search by, if you dare to show one.

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA

FOOD

The market at dawn

+3 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Vientiane Plain.

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA

FOOD

Paddy rice and fish sauce

+2 Food now. Then discard this card.

Something to eat in the Vientiane Plain.

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA

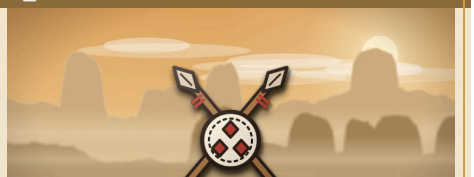
DANGER · HARD III

A checkpoint on the road

Hard fight now. Win and search here 3 times in safety (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Rice paddies, market towns and the road into the capital, a day from the river. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA



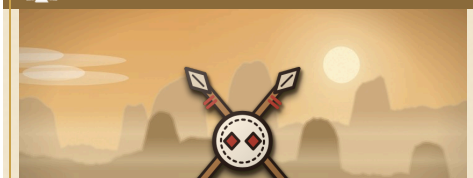
DANGER · HARD III

Soldiers searching a bus

Hard fight now. Win and search here 3 times in safety (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Rice paddies, market towns and the road into the capital, a day from the river. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA



DANGER · MEDIUM II

Militia in the paddies

Medium fight now. Win and search here 2 times in safety (skip Danger and Nothing cards).

Rice paddies, market towns and the road into the capital, a day from the river. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA

CLUE

A Trail Map

Turn face up every tile in the next row.

A hand-drawn map of the paths to the river.

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA

NOTHING

Too many eyes

No effect. Discard this card. The deck gets thinner as you search.

Nothing useful this time.

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

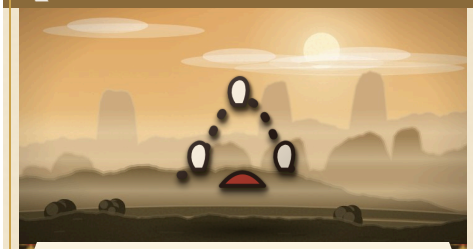
CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA



ESCAPE

A Monk's Blessing

Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: the party slips away, **no fight**.

A way past the soldiers in the Vientiane Plain.

THE TRAIL VIENTIANE PLAIN · 11/1

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

A Trader's Route

Key encounter, **one step harder** than hard: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A market trader runs goods to the river and knows the quiet landings. **He sells to anyone, including the police.**

THE TRAIL VIENTIANE PLAIN · 12/1

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · A PRICE

Papers for the Ferry

Key encounter, **one step harder** than hard: pay silver, baht, coins or 2 Food, or take it by force (a fight **one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A clerk sells the stamp that gets a family onto the ferry. **The stamp costs more than you have.**

THE TRAIL VIENTIANE PLAIN · 13/1

SEARCH · VIENTI... CHAO FA

KEY ENCOUNTER · WAIT FOR DARK

The Night Bus Driver

Key encounter, **one step harder** than hard: take it; everyone eats 1 Food, and on a **Fortune card** of 1 to 8 a patrol comes (**one step up**). Or leave it at the bottom of this deck. Win it: recover the next missing square.

A driver who takes people to the river town after dark. **He only drives when the road is empty.**

THE TRAIL VIENTIANE PLAIN · 14/1

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · EASY

A patrol finds you

Easy fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 1 time **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 1/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · EASY

A patrol finds you

Easy fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 1 time **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 2/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · EASY

A patrol finds you

Easy fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 1 time **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 3/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · EASY

A patrol finds you

Easy fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 1 time **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 4/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · EASY

A patrol finds you

Easy fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 1 time **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 5/85

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

SEARCH · THE LOWLANDS

Vientiane Plain

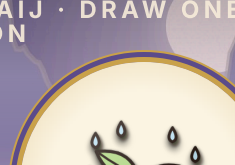
CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON



Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · MEDIUM

A patrol finds you

Medium fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 2 times **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 6/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · MEDIUM

A patrol finds you

Medium fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 2 times **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 7/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · MEDIUM

A patrol finds you

Medium fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 2 times **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 8/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · MEDIUM

A patrol finds you

Medium fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 2 times **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 9/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · MEDIUM

A patrol finds you

Medium fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 2 times **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 10/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · HARD

A patrol finds you

Hard fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 3 times **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 11/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · HARD

A patrol finds you

Hard fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 3 times **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 12/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · HARD

A patrol finds you

Hard fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 3 times **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 13/85

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA

PATROL · HARD

A patrol finds you

Hard fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 3 times **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 14/85

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

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LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

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LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

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Season

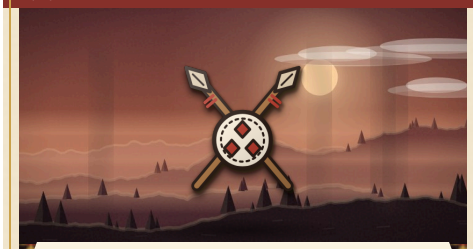
CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

SEASON · PATROL CHAO FA



PATROL · HARD

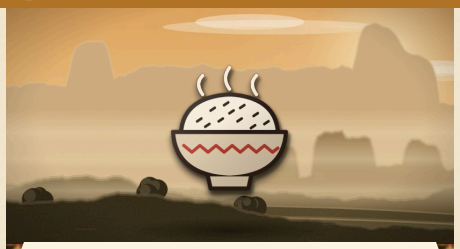
A patrol finds you

Hard fight now, wherever the party is. Win and search the place 3 times **in safety**.

Soldiers or militia sweep the area where you are.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 15/85

SEASON · FOOD CHAO FA



FOOD

Food +3

+3 Food now (**max 20**).

Friends, luck or a good harvest.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 16/85

SEASON · FOOD CHAO FA

FOOD

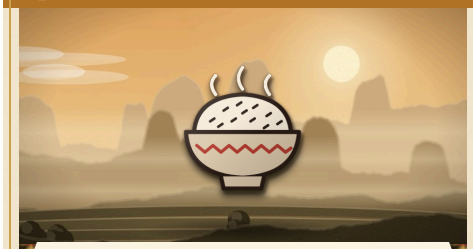
Food +3

+3 Food now (**max 20**).

Friends, luck or a good harvest.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 17/85

SEASON · FOOD CHAO FA



FOOD

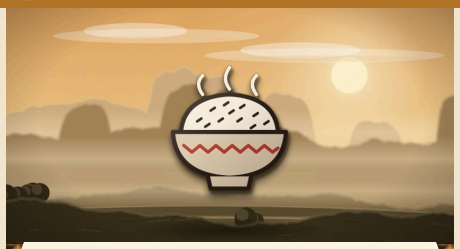
Food +2

+2 Food now (**max 20**).

Friends, luck or a good harvest.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 18/85

SEASON · FOOD CHAO FA



FOOD

Food +2

+2 Food now (**max 20**).

Friends, luck or a good harvest.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 19/85

SEASON · FOOD CHAO FA

FOOD

Food +2

+2 Food now (**max 20**).

Friends, luck or a good harvest.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 20/85

SEASON · FOOD CHAO FA

FOOD

Food +1

+1 Food now (**max 20**).

Friends, luck or a good harvest.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 21/85

SEASON · FOOD CHAO FA

FOOD

Food +1

+1 Food now (**max 20**).

Friends, luck or a good harvest.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 22/85

SEASON · FOOD CHAO FA

FOOD

Food +1

+1 Food now (**max 20**).

Friends, luck or a good harvest.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 23/85

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

SEASON · FOOD CHAO FA

FOOD
Food +1

+1 Food now (**max 20**).

Friends, luck or a good harvest.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 24/85

SEASON · FOOD CHAO FA

FOOD
Food +1

+1 Food now (**max 20**).

Friends, luck or a good harvest.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 25/85

SEASON · SHELTER CHAO FA

SHELTER
DEF +3

Goes to a player's hand. Play it (1 action) for +3 DEF in the **next fight**.

A place to hide for a while.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 26/85

SEASON · SHELTER CHAO FA

SHELTER
DEF +2

Goes to a player's hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 DEF in the **next fight**.

A place to hide for a while.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 27/85

SEASON · SHELTER CHAO FA

SHELTER
DEF +2

Goes to a player's hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 DEF in the **next fight**.

A place to hide for a while.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 28/85

SEASON · SHELTER CHAO FA

SHELTER
DEF +1

Goes to a player's hand. Play it (1 action) for +1 DEF in the **next fight**.

A place to hide for a while.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 29/85

SEASON · SHELTER CHAO FA

SHELTER
DEF +1

Goes to a player's hand. Play it (1 action) for +1 DEF in the **next fight**.

A place to hide for a while.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 30/85

SEASON · REMEDY CHAO FA

REMEDY
HP +3

Goes to a player's hand. Play it (1 action) for +3 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest and care.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 31/85

SEASON · REMEDY CHAO FA

REMEDY
HP +2

Goes to a player's hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest and care.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 32/85

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

SEASON · REMEDY CHAO FA

REMEDY
HP +2

Goes to a player's hand. Play it (1 action) for +2 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest and care.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 33/85

SEASON · REMEDY CHAO FA

REMEDY
HP +1

Goes to a player's hand. Play it (1 action) for +1 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest and care.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 34/85

SEASON · REMEDY CHAO FA

REMEDY
HP +1

Goes to a player's hand. Play it (1 action) for +1 HP in the **next fight**.

Rest and care.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 35/85

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME
The Army Advances

The season is lost: move the time marker forward 1 season. In Winter, the party hides instead (as A Sweep Through the Hills).

The war moves faster than you. The army takes the next valley.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 36/85

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME
The Army Advances

The season is lost: move the time marker forward 1 season. In Winter, the party hides instead (as A Sweep Through the Hills).

The war moves faster than you. The army takes the next valley.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 37/85

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME
The Army Advances

The season is lost: move the time marker forward 1 season. In Winter, the party hides instead (as A Sweep Through the Hills).

The war moves faster than you. The army takes the next valley.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 38/85

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME
The Army Advances

The season is lost: move the time marker forward 1 season. In Winter, the party hides instead (as A Sweep Through the Hills).

The war moves faster than you. The army takes the next valley.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 39/85

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME
The Army Advances

The season is lost: move the time marker forward 1 season. In Winter, the party hides instead (as A Sweep Through the Hills).

The war moves faster than you. The army takes the next valley.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 40/85

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME
A Sweep Through the Hills

This season everyone has 1 action and the party cannot Travel.

Soldiers comb the ridges. The family lies still under the leaves.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 41/85

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

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LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

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LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

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LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME

A Sweep Through the Hills

This season everyone has 1 action and the party cannot Travel.

Soldiers comb the ridges. The family lies still under the leaves.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 42/85

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME

A Sweep Through the Hills

This season everyone has 1 action and the party cannot Travel.

Soldiers comb the ridges. The family lies still under the leaves.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 43/85

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME

A Quiet Spell

This season Travel is safe (no Danger draw) and no one is spotted while foraging.

The soldiers are busy elsewhere.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 44/85

SEASON · HISTO... CHAO FA

HISTORY

Yellow Rain

Each person draws a **Fortune card**: on 4 or less they fall **Sick** (if already **Sick**, they take **a wound**).

Aircraft pass low over the ridge. Refugees later told of a yellow substance falling, and of sickness and deaths after. What it was is still disputed.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 45/85

SEASON · HISTO... CHAO FA

HISTORY

The Offensive on Phou Bia

The party loses **half its Food** (rounded up), and a **Medium patrol** finds you.

Lao and Vietnamese troops sweep the mountains where the resistance holds out. Villages and rice fields are burned.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 46/85

SEASON · HISTO... CHAO FA

HISTORY

A Voice on the Radio

Lose 1 Hope. Then, if Hope is 2 or less, the most hurt villager goes down to **surrender** and leaves the party.

A radio voice speaking Hmong promises rice, land and forgiveness to anyone who comes down from the mountains. Some did. Many officers who went down were sent to camps and never came back.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 47/85

SEASON · HISTO... CHAO FA

HISTORY

A Voice on the Radio

Lose 1 Hope. Then, if Hope is 2 or less, the most hurt villager goes down to **surrender** and leaves the party.

A radio voice speaking Hmong promises rice, land and forgiveness to anyone who comes down from the mountains. Some did. Many officers who went down were sent to camps and never came back.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 48/85

SEASON · HISTO... CHAO FA

HISTORY

Betrayed

A **Medium patrol** finds you. If you have a Guide, the Guide was the traitor: lose the Guide card, and the patrol is Hard.

Someone has told the soldiers where you sleep. Hmong fought on both sides of this war, and some guided the soldiers who hunted their own people.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 49/85

SEASON · HISTO... CHAO FA

HISTORY

Betrayed

A **Medium patrol** finds you. If you have a Guide, the Guide was the traitor: lose the Guide card, and the patrol is Hard.

Someone has told the soldiers where you sleep. Hmong fought on both sides of this war, and some guided the soldiers who hunted their own people.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 50/85

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

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L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

SEASON · HISTO… CHAO FA

HISTORY

Bombs in the Grass

Each person draws a **Fortune card**: on 2 or less they step on one and take **2 wounds**.

The path crosses ground bombed in the war. Small round bomblets lie in the grass and mud, and nearly one in three never went off.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 51/85

SEASON · HISTO… CHAO FA

HISTORY

Bombs in the Grass

Each person draws a **Fortune card**: on 2 or less they step on one and take **2 wounds**.

The path crosses ground bombed in the war. Small round bomblets lie in the grass and mud, and nearly one in three never went off.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 52/85

SEASON · DILEM… CHAO FA

DILEMMA

A Wounded Soldier

A wounded man from the resistance crawls into your camp and asks to come with you.

Take him in. Share your food. He knows where a cache is hidden, but the soldiers hunting him may follow.

−3 Food, +1 Hope, 1 safe search, Fortune card of 10 or less: easy fight

Leave him. You cannot feed another mouth, and soldiers may be tracking him.

−1 Hope

THE TRAIL SEASON · 53/85

SEASON · DILEM… CHAO FA

DILEMMA

A Lao Family's Granary

A lowland family has a full rice granary. Your children are hungry.

Take rice at night. Fill your baskets and hope no one wakes.

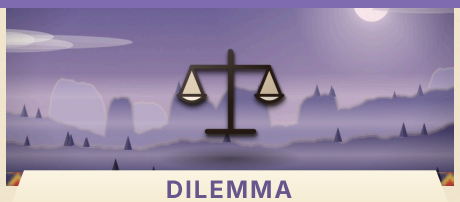
+3 Food, −1 Hope, Fortune card of 10 or less: easy fight

Ask to trade. Offer something you carry. They give what they can spare.

+2 Food, give up an item

THE TRAIL SEASON · 54/85

SEASON · DILEM… CHAO FA



DILEMMA

Another Family

A mother and two children beg to travel with you. They have nothing.

Welcome them. They share your fire and your rice until they find their own people.

−3 Food, +2 Hope

Turn them away. Every mouth slows the party.

−2 Hope

THE TRAIL SEASON · 55/85

SEASON · DILEM… CHAO FA

DILEMMA

Fever in the Night

A child is burning with fever. Your medicine is almost gone.

Use the medicine. Give up a healing item, if you have one, to bring the fever down.

+1 Hope, give up an item, a sick or wounded person recovers

Call the spirits and wait. The shaman sits with the child through the night. The fever breaks at dawn, but the child is weak.

+1 Hope, someone takes 1 wound

THE TRAIL SEASON · 56/85

SEASON · DILEM… CHAO FA

DILEMMA

An Abandoned Harvest

A field of ripe rice, its owners gone. Soldiers patrol the valley by day.

Harvest by day. Take as much as you can carry.

+4 Food, Fortune card of 10 or less: hard fight

Glean at night. Take only what you can find in the dark.

+2 Food

THE TRAIL SEASON · 57/85

SEASON · DILEM… CHAO FA

DILEMMA

Hmong New Year

It is the New Year (Noj Peb Caug). In the village there would be feasting, ball games and new clothes.

Celebrate quietly. Cook a little extra and tell the old stories.

−2 Food, +2 Hope

Let it pass. There is no food to spare. You promise to celebrate on the other side.

no effect

THE TRAIL SEASON · 58/85

SEASON · DILEM… CHAO FA

DILEMMA

Rumours of the Trail

A traveller says the way ahead is watched. Someone could go ahead alone to look.

Send a scout. The scout comes back hurt but knows the way.

someone takes 1 wound, turn up the next row

Go on blind. Trust the trail.

no effect

THE TRAIL SEASON · 59/85

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

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Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

L JB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

SEASON · DILEM... CHAO FA

UNTIL SUMMER 1975

DILEMMA

The March to Vientiane

Spring 1975. Thousands of Hmong are walking toward Vientiane, hoping to reach the Mekong together. Ahead, at the Hin Heup bridge, soldiers wait.

Walk with the crowd. There is safety in numbers, until the shooting starts.

+1 Hope, turn up the next row, Fortune card of 10 or less: hard fight

Keep to the forest. Turn back into the hills, alone.

−1 Hope

THE TRAIL SEASON · 60/85

SEASON · DILEM... CHAO FA

DILEMMA

A Crying Child

Soldiers are on the path below and a child will not stop crying. Many parents gave babies opium so their crying would not give the family away; some children died of it.

Quiet the child with opium. The crying stops. The child sleeps too long and wakes weak.

someone takes 1 wound

Hold the child and run. Carry the child and break for cover before the soldiers come.

−1 Hope, Fortune card of 10 or less: medium fight

THE TRAIL SEASON · 61/85

SEASON · DILEM... CHAO FA

DILEMMA

The Rooster Will Crow

The family must move tonight. A rooster crows at dawn and a dog barks at strangers. One boy had to leave his pet rooster behind for this reason.

Leave the animals behind. Let them go in the forest. The children cry quietly.

−1 Hope, lose your animals

Keep them close. Hold the beaks and muzzles and hope.

Fortune card of 10 or less: medium fight

THE TRAIL SEASON · 62/85

SEASON · DILEM... CHAO FA

FROM FALL 1975

DILEMMA

The Chao Fa

Armed men with long hair stop you on the ridge: a Chao Fa band. They offer to let your family hide with them, but the army hunts them hardest.

Hide with them a while. They share what they know of the forest. Then the soldiers come.

−2 Food, +1 Hope, 1 safe search, Fortune card of 10 or less: hard fight

Keep to your own way. Thank them and walk on alone.

no effect

THE TRAIL SEASON · 63/85

SEASON · DILEM... CHAO FA

DILEMMA

Leaflets of Amnesty

Planes drop leaflets: those who come down from the mountains will be forgiven. Many who went were sent to re-education camps.

Stay hidden. Tear up the leaflets and keep going.

−1 Hope

Argue about it all night. The family is divided and no one sleeps.

+1 Food, −2 Hope

THE TRAIL SEASON · 64/85

SEASON · AMBUSH CHAO FA

AMBUSH

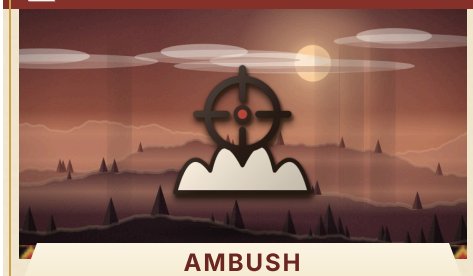
Ambush on the Trail

A **Medium fight**: the soldiers **fire first** (you deal nothing in the first clash).

Shots from above the path. The soldiers were waiting.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 65/85

SEASON · AMBUSH CHAO FA



AMBUSH

Ambush on the Trail

A **Medium fight**: the soldiers **fire first** (you deal nothing in the first clash).

Shots from above the path. The soldiers were waiting.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 66/85

SEASON · AMBUSH CHAO FA

AMBUSH

Ambush on the Trail

A **Medium fight**: the soldiers **fire first** (you deal nothing in the first clash).

Shots from above the path. The soldiers were waiting.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 67/85

SEASON · FOG CHAO FA

FOG

Fog in the Valley

Gain a Fog card: discard it to avoid one fight (not the River Patrol).

A thick fog fills the valley for days.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 68/85

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

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LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

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LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

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LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

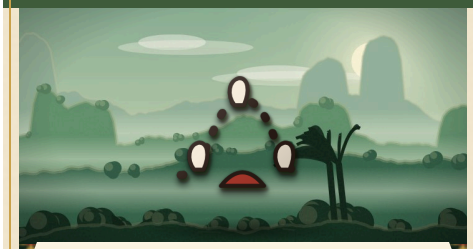
CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

SEASON · FOG CHAO FA



FOG

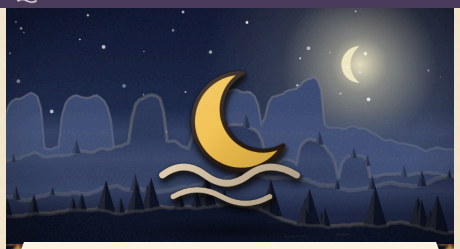
Fog in the Valley

Gain a Fog card: discard it to avoid one fight (not the River Patrol).

A thick fog fills the valley for days.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 69/85

SEASON · OMEN CHAO FA



OMEN

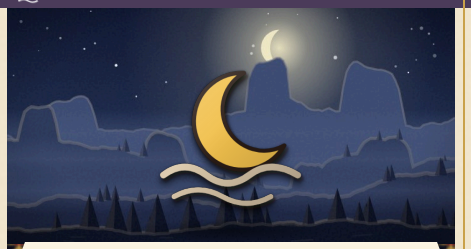
Smoke on the Far Ridge

Keep it face up. Draw a **Fortune card**: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

A village is burning across the valley. Is it yours?

THE TRAIL SEASON · 70/85

SEASON · OMEN CHAO FA



OMEN

Smoke on the Far Ridge

Keep it face up. Draw a **Fortune card**: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

A village is burning across the valley. Is it yours?

THE TRAIL SEASON · 71/85

SEASON · OMEN CHAO FA

OMEN

Dogs Bark All Night

Keep it face up. Draw a **Fortune card**: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

Somewhere below, the dogs will not settle.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 72/85

SEASON · OMEN CHAO FA

OMEN

Dogs Bark All Night

Keep it face up. Draw a **Fortune card**: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

Somewhere below, the dogs will not settle.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 73/85

SEASON · OMEN CHAO FA

OMEN

A Spotter Plane

Keep it face up. Draw a **Fortune card**: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

A small plane circles twice and goes away.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 74/85

SEASON · OMEN CHAO FA

OMEN

A Spotter Plane

Keep it face up. Draw a **Fortune card**: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

A small plane circles twice and goes away.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 75/85

SEASON · OMEN CHAO FA

OMEN

The Grandmother's Dream

Keep it face up. Draw a **Fortune card**: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

She dreamed of a river and a white horse. No one sleeps after that.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 76/85

SEASON · OMEN CHAO FA

OMEN

The Grandmother's Dream

Keep it face up. Draw a **Fortune card**: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

She dreamed of a river and a white horse. No one sleeps after that.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 77/85

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LJB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

SEASON · OMEN CHAO FA

OMEN

Footprints That Are Not Ours

Keep it face up. Draw a **Fortune card**: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

Someone else walked this path in the night.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 78/85

SEASON · OMEN CHAO FA

OMEN

Footprints That Are Not Ours

Keep it face up. Draw a **Fortune card**: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

Someone else walked this path in the night.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 79/85

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME

The Burning Season

This season every Danger draw when the party Travels is 2 better, and no one can Forage (Spring only).

Smoke from the swidden fires hangs over every valley. Nothing can be seen from far, and nothing grows in the ash.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 80/85

SEASON · TIME CHAO FA

TIME

The Burning Season

This season every Danger draw when the party Travels is 2 better, and no one can Forage (Spring only).

Smoke from the swidden fires hangs over every valley. Nothing can be seen from far, and nothing grows in the ash.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 81/85

SEASON · HISTO... CHAO FA

HISTORY

A Child Is Born

Hope +1. One adult goes **Hungry** this Winter. The baby is not a villager and cannot be lost.

A baby is born on the trail, in a shelter of leaves, and lives.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 82/85

SEASON · HISTO... CHAO FA

HISTORY

A Letter from America

Hope +1, and turn face up every place in the river row.

A letter, passed from hand to hand for months, from a relative already resettled. The river is the way.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 83/85

SEASON · HISTO... CHAO FA

HISTORY

The Writing of the Chao Fa

If the party holds the Book or the Pahawh Primer: **Hope +1** and one safe search here. Otherwise nothing.

A fighter shows you the script of Shong Lue Yang, the Mother of Writing, which the Chao Fa carry as their own.

THE TRAIL SEASON · 84/85

SEASON · DILEM... CHAO FA

DILEMMA

The Elder's Choice

The oldest of you, hungry and slow, asks to stay behind at this place so the young can move faster.

Stay together. No one is left. Every Danger draw is 1 worse until the next Winter.

no effect

Let him stay. He keeps a little rice and the fire. He is still in Laos. No Hope is lost, and his things pass to the party.

no effect

THE TRAIL SEASON · 85/85

STRANGER · SEE... CHAO FA

STRANGER

A Lao Trader

A trader with a pole and two baskets stops to rest. He looks at what you carry.

Trade with him. Give up an item for rice and salt.

+4 Food, give up an item

Let him go. He might talk.

no effect

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 1/13

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

LUB CAIJ · DRAW ONE EACH SEASON

Season

CHAO FA

STRANGER · SEE... CHAO FA

STRANGER

A Widow and Her Son

A Hmong widow and her small son have been hiding alone since the spring (Lee clan).

Take them with you. More mouths, but she knows the forest paths.

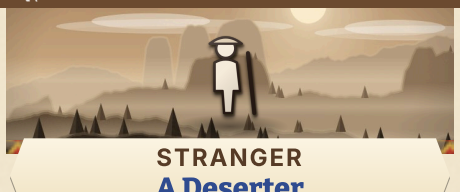
−3 Food, +1 Hope, turn up the next row

Give them what you can spare. A little rice and directions.

−1 Food, +1 Hope

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 2/13

STRANGER · SEE... CHAO FA



STRANGER

A Deserter

A young soldier from the other side, without his rifle, wants to sell what he knows.

Pay him. He tells you where the patrols are.

give up an item, gain an escape card

Drive him off. He may go back to his unit.

Fortune card of 10 or less: easy fight

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 3/13

STRANGER · SEE... CHAO FA

STRANGER

A Forest Monk

A Lao monk lives alone in a hut by the path. He has rice and a little medicine.

Ask for medicine. He tends your sick.

+1 Hope, a sick or wounded person recovers

Ask for rice. He shares his bowl.

+2 Food

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 4/13

STRANGER · SEE... CHAO FA

STRANGER

Hmong Hunters

Two hunters from another clan are out for deer. They know these hills (Vang clan).

Hunt with them. Share the work and the meat.

+3 Food, Fortune card of 10 or less: easy fight

Ask the way. They draw the paths in the dirt.

turn up the next row

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 5/13

STRANGER · SEE... CHAO FA

STRANGER

A Friendly Headman

A village headman smiles, offers rice and asks where you are going.

Tell him the truth. He may be a friend. He may not.

+2 Food, Fortune card of 10 or less: medium fight

Lie and leave at night. Hungry, but unseen.

−1 Hope

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 6/13

STRANGER · SEE... CHAO FA

STRANGER

A Dying Fighter

An old resistance fighter, too sick to walk, says he hid things in this place.

Stay with him to the end. He tells you where to dig.

−1 Food, −1 Hope, 2 safe searches

Leave him your water. You go on.

−1 Hope

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 7/13

STRANGER · SEE... CHAO FA

STRANGER

Lost Children

Three children whose parents were shot at the river are hiding in a hollow tree.

Take them. They slow you, but how could you not?

−3 Food, +2 Hope

Show them the way to a village. Lao farmers may take them in.

−2 Hope

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 8/13

STRANGER · SEE... CHAO FA

STRANGER

An Opium Smuggler

A smuggler with a pack pony knows the back ways to the river, for silver.

Hire him. Pay, and he shows a hidden path.

give up an item, turn up the next row, gain an escape card

Keep away. Smugglers attract soldiers.

no effect

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 9/13

STRANGER · SEE... CHAO FA

STRANGER

A Txiv Neeb on the Trail

A shaman travelling to a sick relative offers to call your souls home (Yang clan).

Hold a ceremony. Kill your last chicken and call the souls.

−1 Food, +2 Hope, a sick or wounded person recovers

Thank him. He blesses the children as he passes.

+1 Hope

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 10/13

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

STRANGER · SEE… CHAO FA

STRANGER

Militia at the Spring

Village militia are filling their water at the spring you need.

Wait them out. Lie still until dark.
−1 Food

Rush them. Take their water and their gear.
1 safe search, Fortune card of 10 or less: easy fight

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 11/13

STRANGER · SEE… CHAO FA

STRANGER

Men Around a Radio

Hmong men in a clearing listen to a radio from Thailand. Names of the people in the camps are read out.

Listen with them. You hear a cousin's name. He made it.
+2 Hope

Ask for news of the river. They tell you which crossings are watched.
+1 Hope, turn up the next row

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 12/13

STRANGER · SEE… CHAO FA

STRANGER

A Lao Boatman

A lowland fisherman mending nets says he has taken Hmong families across before, and asks for nothing.

Accept his help. He will wait for you at the Fishing Hamlet.
+1 Hope

Keep away. You trust no one now.
no effect

THE TRAIL STRANGER · 13/13

STORY CLOTH · 1… CHAO FA

1961 TO 1975 · BEFORE

The Village

Read it aloud when found. Its carrier keeps it; if they are killed or taken, shuffle it into the top 3 of that place's search deck as a fallen square.

Families farmed the mountain slopes. From 1961 the men were recruited into a secret army; by 1969 it counted about 39,000, and planes dropped rice to the hill airstrips when the fields could no longer be farmed.

THE TRAIL STORY CLOTH · 1/9

STORY CLOTH · … CHAO FA

MAY 1975 · LEFT BEHIND

The Last Planes

Read it aloud when found. Its carrier keeps it; if they are killed or taken, shuffle it into the top 3 of that place's search deck as a fallen square.

On 14 May 1975 about 2,500 officers and their families were flown out of Long Tieng. Most soldiers and their families were left at their posts and had to walk.

THE TRAIL STORY CLOTH · 2/9

STORY CLOTH · … CHAO FA

1975 ONWARD · THE NEW GOVERNMENT

The Soldiers Come

Read it aloud when found. Its carrier keeps it; if they are killed or taken, shuffle it into the top 3 of that place's search deck as a fallen square.

Many officers and officials were sent to re-education "seminars" in remote camps, where many were starved or worked to death. At the Hin Heup bridge, soldiers fired on Hmong marching toward Vientiane.

THE TRAIL STORY CLOTH · 3/9

STORY CLOTH · … CHAO FA

1975 TO 1976 · PHOU BIA

Into the Forest

Read it aloud when found. Its carrier keeps it; if they are killed or taken, shuffle it into the top 3 of that place's search deck as a fallen square.

Others went into the forest. Former soldiers joined the Chao Fa, and Phou Bia, the highest mountain in Laos, became their stronghold. Whole villages hid with them.

THE TRAIL STORY CLOTH · 4/9

STORY CLOTH · … CHAO FA

1975 TO 1980 · IN THE JUNGLE

Hiding

Read it aloud when found. Its carrier keeps it; if they are killed or taken, shuffle it into the top 3 of that place's search deck as a fallen square.

Families hid in the jungle with the fighters and moved on whenever the soldiers came close. One oral history speaks of more than 100,000 people in the jungles.

THE TRAIL STORY CLOTH · 5/9

STORY CLOTH · … CHAO FA

1977 TO 1978 · THE OFFENSIVES

Fire from the Sky

Read it aloud when found. Its carrier keeps it; if they are killed or taken, shuffle it into the top 3 of that place's search deck as a fallen square.

Vietnamese regiments were sent against Phou Bia, and thousands were killed or captured. Refugees told of "yellow rain" from aircraft; what it was is still disputed.

THE TRAIL STORY CLOTH · 6/9

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

QHUA · SEEK HELP

Stranger

CHAO FA

PAJ NTAUB DAB NEEG · 3 × 3

Square 3

CHAO FA

PAJ NTAUB DAB NEEG · 3 × 3

Square 2

CHAO FA

PAJ NTAUB DAB NEEG · 3 × 3

Square 1

CHAO FA

PAJ NTAUB DAB NEEG · 3 × 3

Square 6

CHAO FA

PAJ NTAUB DAB NEEG · 3 × 3

Square 5

CHAO FA

PAJ NTAUB DAB NEEG · 3 × 3

Square 4

CHAO FA

STORY CLOTH · 7… CHAO FA

1975 TO 1980 · THE WAY OUT

The Walk South

Read it aloud when found. Its carrier keeps it; if they are killed or taken, shuffle it into the top 3 of that place's search deck as a fallen square.

Families walked for weeks toward the Mekong, carrying children and what they could. Up to a third of the Hmong of Laos left the country.

THE TRAIL STORY CLOTH · 7/9

STORY CLOTH · … CHAO FA

1975 TO 1992 · THE MEKONG

The Crossing

Read it aloud when found. Its carrier keeps it; if they are killed or taken, shuffle it into the top 3 of that place's search deck as a fallen square.

They crossed at night on bamboo floats, rafts or hired boats, and were shot at from the Lao bank. No one counted how many drowned. UNHCR counted 211,344 people from Laos reaching Thailand from 1975 to 1979.

THE TRAIL STORY CLOTH · 8/9

STORY CLOTH · … CHAO FA

1975 TO 1992 · BAN VINAI

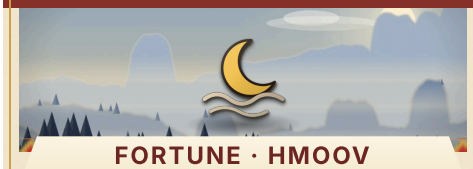
The Camp

Read it aloud when found. Its carrier keeps it; if they are killed or taken, shuffle it into the top 3 of that place's search deck as a fallen square.

Ban Vinai held 42,858 people at its peak, 90 percent of them Hmong, and families waited years for a country to take them. In the Thai camps they began to stitch story cloths like this one, so the story would not be lost.

THE TRAIL STORY CLOTH · 9/9

FORTUNE · 1 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Dab phem

In a fight: the soldiers' ATK is +2 this clash.

1

An ill spirit walks. Nothing goes right tonight.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 1/20

FORTUNE · 2 OF 20 CHAO FA

FORTUNE · HMOOV

Ntuj tsaus

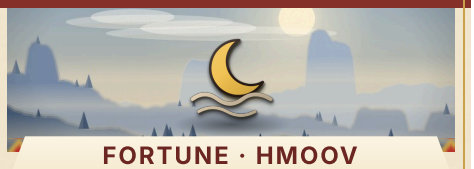
In a fight: the soldiers' ATK is +2 this clash.

2

A dark sky. The rain hides the soldiers, not you.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 2/20

FORTUNE · 3 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Huab cua phem

In a fight: the soldiers' ATK is +2 this clash.

3

Bad weather. The path turns to mud under your feet.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 3/20

FORTUNE · 4 OF 20 CHAO FA

FORTUNE · HMOOV

Ib lub suab

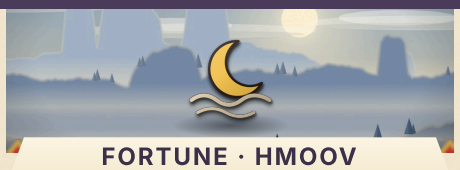
In a fight: the soldiers' ATK is +2 this clash.

4

A sound. A twig snaps, and someone heard it.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 4/20

FORTUNE · 5 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Hmoov phem

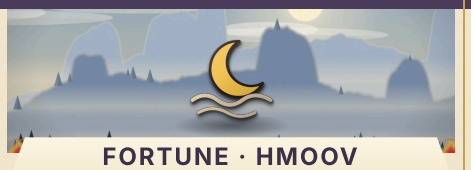
In a fight: an even clash.

5

Ill luck. The elders would have waited a day.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 5/20

FORTUNE · 6 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Hnub tsis tawm

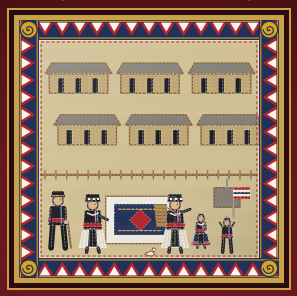
In a fight: an even clash.

6

The sun does not come out. A grey morning, a grey mood.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 6/20

PAJ NTAUB DAB NEEG · 3 × 3



Square 9

CHAO FA

PAJ NTAUB DAB NEEG · 3 × 3

Square 8

CHAO FA

PAJ NTAUB DAB NEEG · 3 × 3

Square 7

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

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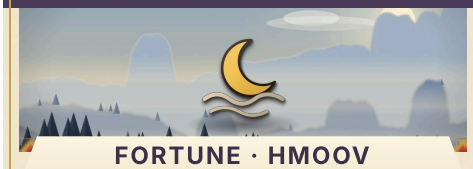
RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

FORTUNE · 7 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Tsis zoo

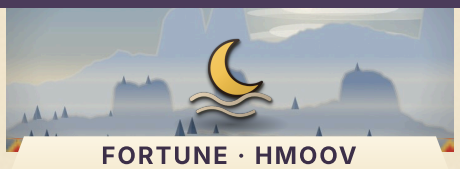
In a fight: an even clash.

7

Not good, not yet lost.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 7/20

FORTUNE · 8 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Nco tsev

In a fight: an even clash.

8

Homesick. You remember the village for a moment, and lose the trail.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 8/20

FORTUNE · 9 OF 20 CHAO FA

FORTUNE · HMOOV

Ua siab ntev

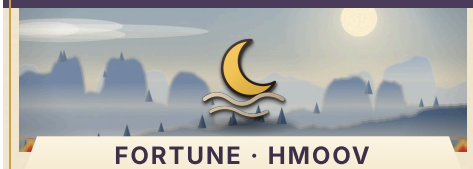
In a fight: an even clash.

9

Be patient. The hour is neither for you nor against you.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 9/20

FORTUNE · 10 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Kev khwv

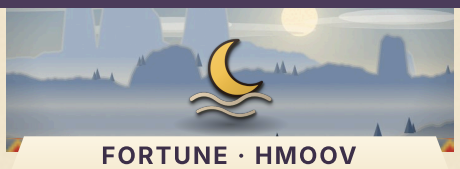
In a fight: an even clash.

10

Hard work, as every day.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 10/20

FORTUNE · 11 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Mus ntsiag to

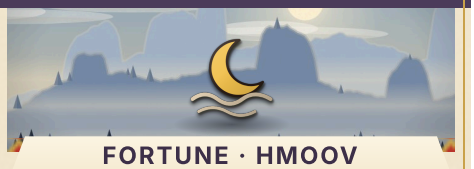
In a fight: an even clash.

11

Go quietly. The hills keep your secret.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 11/20

FORTUNE · 12 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Ib txoj kev

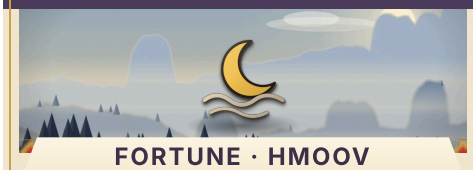
In a fight: an even clash.

12

One path among many. It will do.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 12/20

FORTUNE · 13 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Cov me nyuam luag

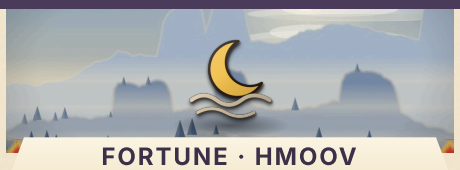
In a fight: an even clash.

13

The children laugh. Everyone walks a little lighter.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 13/20

FORTUNE · 14 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Noj mov

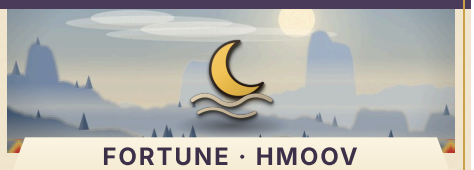
In a fight: an even clash.

14

A warm meal, and strength for the morning.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 14/20

FORTUNE · 15 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Pom kev

In a fight: an even clash.

15

You see the way ahead between the trees.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 15/20

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

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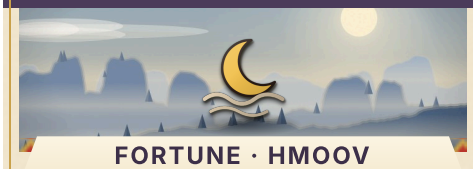
RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

FORTUNE · 16 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Siab tawv

In a fight: an even clash.

16

A brave heart. Courage runs through the party.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 16/20

FORTUNE · 17 OF 20 CHAO FA

FORTUNE · HMOOV

Ntuj pab

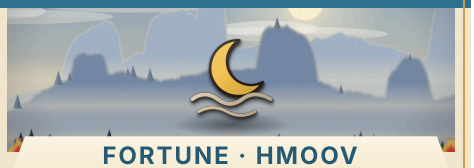
★ In a fight: the party's ATK is +2 this clash.

17

Heaven helps. The soldiers look the wrong way.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 17/20

FORTUNE · 18 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Hmoov zoo

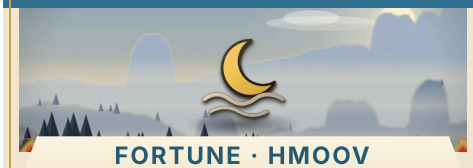
★ In a fight: the party's ATK is +2 this clash.

18

Good fortune. The old sayings were right.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 18/20

FORTUNE · 19 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Qeej nrov

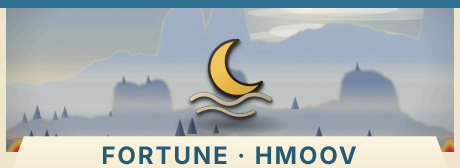
★ In a fight: the party's ATK is +2 this clash.

19

A qeej plays somewhere far off, and the spirits listen.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 19/20

FORTUNE · 20 OF 20 CHAO FA



FORTUNE · HMOOV

Cob Fab

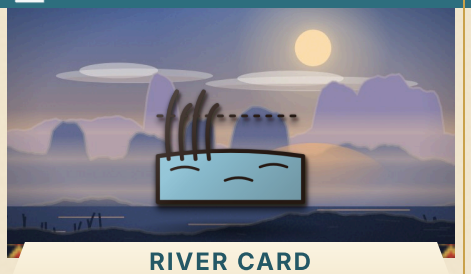
★ In a fight: the party's ATK is +2 this clash.

20

The Lord of the Sky rides. Nothing can touch you today.

THE TRAIL FORTUNE · 20/20

RIVER CHAO FA



RIVER CARD

Slack Water

Current check 6 better.

For a moment the great river is almost still.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 1/21

RIVER CHAO FA

RIVER CARD

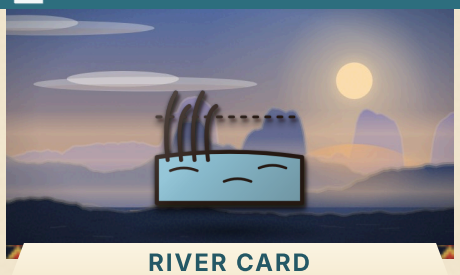
Slack Water

Current check 6 better.

For a moment the great river is almost still.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 2/21

RIVER CHAO FA



RIVER CARD

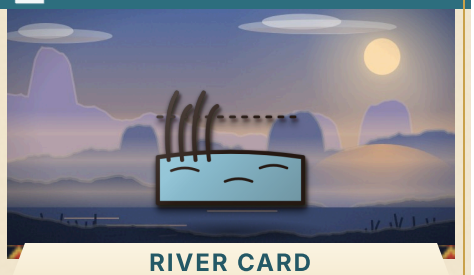
The Current

The usual current check.

The Mekong pulls hard toward the south, as it always does.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 3/21

RIVER CHAO FA



RIVER CARD

The Current

The usual current check.

The Mekong pulls hard toward the south, as it always does.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 4/21

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

RESHUFFLE ONLY WHEN IT RUNS OUT

Fortune

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

RIVER CHAO FA

RIVER CARD
The Current

The usual current check.

The Mekong pulls hard toward the south, as it always does.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 5/21

RIVER CHAO FA

RIVER CARD
A Drifting Log

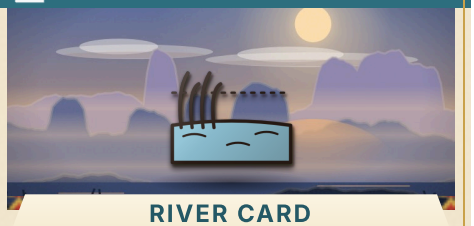
Hold on to it: It carries you across, far downstream. You let go of everything you carry.

Let it go: The usual current check.

A log turns slowly past in the dark.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 6/21

RIVER CHAO FA



RIVER CARD
The Searchlight

Dive and hold your breath: Current check 3 worse.

Lie still in the reeds: They may see you: Fortune 1–2 killed, 3–4 wounded (+4 under fire). Then the usual current check.

A patrol boat sweeps its light across the water.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 7/21

RIVER CHAO FA

RIVER CARD
The Searchlight

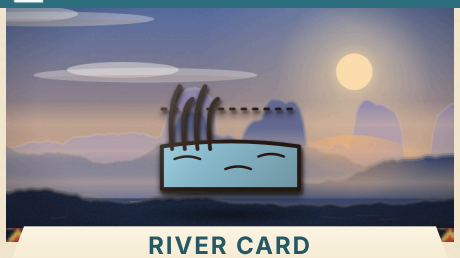
Dive and hold your breath: Current check 3 worse.

Lie still in the reeds: They may see you: Fortune 1–2 killed, 3–4 wounded (+4 under fire). Then the usual current check.

A patrol boat sweeps its light across the water.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 8/21

RIVER CHAO FA



RIVER CARD
The Whirlpool

Throw a rope or float: Spend a Rattan Rope, Bamboo Floats or an Inner Tube: you are pulled clear and cross.

Fight it alone: The river takes you: the drowning check.

The water turns in a circle and pulls down.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 9/21

RIVER CHAO FA

RIVER CARD
Cramp

Someone across swims back: The strongest one already across goes back in: their current check 2 worse. Pass and both reach the bank; fail and both are swept away.

Float and pray: Swept away, but floating: the drowning check 2 better.

Legs lock in the cold water. A child cries out, or an old man stops swimming.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 10/21

RIVER CHAO FA

RIVER CARD
A Sandbar

Current check 4 better.

Halfway across, sand under your feet. You can rest.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 11/21

RIVER CHAO FA

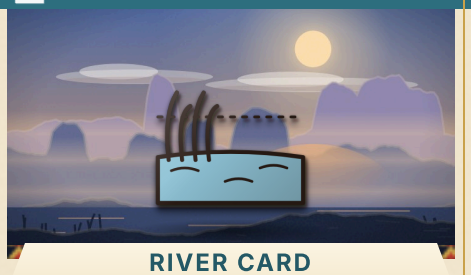
RIVER CARD
Thai Fishermen

They pull you aboard and you cross. Under fire they turn back: the usual current check.

A small boat puts out from the Thai bank to meet you.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 12/21

RIVER CHAO FA



RIVER CARD
The Raft Comes Apart

Current check 2 worse, and everyone still to cross on the raft must swim.

The bamboo lashings slip loose one by one.

THE TRAIL RIVER · 13/21

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

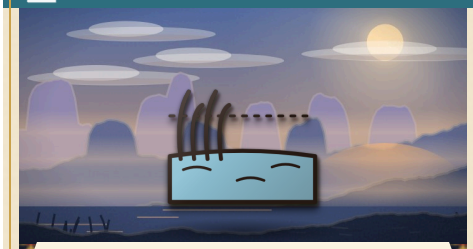
CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

RIVER · CHAO FA



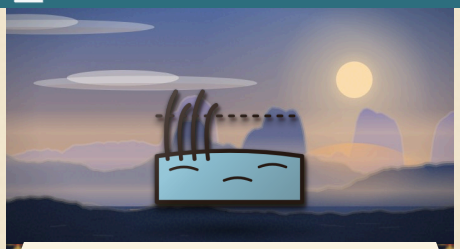
RIVER CARD
Cold Water

Current check 1 worse; 4 worse for a child, elder, sick or wounded person.

The river is colder than anyone expected.

THE TRAIL · RIVER · 14/21

RIVER · CHAO FA



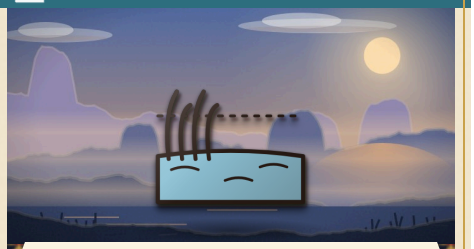
RIVER CARD
A Rain Squall

The usual current check, and no one else is shot going down to the water.

Rain comes down so hard the patrol cannot see the river.

THE TRAIL · RIVER · 15/21

RIVER · CHAO FA



RIVER CARD
A Line from the Thai Bank

Current check 8 better.

People on the far bank have seen you and throw a rope.

THE TRAIL · RIVER · 16/21

RIVER · CHAO FA

RIVER CARD
The Machine Gun

Swim under the water: Current check 4 worse.

Swim fast on the surface: Fortune 1–2 killed, 3–4 wounded (+4 under fire). Then the usual current check.

The patrol on the Lao bank opens fire into the water.

THE TRAIL · RIVER · 17/21

RIVER · MONSOON · CHAO FA

RIVER CARD · ADD IN THE MONSOON
Flood Surge

Current check 5 worse.

A wall of brown water comes down the river.

THE TRAIL · RIVER · 18/21

RIVER · MONSOON · CHAO FA

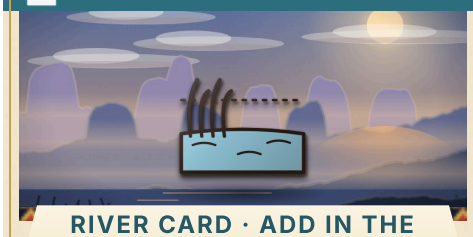
RIVER CARD · ADD IN THE MONSOON
Flood Surge

Current check 5 worse.

A wall of brown water comes down the river.

THE TRAIL · RIVER · 19/21

RIVER · MONSOON · CHAO FA



RIVER CARD · ADD IN THE MONSOON
An Uprooted Tree

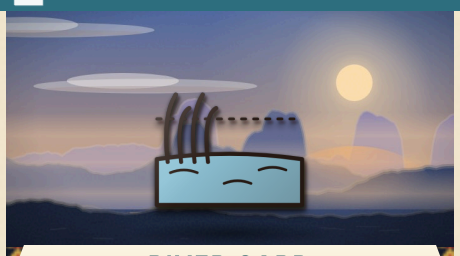
Hold on to the tree: It carries you across. You let go of everything you carry.

Swim clear of it: Current check 4 worse.

A whole tree comes down the flood, roots and all.

THE TRAIL · RIVER · 20/21

RIVER · CHAO FA



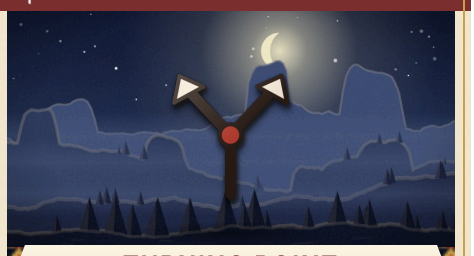
RIVER CARD
Pushed Back

Current check 4 worse.

Thai soldiers on the far bank wave you off: the camps are full. You must land further down, in the dark.

THE TRAIL · RIVER · 21/21

TURNING POINT · CHAO FA



TURNING POINT
Hunted

For the rest of the game every Danger draw when the party Travels is 2 worse, but every fight you win gives 1 more safe search.

The army has learned your family's names. Patrols carry a list.

THE TRAIL · TURNING POINT · 1/6

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

WHEN THE OMENS COME TRUE

Turning Point

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

DEJ · ONE PER PERSON AT THE CURRENT

River

CHAO FA

TURNING POINT CHAO FA

TURNING POINT

Sickness Spreads

Each villager draws a Fortune card: on 8 or less they fall Sick.

Dysentery runs through the people hiding in the hills.

TURNING POINT CHAO FA

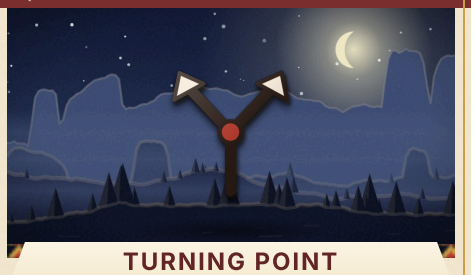
TURNING POINT

Word From Thailand

The passage needs 1 piece fewer. A Boatman waits at the Fishing Hamlet.

A message comes from a cousin in the camps: a fisherman at the hamlet will take you across.

TURNING POINT CHAO FA



TURNING POINT

The Long Rains

For the rest of the game the river is also in flood in Spring. Summer Forage finds 1 more Food everywhere.

The rains come early and stay late. The river rises and stays high.

TURNING POINT CHAO FA

TURNING POINT

Someone Is Following

The next time the party Travels, draw a Fortune card. On 10 or less he leads soldiers to you (a Hard fight). On 11 or more he is a Hmong man running too, and he joins you as a Guide.

A man has been walking behind you for two days, never closer, never gone.

TURNING POINT CHAO FA

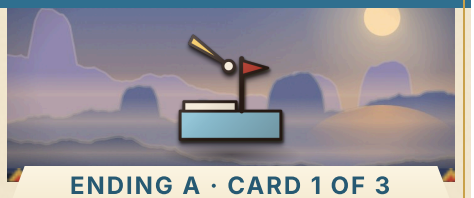
TURNING POINT

The Mountain Falls

Every square still guarded is now On the Fallen. Soldiers everywhere use the "from 1977" row. Hope +1 for the families now walking with you.

Spring 1978. The army takes Phou Bia, and the families who hid there come down the paths behind you.

ENDING A · IF ANYO... CHAO FA



ENDING A · CARD 1 OF 3

Across the Mekong

The survivors climb the Thai bank. Like the families who really made this crossing, they are taken to a refugee camp such as Ban Vinai or Nong Khai, and wait there for years. Say aloud the names of those who did not reach the river.

Read on: card 2 of 3.

ENDING A · IF ANYO... CHAO FA

ENDING A · CARD 2 OF 3

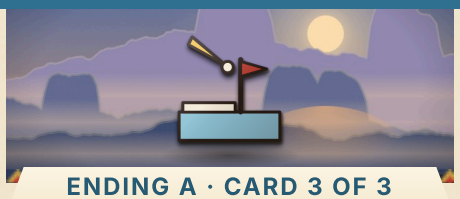
Across the Mekong

Now lay out the nine squares of the story cloth, 1 to 9, and read them aloud in order: the whole journey, from the village to the camp, the way the story cloths stitched in the camps kept it.

Most of those who crossed were resettled in the United States, France, Australia, Canada and French Guiana. More than 330,000 people in the United States now identify as Hmong, the largest group around Minneapolis and St. Paul.

Read on: card 3 of 3.

ENDING A · IF ANYO... CHAO FA



ENDING A · CARD 3 OF 3

Across the Mekong

The ones who did not cross are part of this story too. Turn the page of this ending and read what happened to them.

For what really happened, from the Chao Fa's origins in 1959 to the families still hiding today, read the history in the companion book or the app.

Based on true stories.

ENDING B · IF NO O... CHAO FA

ENDING B · CARD 1 OF 2

The ones who stayed

Those still alive turn back into the forest around Phou Bia. They join the people later called the Chao Fa: Hmong who stayed in the jungle after 1975, moving constantly, cut off from schools, clinics and work.

Lay out the squares of the story cloth you recovered and read them. The rest of the story stayed in the hills.

Read on: card 2 of 2.

WHEN THE OMENS COME TRUE

Turning Point

CHAO FA

WHEN THE OMENS COME TRUE

Turning Point

CHAO FA

WHEN THE OMENS COME TRUE

Turning Point

CHAO FA

IF ANYONE CROSSES

Across the Mekong

CHAO FA

WHEN THE OMENS COME TRUE

Turning Point

CHAO FA

WHEN THE OMENS COME TRUE

Turning Point

CHAO FA

IF NO ONE CROSSES

The ones who stayed

CHAO FA

IF ANYONE CROSSES

Across the Mekong

CHAO FA

IF ANYONE CROSSES

Across the Mekong

CHAO FA

ENDING B · IF NO O... CHAO FA

ENDING B · CARD 2 OF 2

The ones who stayed

A Chao Fa leader said in 2018 that if nothing is done, his people "will not die from being killed in direct confrontation, but from starvation." The Lao government denies these accounts.

Many are still there, in hiding.

For what really happened, from the Chao Fa's origins in 1959 to the families still hiding today, read the history in the companion book or the app.

Based on true stories.

THE TRAIL ENDING · 5/5

VOICE · IF ANYONE ... CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

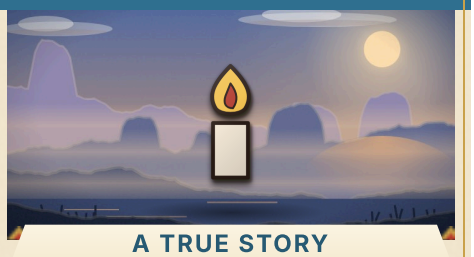
Song Ly

market seller at Long Tieng

On 14 May 1975 she and her child boarded the last aircraft out of Long Tieng. Her husband, an air traffic controller, missed it. They found each other again within a month at the Nam Phong camp.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 1/14

VOICE · IF ANYONE ... CHAO FA



A TRUE STORY

May Lee Soung

nurse

She began nursing at Sam Thong hospital at 11 and watched soldiers whose wounds were beyond treatment die in front of her. In 1975 her family went to Vientiane and hired a boat across the Mekong.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 2/14

VOICE · IF ANYONE ... CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

Neng "Nhia Cha" Xiong

lieutenant, recruited at 15

After 1975 he hid in the jungle, hunted by the soldiers. In 1979 he swam across the Mekong with his family, and lived at Ban Vinai until the camp closed.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 3/14

VOICE · IF ANYONE ... CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

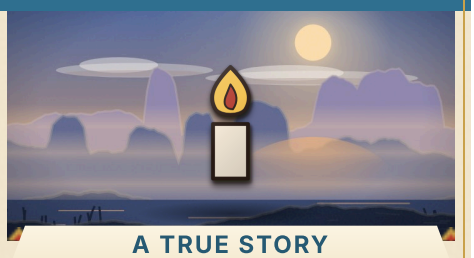
Youa K. Vue

survivor

In 1979 she made a hard choice: to leave her mother and siblings behind. After days of walking her group reached the Mekong and crossed safely. On the way she met and married Xai Chou Xiong, who promised to protect her. Her mother and siblings survived in Laos.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 4/14

VOICE · IF ANYONE ... CHAO FA



A TRUE STORY

Sao Ger Xiong

medic

His family hid in the jungle so he would not be imprisoned. In October 1979 he, his family and about 250 Hmong risked their lives to cross the Mekong together.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 5/14

VOICE · IF ANYONE ... CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

Cha Ger Moua

boy soldier

Two of his brothers were killed, and in 1972 he joined the army as a boy to avenge them. From 1975 his family hid in the jungle. In May 1980 he crossed the Mekong with 361 other Hmong.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 6/14

VOICE · IF ANYONE ... CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

Nhia Ge Vang

captain

After 1975 his community was moved into a village where they were ordered to learn the communist way of life. In 1979 he left for Thailand with about 1,000 Hmong.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 7/14

VOICE · IF NO ONE ... CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

Xong Pao Hang

boy soldier, recruited at 13

His uniform had to be cut down to fit him. After 1975 his family hid. In 1978, as they fled toward Thailand, his mother and sister were shot dead by the troops pursuing them.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 8/14

IF ANYONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

IF ANYONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

IF NO ONE CROSSES

The ones who stayed

CHAO FA

IF ANYONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

IF ANYONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

IF ANYONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

IF NO ONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

IF ANYONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

IF ANYONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

VOICE · IF NO ONE … CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

Xai Chou Xiong

lieutenant

After 1975 his family hid in the jungle. Almost all of them were killed in one attack. He survived, and later reached the Thai camps.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 9/14

VOICE · IF NO ONE … CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

Chong Neng Lor

platoon commander

Some of his soldiers were as young as 12. In 1975 he was sent to a re-education camp. He escaped from a work field into the forest and found his family in the jungle. They crossed in 1983, lived about 20 years in Thailand, and reached the United States in 2004.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 10/14

VOICE · IF NO ONE … CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

Nhia Tou Pha

lieutenant

When the soldiers were rounded up, his family hid in the jungle. From 1975 to 1979 he fought with the Chao Fa resistance. In 1980 he fled to Ban Vinai.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 11/14

VOICE · IF NO ONE … CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

Tong Chang Lee

captain, wounded three times

After 1975 he resisted from the jungle. He escaped to Thailand in 1979 and lived in the camps for 25 years, at Ban Vinai and then Wat Tham Krabok. He reached the United States in 2005, with the last wave.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 12/14

VOICE · IF NO ONE … CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

Tong Vang

veteran

He came back to Long Tieng and found all the planes gone. "If you lived, you live. If you died you died."

THE TRAIL VOICE · 13/14

VOICE · IF NO ONE … CHAO FA

A TRUE STORY

Boua Vang Xiong

soldier

He kept fighting from 1973 to 1979. In May 1979 he fled to Thailand with his brother, leaving their parents behind.

THE TRAIL VOICE · 14/14

LAW CHAO FA

LAW OF THE PARTY

Council of Elders

The elders decide together. At every year end, +1 Hope, but 1 Food is cooked for the council.

At a Winter council, draw 2 laws; the party may adopt one. It cannot be undone.

THE TRAIL LAW · REF · 1/21

LAW CHAO FA

LAW OF THE PARTY

Travel by Night

Every Danger draw when the party moves is 2 better, but each Forage finds 1 less Food.

At a Winter council, draw 2 laws; the party may adopt one. It cannot be undone.

THE TRAIL LAW · REF · 2/21

LAW CHAO FA

LAW OF THE PARTY

Proper Funerals

Deaths cost no Hope, but each burial uses 1 Food for the funeral meal.

At a Winter council, draw 2 laws; the party may adopt one. It cannot be undone.

THE TRAIL LAW · REF · 3/21

IF NO ONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

IF NO ONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

IF NO ONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

IF NO ONE CROSSES

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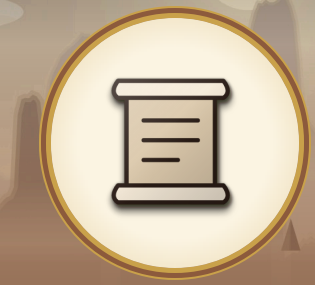
IF NO ONE CROSSES

Voice

CHAO FA

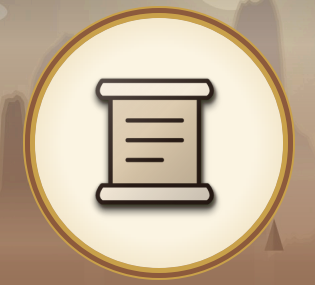
WINTER COUNCIL



Law

CHAO FA

WINTER COUNCIL



Law

CHAO FA

WINTER COUNCIL

Law

CHAO FA

LAW OF THE PARTY

Everyone Nurses the Sick

Every Rest heals 1 extra wound or cures Sickness on any card, but each cure uses 1 Food for broth.

At a Winter council, draw 2 laws; the party may adopt one. It cannot be undone.

LAW OF THE PARTY

Strict Rations

In Spring and Summer only half the party (rounded up) eats. -1 Hope at every year end while anyone is hungry.

At a Winter council, draw 2 laws; the party may adopt one. It cannot be undone.

LAW OF THE PARTY

Travel Light

Each person keeps at most 3 items (discard the rest now). Every Danger draw is 2 better.

At a Winter council, draw 2 laws; the party may adopt one. It cannot be undone.

REFERENCE

Waiting, powers and escape · 1 of 3

When you cannot move (1 action each): **Lay an ambush** (once a place): next fight here you fire first. **Cover tracks** (once a season): noise here −2. **Trade** (village, hamlet, road, ferry): item for 3 Food, informer on a Fortune card of 1–3. **Share a meal** (once a season): 2 Food, Hope +1. **Seek help** (once a season): draw a Stranger.

Side A power: once a season (Old Road, Winter Clothes once a year). **Side B trait**: always on.

Armor: stops that much damage to its

REFERENCE

Waiting, powers and escape · 2 of 3

Escape card: when soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.

Omens: on the Omen row of the board; each new one, a Fortune card at or under the row's number = the Turning Point (draw 1 of 6, once a game).

Clan: a Stranger of a clan in the party gives the better answer for nothing.

Hidden field (Spring, at the fields, the stream or the Vientiane plain, 1 Food): planted; +4 Food in Fall if you are still there and no fight has happened here.

REFERENCE

Waiting, powers and escape · 3 of 3

Animals: a Horse or Water Buffalo carries one more pack slot and may be slaughtered for 4 Food and −1 Hope; neither goes into the caves or across the river. **Disguise**: two disguise pieces in the party and a Guarded or Price key is not stepped up.

REFERENCE

A season on the trail · 1 of 3

Season card: draw and resolve; answer dilemmas together.

2 actions each (1 if Sick; −1 at Hope 0): Search · Scout · Forage · Rest or nurse · Build camp · Side A power · Play a card · Give an item.

Travel (first thing in the season, instead of any actions): move the party to a known place next to it, draw a Fortune card against its Danger, gather forage, and the season ends.

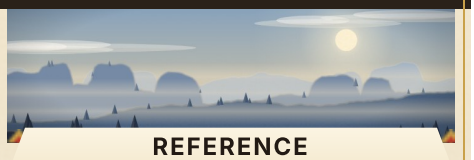
REFERENCE

A season on the trail · 2 of 3

Hard work eats: Search, Scout, Build and Travel cost 1 Food (none left: the worker takes a wound). **Winter**: eat 1 Food each; each short is a wound. Forage: +1 wherever the tile shows any.

Carry: 2 hands (rifles, bows and spears take both), 1 body, 1 head, 3 pack. Animals, boats and raft wood are shared. Too much? Hand it on or leave it.

Unnursed sick: die on a Fortune card of 1–5.



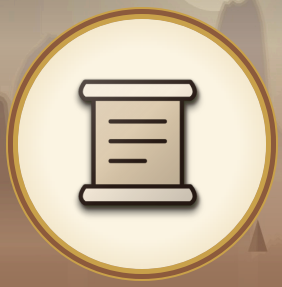
REFERENCE

A season on the trail · 3 of 3

Winter: the Toll, then draw 2 laws; the council may adopt one.

Fallen players: once a season, give a living villager 1 more action.

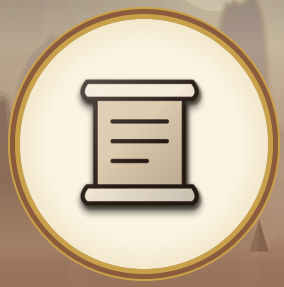
WINTER COUNCIL



Law

CHAO FA

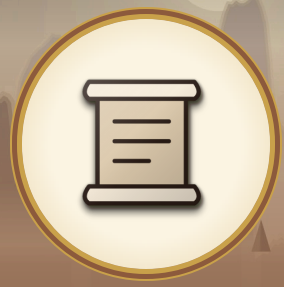
WINTER COUNCIL



Law

CHAO FA

WINTER COUNCIL



Law

CHAO FA

KEEP FACE UP

Reference

CHAO FA

KEEP FACE UP

Reference

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CHAO FA

KEEP FACE UP

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CHAO FA

REFERENCE

Fights and noise · 1 of 3

1 · The soldiers: one number from the Patrol table (the row is the fight, the column your living villagers, the block the year) is their ATK, DEF and HP. Nothing is added. Add up the party's ATK, DEF and HP.

2 · Clash, up to 3 times: draw 1 Fortune card (1–4: soldiers +2 ATK; 17–20: party +2 ATK). You deal your ATK minus their number; they deal their number minus your DEF, **always at least 1**. You choose who is hit; Armor stops it first.

3 · The cost: their damage reaches their number = you win and search here in

REFERENCE · FIGHTS CHAO FA

REFERENCE

Fights and noise · 2 of 3

Prisoner: a villager who falls in a fight (not the river) draws a Fortune card: 1–10 killed, 11–20 taken prisoner (Ending 4). Either way, everything they carried is lost.

Break away (after clash 1 or 2): discard one item per living villager instead of taking their hit; the fight ends, nothing gained.

Shakedown (Easy fights only): hand over 2 Food or one money item and walk on. No fight.

Loud weapons: a fight with any loud weapon puts an Alarm token on the

REFERENCE · FIGHTS CHAO FA

REFERENCE

Fights and noise · 3 of 3

Night (Travel by Night, after moving): the soldiers' number and your ATK are both 1 lower. **A carried child**: the carrier has one hand and ATK −1; the child cannot be hit.

Noise: searching a place again, a Fortune card at or under its earlier searches = soldiers (no spoils).

REFERENCE

The Toll and the river · 1 of 3

Toll: each person draws a Fortune card, falls Sick on 5 or less. +1 child, elder, wounded or sick; +1 per Food short (max 3); +cold (1975 0, 76–77 +1, 78–79 +2); Hope 0 +2, 1–2 +1, 5–6 −1; healer −1; finished camp −1; warm items up to −2. Sick and taken again: dies.

Guard tokens: when a key encounter is drawn and left, its guard token goes on the tile so the table sees where the keys are.

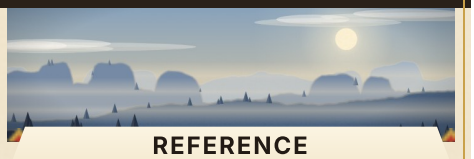
REFERENCE · WINT... CHAO FA

REFERENCE

The Toll and the river · 2 of 3

Keys: every key is guarded, one step harder than its place (hard → deadly); a win recovers the next square of the story cloth. **River**: need all 9 squares (sewn at the start: a party of 6 has squares 1–2, 5 has 1–3, 4 has 1–4, 3 has 1–5; Short Trail 3 more), on any river place. A fallen carrier's squares go into the top 3 of that place's search deck. 1 Hope lets one person draw again at the current or when drowning. River Patrol: its own row of the Patrol table, no escape cards; up to 3 clashes; still standing = cross under fire (no

REFERENCE · WINT... CHAO FA

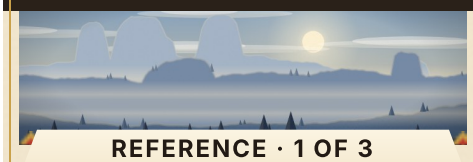


REFERENCE

The Toll and the river · 3 of 3

Low water (Spring, not monsoon): the current is 2 better. **The tributary** (lowlands to river, Summer or Fall): a Fortune card, on 1–2 the heaviest load loses an item.

Boat: four seats a trip; a second trip meets the River Patrol again. **Washed up**: swept away and drawing 18 or more, you reach the Thai bank alone with nothing.



REFERENCE · 1 OF 3

Symbol key

Search: draw the top card of this place

Scout: turn a hidden place face up

Travel: the party moves; the season ends

Rest / Nurse: heal 1, or break a fever

Camp: a finished camp heals 2 and eases the Toll

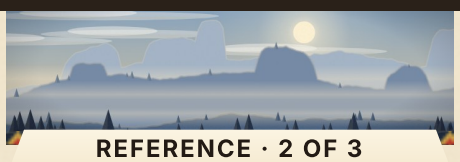
Food: the store; eaten in Winter

Hope: 0 to 6; sets the Toll and the actions

Wound: −1 HP; at 0 the villager falls

Sick: one action; cured by nursing

REFERENCE · SYMB... CHAO FA



REFERENCE · 2 OF 3

Symbol key

Danger III / IIII: Hard and Deadly fights

River Patrol ~: the fight at the bank

Ambush: the soldiers fire first

Escape: discard: no fight

Fortune 1–4: soldiers +2 this clash

Fortune 17–20: party +2 this clash

Alarm: next fight here one row harder

Guard: a key encounter waits here

Key: a square of the story cloth

Omen: on the Omen row; brings the Turning Point

REFERENCE · SYMB... CHAO FA

REFERENCE · 3 OF 3

Symbol key

Quiet weapon: no alarm; a hunter fires first

Cannot swim: drowns 2 worse without a float

Money: pays a Boatman, a Price, a Trade, a shakedown

Animal: one more pack slot; 3 Food if slaughtered

Disguise: two pieces: no step up at a key

Cache: items left on a tile

Planted field: harvest +2 Food when you return

KEEP FACE UP

Reference

CHAO FA

KEEP FACE UP

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SETUP · THE PHOU … CHAO FA

SETUP CARD · A HISTORICAL TRAIL

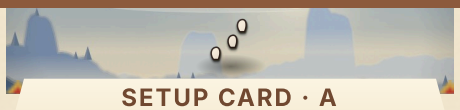
The Phou Bia Trail

Lay face down, left to right. **Hills**: Swidden Fields, Plain of Jars, Long Tieng Airstrip. **Jungle**: Phou Bia Slopes, Phou Khao Khouay Jungle, Limestone Caves. **Lowlands**: Lao Farm Village, Nam Xan Valley, Vientiane Plain. **River**: Mekong Reeds, Fishing Hamlet, Tha Deua Ferry.

Far bank: Bueng Kan, then the camp at Ban Vinai.

THE TRAIL SETUP · 1/3

SETUP · THE VIENTI… CHAO FA



SETUP CARD · A HISTORICAL TRAIL

The Vientiane Road

Lay face down, left to right. **Hills**: Swidden Fields, Pine Ridge, Long Tieng Airstrip. **Jungle**: Bamboo Forest, Phou Khao Khouay Jungle, Limestone Caves. **Lowlands**: Lao Farm Village, Hin Heup Bridge, Vientiane Plain. **River**: Mekong Reeds, Fishing Hamlet, Tha Deua Ferry.

Far bank: Nong Khai, then the camp at Ban Vinai.

THE TRAIL SETUP · 2/3

SCENARIO · THE LA… CHAO FA

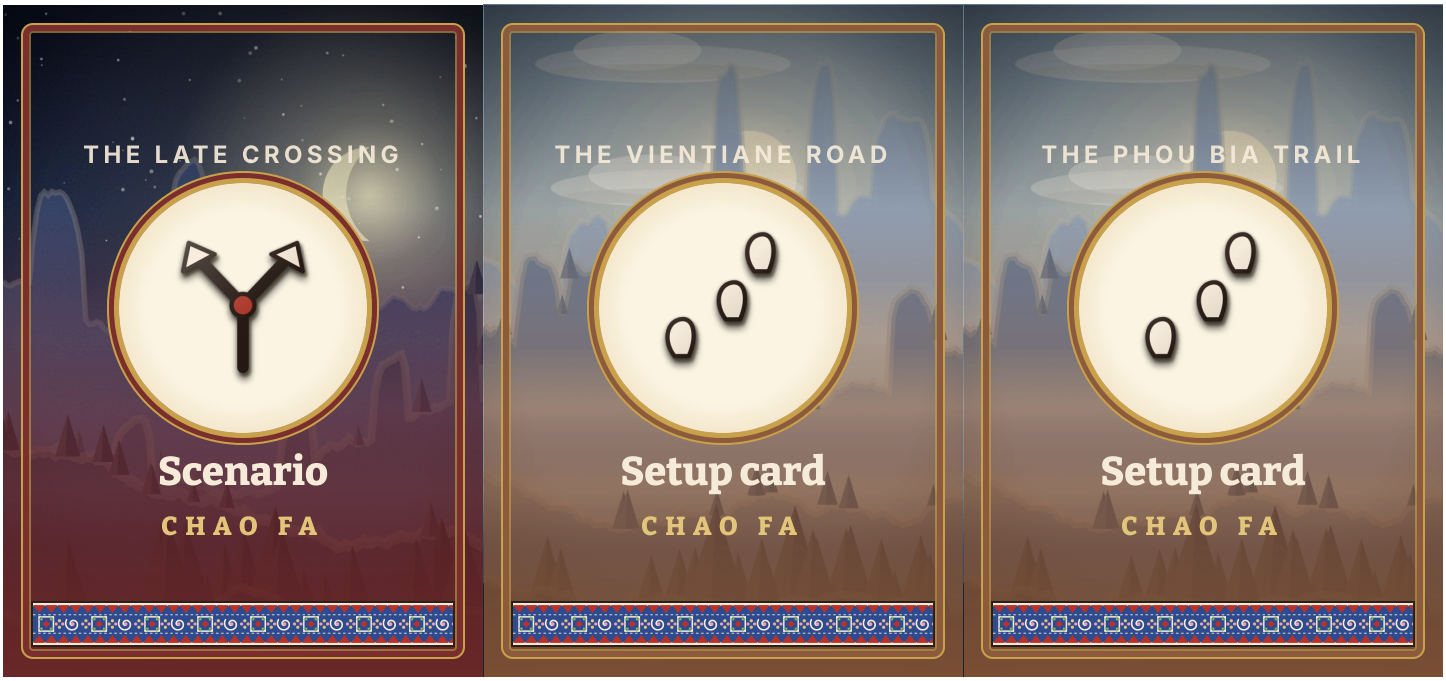
SCENARIO · AFTER A GAME

The Late Crossing, 1979

Spring 1979 (season 17), a lowlands place, the squares you held (at least six). Patrol table face 2 only; Pushed Back in the River deck. Food 2 each, Hope 2. The camps close after season 24.

The villagers alive in Laos at the last Winter try again.

THE TRAIL SETUP · 3/3


THE LATE CROSSING
Scenario
CHAO FA
THE VIENTIANE ROAD
Setup card
CHAO FA
THE PHOU BIA TRAIL
Setup card
CHAO FA

CHAO FA

The Trail. *Laos, 1975 to 1980. Walk south from the burned village, recover the nine squ river in flood. Winter: the Toll, then the council.*

TIME · ONE TURN IS ONE SEASON

1975	1	2	3	4	1976	5	6	7	8	1977	9	10
cold +0	Spring · start	Summer · monsoon	Fall · nplooj zeeg	Winter · ntuj no · Toll, council	cold +1	Spring · nplooj hlav	Summer · monsoon	Fall · nplooj zeeg	Winter · ntuj no · Toll, council	cold +1	Spring · nplooj hlav	Summe monso

HOME

Village Ruins

Face up. The party starts here.

THE HILLS

Shuffle the 4, lay 3 face down, 1 back in the box: Swidden Fields · Pine Ridge · Long Tieng Airstrip · Plain of Jars

Hills place

Face down until scouted. Its search deck lies on the tile.

Hills place

Face down until scouted. Its search deck lies on the tile.

Hills place

Face down until scouted. Its search deck lies on the tile.

THE JUNGLE

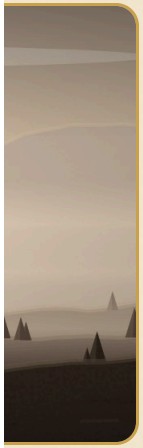
Shuffle the 4, lay 3 face down, 1 back in the box: Bamboo Forest · Phou Khao Khouay Jungle · Limestone Caves · Phou Bia Slopes

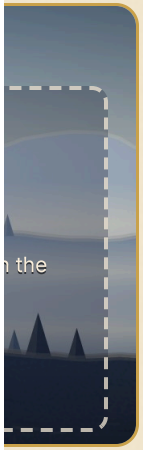
glue sheet 2 over this margin

glue sheet 3 over this margin

ares of the story cloth, and cross the Mekong before the camps close. One turn is one season; the time marker moves at the end of each. Blue edge: monsoon, the

er · on	11 Fall · nplooj zeeg	12 Winter · ntuj no · Toll, council	**1978** cold +2	13 Spring · nplooj hlav	14 Summer · monsoon	15 Fall · nplooj zeeg	16 Winter · ntuj no · Toll, council	**1979** cold +2	17 Spring · nplooj hlav	18 Summer · monsoon	19 Fall · nplooj zeeg	20 Winter · the last season





FOOD · START WITH 3 PER VILLAGER · MAX 20

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20

HOPE · 0 TO 6

0	1	2	3	4	5	6
Toll 2 worse, 1 action less	Toll 1 worse	Toll 1 worse	start		Toll 1 better	Toll 1 better

THE STORY CLOTH · ALL NINE SQUARES TO CROSS

SETUP

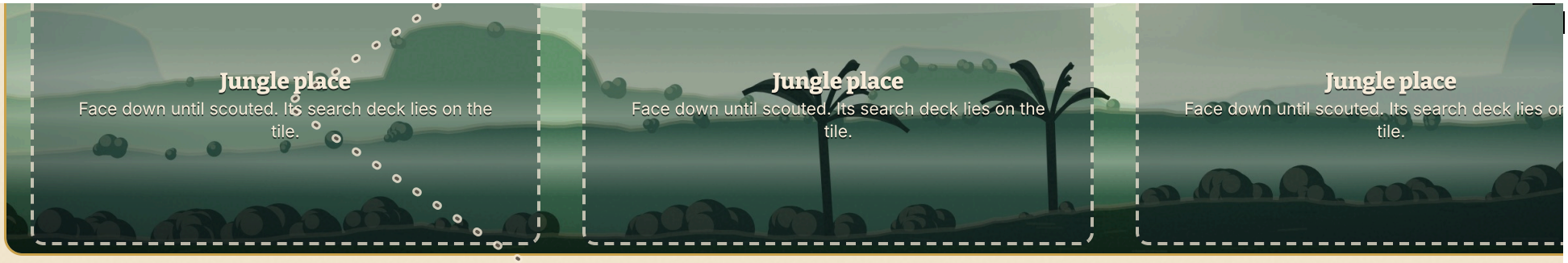
1. Village Ruins face up at the top; each row's tiles shuffled, three laid face down, the fourth back in the box (or a setup card decides).
2. Each place's search deck shuffled, face down on its tile.
3. Food 3 per villager, Hope 3, time on 1. Squares already sewn: 2 for a party of 6, 3 for 5, 4 for 4, 5 for 3 (see the cloth).
4. Each villager holds the first of their own items. Shuffle the Fortune deck, face down. Season deck: the From 1977 cards shuffled under the rest.

MOVING

1. **Scout** (1 action, 1 Food): turn one hidden place next to the party face

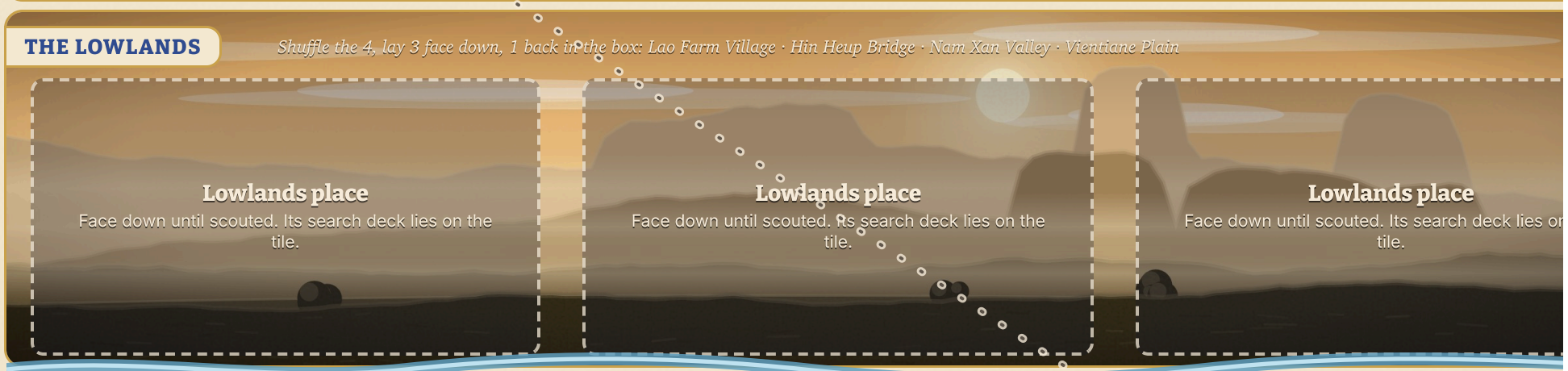
✂ trim this edge, lay it over sheet 1

glue sheet 4 over this margin



THE LOWLANDS

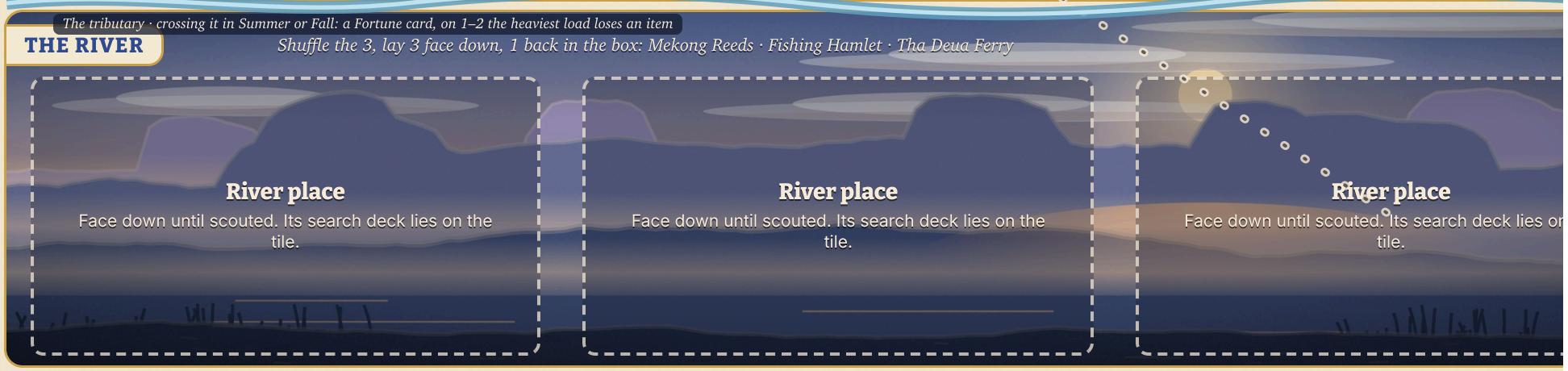
Shuffle the 4, lay 3 face down, 1 back in the box: Lao Farm Village · Hin Heup Bridge · Nam Xan Valley · Vientiane Plain



The tributary · crossing it in Summer or Fall: a Fortune card, on 1–2 the heaviest load loses an item

THE RIVER

Shuffle the 3, lay 3 face down, 1 back in the box: Mekong Reeds · Fishing Hamlet · Tha Deua Ferry



The Mekong

THAILAND BEYOND

Cross with all nine squares, from any river place. Children and the sick go first; each person or pair walks the lane in turn.

1 The bank

THE RIVER PATROL

Its own row of the Patrol table. No escape cards. Up to 3 clashes: beaten, you reach the water unseen; still standing, you break for the water **under fire.** A hired boat takes 4 a trip; a second trip meets the

2 Down to the water

ONE FORTUNE CARD EACH

Hit on **3 or less** (7 under fire): killed on 1 (1–2 under fire), otherwise wounded. A Safe Crossing Place, Travel by Night and Gao B each make it 1–2 better.

3

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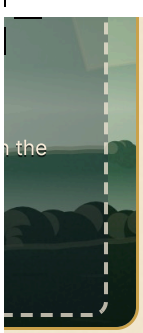
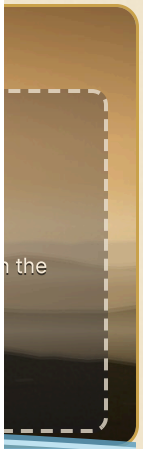
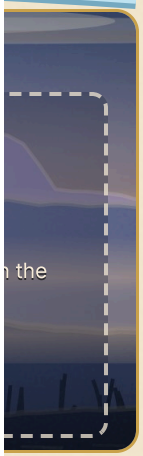
✂ trim this edge, lay it over sheet 2

✂ trim this edge, lay it over sheet 3







Into the Forest · party of 4 | Hiding · party of 3 | Fire from the Sky

up.

2. **Travel** (before anyone acts, 1 Food): the whole party moves to a face-up place ahead, diagonally ahead or beside it; draw a Fortune card against the place's Danger; the season ends.
3. A finished camp stays on its tile. Everything else is on the player aids.

THE OMEN ROW · EACH OMEN CARD LIES IN THE NEXT SLOT; DRAW A FORTUNE CARD WHEN IT ARRIVES

1	2	3	4	5
Turning Point on 5 or less	Turning Point on 10 or less	Turning Point on 15 or less	the Turning Point is certain	the Turning Point is certain

Season deck
Face down. One card at the start of every season.

Season discard
Face up. Shuffle it back in when the deck runs out.

A SEASON · THE PHASE MARKER

1. **Season card**
   Draw the top card and do what it says. Monsoon (blue edge): the river is in flood.
2. **Travel?**
   Before anyone acts the party may Travel (1 Food): draw a Fortune card against the new place, forage there, and the season ends.
3. **Actions**
   Each villager, in any order, 2 actions (1 in a Sweep). Search, Scout, Forage, Rest, Camp, powers, Cross.
4. **Winter only**
   Eat 1 Food each (none: Hungry). The Toll: one Fortune card each, Sick on 5 or less. Then the council adopts a law.
5. **Time marker**
   Move it one season. 1980 arrives: the game ends.

THE LAWS, THE FORTUNE DECK (FACE DOWN, RESHUFFLE WHEN IT RUNS OUT), STRANGERS, RIVER CARDS AND TURNING POINTS WAIT BESIDE THE BOARD; ADOPTED LAWS LIE FACE UP.

In the current
A RIVER CARD, THEN A FORTUNE CARD
Swept away on **13 or less**: monsoon +4, child, elder, sick or wounded +2, boat −6, raft −3, Safe Crossing Place −3, floats up to −4, Spring low water −2. A pair walks on one set of draws; a child is

4 **Swept away**
ONE FORTUNE CARD
Drowned on **12 or less**: monsoon +3, vulnerable +2, cannot swim without a float +2; 2 better with a line from the Thai bank, 2 better off a raft or boat. 18 or more: washed up alone on the Thai bank with

5 **The Thai bank**
NONG KHAI · BAN VINAI
Out of the water. When no one is left in the river the game ends: read **Ending A** and say the names of those who did not reach it.

Chao Fa · place tiles, fronts 1 (cut on the dashed lines)

HOME · CHAO FA

Village Ruins

the hills of Xieng Khouang

Danger 2 · easy fight · Forage Sp 1 · Su 1 · Fa 1 · Wi 0

Your own village or a neighbour's, burned or abandoned when the soldiers came.

THE HILLS · CHAO FA

Swidden Fields

Danger 3 · easy fight · Forage Sp 1 · Su 1 · Fa 2 · Wi 1

Hillside fields of upland rice and corn, cleared by slash-and-burn.

THE HILLS · CHAO FA

Pine Ridge

Danger 2 · easy fight · Forage Sp 1 · Su 1 · Fa 1 · Wi 0

High, cool pine forest along the ridgeline above the villages.

THE HILLS · CHAO FA

Long Tieng Airstrip

Lima Site 20A

Danger 4 · medium fight · Forage Sp 1 · Su 1 · Fa 1 · Wi 0

The long dirt runway of Long Tieng, the Hmong army's old headquarters, between the karst hills. *Everyone knew this strip: the planes came every day, until the day they did not. Sam Thong, with its hospital, lies over the ridge.*

THE JUNGLE · CHAO FA

Bamboo Forest

Danger 3 · easy fight · Forage Sp 1 · Su 2 · Fa 1 · Wi 0

Dense groves of giant bamboo in the valleys below the ridges.

THE JUNGLE · CHAO FA

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

the forest toward the river

Danger 5 · medium fight · Forage Sp 1 · Su 2 · Fa 2 · Wi 0

Tall rain forest on the sandstone hills between the mountains and the Mekong, with leeches and little light. *Families walking down from Phou Bia toward Paksane came through these hills. Good for hiding, and the soldiers know it.*

THE JUNGLE · CHAO FA

Limestone Caves

the karst toward Vang Vieng

Danger 1 · easy fight · Forage Sp 0 · Su 0 · Fa 0 · Wi 0

Caves in the karst towers, dry inside even in the monsoon. *The villagers remember the cave at Tham Piu, where a whole village sheltering from the bombing was killed. They go in quietly.*

THE LOWLANDS · CHAO FA

Lao Farm Village

Danger 4 · medium fight · Forage Sp 1 · Su 1 · Fa 2 · Wi 1

A lowland village of Lao rice farmers, on the way to the river.

Chao Fa · place tiles, backs 1 (print on the back of the page before)

Chao Fa · place tiles, fronts 2 (cut on the dashed lines)

THE LOWLANDS — CHAO FA

Hin Heup Bridge

Route 13

Danger 8 · hard fight **Forage Sp 0 · Su 0 · Fa 0 · Wi 0**

The road to Vientiane and the bridge over the Nam Lik, with an army checkpoint at its end. *Everyone has heard what happened on this bridge in May 1975. Nobody crosses it in daylight.*

THE LOWLANDS — CHAO FA

Nam Xan Valley

down to Paksane

Danger 3 · easy fight **Forage Sp 1 · Su 2 · Fa 2 · Wi 1**

A rocky stream running down into the Nam Xan, the river that meets the Mekong at Paksane.

THE RIVER — CHAO FA

Mekong Reeds

the Lao bank, facing Thailand

Danger 4 · medium fight **Forage Sp 1 · Su 1 · Fa 1 · Wi 1**

Reeds and mud flats on the Lao bank between Vientiane and Paksane, with Thailand across the water.

THE RIVER — CHAO FA

Fishing Hamlet

Danger 5 · medium fight **Forage Sp 2 · Su 1 · Fa 1 · Wi 1**

A few stilt houses of Lao fishermen with boats pulled up on the bank.

THE RIVER — CHAO FA

Tha Deua Ferry

across from Nong Khai

Danger 9 · hard fight **Forage Sp 1 · Su 1 · Fa 1 · Wi 1**

The old ferry landing below Vientiane, where the boats to Nong Khai crossed, now a guarded army post.

THE HILLS — CHAO FA

Plain of Jars

Danger 3 · medium fight **Forage Sp 1 · Su 1 · Fa 1 · Wi 0**

Open grassland around the great stone jars, cratered and littered with old bombs. *The jars stood here before anyone's grandfather. The craters are newer.*

THE JUNGLE — CHAO FA

Phou Bia Slopes

Danger 3 · medium fight · from 1977: 6 · hard

Forage Sp 1 · Su 1 · Fa 1 · Wi 0

The high slopes of the biggest mountain in Laos, cold, steep and full of hiding families. *The mountain the resistance is named for. Up here the Chao Fa may find you before the soldiers do.*

THE LOWLANDS — CHAO FA

Vientiane Plain

Danger 7 · hard fight **Forage Sp 1 · Su 1 · Fa 2 · Wi 1**

Rice paddies, market towns and the road into the capital, a day from the river. *The lowland Lao here are not the enemy, and not all of them are friends.*

Chao Fa · place tiles, backs 2 (print on the back of the page before)

CHAO FA · standees 1 of 2 · cut on the dashed lines, fold at the top so the two faces stand back to back, fold the tabs out as feet

FOLD · STAND

Chai
SIDE A · SENGLAO (MAYOR)

FOLD · STAND

Tou
SIDE A · TEACHER

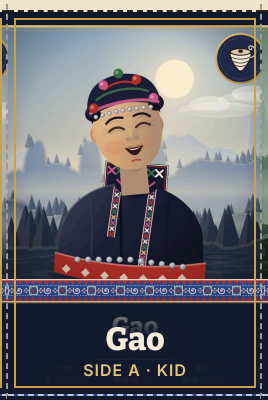
FOLD · STAND

Mai
SIDE A · FARMER

FOLD · STAND

Chao
SIDE A · KID

FOLD · STAND



Gao
SIDE A · KID

FOLD · STAND

Sheng
SIDE A · HUNTER

FOLD · STAND

Chai
SIDE B · SENGLAO IN EXILE

FOLD · STAND

Tou
SIDE B · TEACHER WHO READS THAI AND LAO

FOLD · STAND

Mai
SIDE B · RICE FARMER, MOTHER OF TWO

FOLD · STAND

Chao
SIDE B · KID, MESSAGE RUNNER

FOLD · STAND

Gao
SIDE B · KID, LITTLE MOTHER

FOLD · STAND

Sheng
SIDE B · CROSSBOW HUNTER

FOLD · STAND

Chong
SIDE A · BLACKSMITH

FOLD · STAND

Meng
SIDE A · SHAMAN

FOLD · STAND

Pao
SIDE A · FARMER

FOLD · STAND

Blong
SIDE A · ELDER

FOLD · STAND

Cheng
SIDE A · SOLDIER

FOLD · STAND

Kong
SIDE A · DOCTOR

FOLD · STAND

Chong
SIDE B · RAFT BUILDER

FOLD · STAND

Meng
SIDE B · SHAMAN WHO READS THE BONES

FOLD · STAND

Pao
SIDE B · FISHERMAN-FARMER, STRONG SWIMMER

FOLD · STAND

Blong
SIDE B · ELDER WHO KNOWS THE OLD ROADS

FOLD · STAND

Cheng
SIDE B · SGU RADIO OPERATOR

FOLD · STAND

Kong
SIDE B · MEDIC TRAINED AT SAM THONG

FOLD · STAND

CHAO FA · standees 2 of 2, and the tokens

FOLD · STAND FOLD · STAND FOLD · STAND FOLD · STAND

FOLD · STAND FOLD · STAND FOLD · STAND FOLD · STAND

TOKENS

8 Sick · 12 Wound · 4 Camp · 4 Bamboo Armor · 4 Ambush · 3 Fallen square · 6 Power ready · 5 Guard · 6 Alarm · 4 Cache · 3 Planted field (0.7 in). Larger markers: Hope, Food, Time, The party, Story cloth count, Phase, Soldiers' number, Damage dealt (0.9 in). Glue to card, coins or wooden discs.

Player aid · side 1

1	2	3	4	5
Season card	**Travel?**	**Actions**	**Winter**	**Time**
draw one, do what it says	before anyone acts; the season ends	2 each, in any order (1 in a Sweep)	eat, the Toll, the council	move the marker one season

Actions · 1 Food (🍚) or free (✋); the whole season (⧖)

Search 🍚 1 Food
Draw the top card of this place's deck. Searched before? Draw a Fortune card first: earlier searches or less brings soldiers.

Scout 🍚 1 Food
Turn one hidden place next to the party face up.

Travel ⧖ the whole season
Before anyone acts: the whole party moves to a known place next to it, draws a Fortune card against its Danger, gathers forage. The season ends.

Forage ✋ free
Take the Food the tile shows for this season, +1. A Fortune card of 1–3: spotted, an ambush.

Rest or nurse ✋ free
Nurse: the fever breaks on 11+ (6+ with medicine; always with Kong B, or Lee or Pa B nursing). Or rest: heal 1 wound (2 at a finished camp).

Build a camp 🍚 1 Food
Two actions finish a hidden camp here: the Toll 1 better, resting heals 1 more.

Side A power 📄 see the card
Once a season (Winter Clothes once a year). Side B traits are always on.

Play a card or give an item ✋ free
Play a DEF or HP card for the next fight, or hand an item to someone in the party (free when it is found).

Waiting, trading and the end

Lay an ambush 🕒 limited
Once at each place: the next fight here, you fire first.

Cover tracks 🕒 limited
Once a season: searching here again counts 2 fewer earlier searches.

Trade ✋ free
Lao village, hamlet, road or ferry: any item for 3 Food. A Fortune card of 1–3: an informer, fight at the place's level.

Share a meal 🍚 2 Food
Once a season: 2 Food for Hope +1.

Seek help 🕒 limited
Once a season: draw a Stranger and choose one of two answers together.

Escape card ✋ free
When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it from your hand: the party slips away, no fight.

Cross the Mekong ⧖ the whole season
With all nine squares, from any river place: the River Patrol, then each person walks the river lane.

Soldiers, the Toll and the river are on side 2. Keep this card face up in front of you.

Player aid · side 1

CHAO FA · A SEASON

1	2	3	4	5
Season card	**Travel?**	**Actions**	**Winter**	**Time**
draw one, do what it says	before anyone acts; the season ends	2 each, in any order (1 in a Sweep)	eat, the Toll, the council	move the marker one season

Actions · 1 Food (🍚) or free (✋); the whole season (⧖)

Search 🍚 1 Food
Draw the top card of this place's deck. Searched before? Draw a Fortune card first: earlier searches or less brings soldiers.

Scout 🍚 1 Food
Turn one hidden place next to the party face up.

Travel ⧖ the whole season
Before anyone acts: the whole party moves to a known place next to it, draws a Fortune card against its Danger, gathers forage. The season ends.

Forage ✋ free
Take the Food the tile shows for this season, +1. A Fortune card of 1–3: spotted, an ambush.

Rest or nurse ✋ free
Nurse: the fever breaks on 11+ (6+ with medicine; always with Kong B, or Lee or Pa B nursing). Or rest: heal 1 wound (2 at a finished camp).

Build a camp 🍚 1 Food
Two actions finish a hidden camp here: the Toll 1 better, resting heals 1 more.

Side A power 📄 see the card
Once a season (Winter Clothes once a year). Side B traits are always on.

Play a card or give an item ✋ free
Play a DEF or HP card for the next fight, or hand an item to someone in the party (free when it is found).

Waiting, trading and the end

Lay an ambush 🕒 limited
Once at each place: the next fight here, you fire first.

Cover tracks 🕒 limited
Once a season: searching here again counts 2 fewer earlier searches.

Trade ✋ free
Lao village, hamlet, road or ferry: any item for 3 Food. A Fortune card of 1–3: an informer, fight at the place's level.

Share a meal 🍚 2 Food
Once a season: 2 Food for Hope +1.

Seek help 🕒 limited
Once a season: draw a Stranger and choose one of two answers together.

Escape card ✋ free
When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it from your hand: the party slips away, no fight.

Cross the Mekong ⧖ the whole season
With all nine squares, from any river place: the River Patrol, then each person walks the river lane.

Soldiers, the Toll and the river are on side 2. Keep this card face up in front of you.

Player aid · side 2

Soldiers · the Patrol table

The fight	1975–76 · living villagers						from 1977 · living villagers					
	1	2	3	4	5	6	1	2	3	4	5	6
Easy	1	1	2	4	6	9	1	3	5	9	13	19
Medium	1	2	3	5	7	10	2	4	6	10	14	20
Hard	5	6	7	9	11	14	6	8	10	14	18	24
Deadly	8	9	10	12	14	17	9	11	13	17	21	27
River Patrol	8	9	10	12	14	14	9	11	13	17	21	21

The row is the fight, the column is how many of you are living, the block is the year. That one number is the soldiers' ATK, DEF and HP alike; nothing is added. (Gentle: every number −3. Merciless: +3.)

Fights and noise

- **1 · The soldiers**: one number from the Patrol table (the row is the fight, the column your living villagers, the block the year) is their ATK, DEF and HP. Nothing is added. Add up the party's ATK, DEF and HP.
- **2 · Clash**, up to 3 times: draw 1 Fortune card (1–4: soldiers +2 ATK; 17–20: party +2 ATK). You deal your ATK minus their number; they deal their number minus your DEF, **always at least 1**. You choose who is hit; Armor stops it first.
- **3 · The cost**: their damage reaches their number = you win and search here in safety (Easy 1, Medium 2, Hard 3). Still standing after 3 clashes = you break away with your wounds, nothing gained.
- **Ambush** (found travelling, spotted foraging, Ambush card): they fire first; you deal nothing in clash 1. Laid an ambush here: you fire first.
- **Prisoner**: a villager who falls in a fight (not the river) draws a Fortune card: 1–10 killed, 11–20 taken prisoner (Ending 4). Either way, everything they carried is lost.
- **Break away** (after clash 1 or 2): discard one item per living villager instead of taking their hit; the fight ends, nothing gained.
- **Shakedown** (Easy fights only): hand over 2 Food or one money item and walk on. No fight.
- **Loud weapons**: a fight with any loud weapon puts an Alarm token on the place: the next fight there is one row harder. A fight in a village, hamlet or on the plain closes its market.
- **Night** (Travel by Night, after moving): the soldiers' number and your ATK are both 1 lower. **A carried child**: the carrier has one hand and ATK −1; the child cannot be hit.
- **Noise**: searching a place again, a Fortune card at or under its earlier searches = soldiers (no spoils).

The Toll and the river

- **Toll**: each person draws a Fortune card, falls Sick on 5 or less. +1 child, elder, wounded or sick; +1 per Food short (max 3); +cold (1975 0, 76–77 +1, 78–79 +2); Hope 0 +2, 1–2 +1, 5–6 −1; healer −1; finished camp −1; warm items up to −2. Sick and taken again: dies.
- **Guard tokens**: when a key encounter is drawn and left, its guard token goes on the tile so the table sees where the keys are.
- **Keys**: every key is guarded, one step harder than its place (hard → deadly); a win recovers the next square of the story cloth. **River**: need all 9 squares (sewn at the start: a party of 6 has squares 1–2, 5 has 1–3, 4 has 1–4, 3 has 1–5; Short Trail 3 more), on any river place. A fallen carrier's squares go into the top 3 of that place's search deck. 1 Hope lets one person draw again at the current or when drowning. River Patrol: its own row of the Patrol table, no escape cards; up to 3 clashes; still standing = cross under fire (no Boatman). Each person: 1) the water: Fortune card 1–2 killed, 3–4 wounded (+4 under fire); 2) draw a River card, most end in the current check: swept on 13; monsoon +4, child/elder/sick/wounded +2, boat −6, raft −3, crossing place −3; 3) swept: drowned on 12; monsoon +3, vulnerable +2, line from far bank −2, raft/boat −2.
- **Non-swimmers**: swept away, they drown 2 worse unless they hold a float item. **Pairs**: two may walk the lane on one set of draws; a child must be paired. Swept away as a pair: both are.
- **Low water** (Spring, not monsoon): the current is 2 better. **The tributary** (lowlands to river, Summer or Fall): a Fortune card, on 1–2 the heaviest load loses an item.
- **Boat**: four seats a trip; a second trip meets the River Patrol again. **Washed up**: swept away and drawing 18 or more, you reach the Thai bank alone with nothing.

Player aid · side 2

CHAO FA · THE TRAIL

Soldiers · the Patrol table

The fight	1975–76 · living villagers						from 1977 · living villagers					
	1	2	3	4	5	6	1	2	3	4	5	6
Easy	1	1	2	4	6	9	1	3	5	9	13	19
Medium	1	2	3	5	7	10	2	4	6	10	14	20
Hard	5	6	7	9	11	14	6	8	10	14	18	24
Deadly	8	9	10	12	14	17	9	11	13	17	21	27
River Patrol	8	9	10	12	14	14	9	11	13	17	21	21

The row is the fight, the column is how many of you are living, the block is the year. That one number is the soldiers' ATK, DEF and HP alike; nothing is added. (Gentle: every number −3. Merciless: +3.)

Fights and noise

- **1 · The soldiers**: one number from the Patrol table (the row is the fight, the column your living villagers, the block the year) is their ATK, DEF and HP. Nothing is added. Add up the party's ATK, DEF and HP.
- **2 · Clash**, up to 3 times: draw 1 Fortune card (1–4: soldiers +2 ATK; 17–20: party +2 ATK). You deal your ATK minus their number; they deal their number minus your DEF, **always at least 1**. You choose who is hit; Armor stops it first.
- **3 · The cost**: their damage reaches their number = you win and search here in safety (Easy 1, Medium 2, Hard 3). Still standing after 3 clashes = you break away with your wounds, nothing gained.
- **Ambush** (found travelling, spotted foraging, Ambush card): they fire first; you deal nothing in clash 1. Laid an ambush here: you fire first.
- **Prisoner**: a villager who falls in a fight (not the river) draws a Fortune card: 1–10 killed, 11–20 taken prisoner (Ending 4). Either way, everything they carried is lost.
- **Break away** (after clash 1 or 2): discard one item per living villager instead of taking their hit; the fight ends, nothing gained.
- **Shakedown** (Easy fights only): hand over 2 Food or one money item and walk on. No fight.
- **Loud weapons**: a fight with any loud weapon puts an Alarm token on the place: the next fight there is one row harder. A fight in a village, hamlet or on the plain closes its market.
- **Night** (Travel by Night, after moving): the soldiers' number and your ATK are both 1 lower. **A carried child**: the carrier has one hand and ATK −1; the child cannot be hit.
- **Noise**: searching a place again, a Fortune card at or under its earlier searches = soldiers (no spoils).

The Toll and the river

- **Toll**: each person draws a Fortune card, falls Sick on 5 or less. +1 child, elder, wounded or sick; +1 per Food short (max 3); +cold (1975 0, 76–77 +1, 78–79 +2); Hope 0 +2, 1–2 +1, 5–6 −1; healer −1; finished camp −1; warm items up to −2. Sick and taken again: dies.
- **Guard tokens**: when a key encounter is drawn and left, its guard token goes on the tile so the table sees where the keys are.
- **Keys**: every key is guarded, one step harder than its place (hard → deadly); a win recovers the next square of the story cloth. **River**: need all 9 squares (sewn at the start: a party of 6 has squares 1–2, 5 has 1–3, 4 has 1–4, 3 has 1–5; Short Trail 3 more), on any river place. A fallen carrier's squares go into the top 3 of that place's search deck. 1 Hope lets one person draw again at the current or when drowning. River Patrol: its own row of the Patrol table, no escape cards; up to 3 clashes; still standing = cross under fire (no Boatman). Each person: 1) the water: Fortune card 1–2 killed, 3–4 wounded (+4 under fire); 2) draw a River card, most end in the current check: swept on 13; monsoon +4, child/elder/sick/wounded +2, boat −6, raft −3, crossing place −3; 3) swept: drowned on 12; monsoon +3, vulnerable +2, line from far bank −2, raft/boat −2.
- **Non-swimmers**: swept away, they drown 2 worse unless they hold a float item. **Pairs**: two may walk the lane on one set of draws; a child must be paired. Swept away as a pair: both are.
- **Low water** (Spring, not monsoon): the current is 2 better. **The tributary** (lowlands to river, Summer or Fall): a Fortune card, on 1–2 the heaviest load loses an item.
- **Boat**: four seats a trip; a second trip meets the River Patrol again. **Washed up**: swept away and drawing 18 or more, you reach the Thai bank alone with nothing.

A season, actions and powers are on side 1.

Player aid · side 1

CHAO FA · A SEASON

1	2	3	4	5
Season card draw one, do what it says	**Travel?** before anyone acts; the season ends	**Actions** 2 each, in any order (1 in a Sweep)	**Winter** eat, the Toll, the council	**Time** move the marker one season

Actions · 1 Food (🍚) or free (✋); the whole season (⌛)

Search 🍚 1 Food
Draw the top card of this place's deck. Searched before? Draw a Fortune card first: earlier searches or less brings soldiers.

Travel ⌛ the whole season
Before anyone acts: the whole party moves to a known place next to it, draws a Fortune card against its Danger, gathers forage. The season ends.

Rest or nurse ✋ free
Nurse: the fever breaks on 11+ (6+ with medicine; always with Kong B, or Lee or Pa B nursing). Or rest: heal 1 wound (2 at a finished camp).

Side A power 📄 see the card
Once a season (Winter Clothes once a year). Side B traits are always on.

Scout 🍚 1 Food
Turn one hidden place next to the party face up.

Forage ✋ free
Take the Food the tile shows for this season, +1. A Fortune card of 1–3: spotted, an ambush.

Build a camp 🍚 1 Food
Two actions finish a hidden camp here: the Toll 1 better, resting heals 1 more.

Play a card or give an item ✋ free
Play a DEF or HP card for the next fight, or hand an item to someone in the party (free when it is found).

Waiting, trading and the end

Lay an ambush 🕒 limited
Once at each place: the next fight here, you fire first.

Trade ✋ free
Lao village, hamlet, road or ferry: any item for 3 Food. A Fortune card of 1–3: an informer, fight at the place's level.

Seek help 🕒 limited
Once a season: draw a Stranger and choose one of two answers together.

Cross the Mekong ⌛ the whole season
With all nine squares, from any river place: the River Patrol, then each person walks the river lane.

Cover tracks 🕒 limited
Once a season: searching here again counts 2 fewer earlier searches.

Share a meal 🍚 2 Food
Once a season: 2 Food for Hope +1.

Escape card ✋ free
When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it from your hand: the party slips away, no fight.

Soldiers, the Toll and the river are on side 2. Keep this card face up in front of you.

Player aid · side 1

CHAO FA · A SEASON

1	2	3	4	5
Season card draw one, do what it says	**Travel?** before anyone acts; the season ends	**Actions** 2 each, in any order (1 in a Sweep)	**Winter** eat, the Toll, the council	**Time** move the marker one season

Actions · 1 Food (🍚) or free (✋); the whole season (⌛)

Search 🍚 1 Food
Draw the top card of this place's deck. Searched before? Draw a Fortune card first: earlier searches or less brings soldiers.

Travel ⌛ the whole season
Before anyone acts: the whole party moves to a known place next to it, draws a Fortune card against its Danger, gathers forage. The season ends.

Rest or nurse ✋ free
Nurse: the fever breaks on 11+ (6+ with medicine; always with Kong B, or Lee or Pa B nursing). Or rest: heal 1 wound (2 at a finished camp).

Side A power 📄 see the card
Once a season (Winter Clothes once a year). Side B traits are always on.

Scout 🍚 1 Food
Turn one hidden place next to the party face up.

Forage ✋ free
Take the Food the tile shows for this season, +1. A Fortune card of 1–3: spotted, an ambush.

Build a camp 🍚 1 Food
Two actions finish a hidden camp here: the Toll 1 better, resting heals 1 more.

Play a card or give an item ✋ free
Play a DEF or HP card for the next fight, or hand an item to someone in the party (free when it is found).

Waiting, trading and the end

Lay an ambush 🕒 limited
Once at each place: the next fight here, you fire first.

Trade ✋ free
Lao village, hamlet, road or ferry: any item for 3 Food. A Fortune card of 1–3: an informer, fight at the place's level.

Seek help 🕒 limited
Once a season: draw a Stranger and choose one of two answers together.

Cross the Mekong ⌛ the whole season
With all nine squares, from any river place: the River Patrol, then each person walks the river lane.

Cover tracks 🕒 limited
Once a season: searching here again counts 2 fewer earlier searches.

Share a meal 🍚 2 Food
Once a season: 2 Food for Hope +1.

Escape card ✋ free
When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it from your hand: the party slips away, no fight.

Soldiers, the Toll and the river are on side 2. Keep this card face up in front of you.

Player aid · side 2

Soldiers · the Patrol table

The fight	1975–76 · living villagers						from 1977 · living villagers					
	1	2	3	4	5	6	1	2	3	4	5	6
Easy	1	1	2	4	6	9	1	3	5	9	13	19
Medium	1	2	3	5	7	10	2	4	6	10	14	20
Hard	5	6	7	9	11	14	6	8	10	14	18	24
Deadly	8	9	10	12	14	17	9	11	13	17	21	27
River Patrol	8	9	10	12	14	14	9	11	13	17	21	21

The row is the fight, the column is how many of you are living, the block is the year. That one number is the soldiers' ATK, DEF and HP alike; nothing is added. (Gentle: every number −3. Merciless: +3.)

Fights and noise

- **1 · The soldiers**: one number from the Patrol table (the row is the fight, the column your living villagers, the block the year) is their ATK, DEF and HP. Nothing is added. Add up the party's ATK, DEF and HP.
- **2 · Clash**, up to 3 times: draw 1 Fortune card (1–4: soldiers +2 ATK; 17–20: party +2 ATK). You deal your ATK minus their number; they deal their number minus your DEF, **always at least 1**. You choose who is hit; Armor stops it first.
- **3 · The cost**: their damage reaches their number = you win and search here in safety (Easy 1, Medium 2, Hard 3). Still standing after 3 clashes = you break away with your wounds, nothing gained.
- **Ambush** (found travelling, spotted foraging, Ambush card): they fire first; you deal nothing in clash 1. Laid an ambush here: you fire first.
- **Prisoner**: a villager who falls in a fight (not the river) draws a Fortune card: 1–10 killed, 11–20 taken prisoner (Ending 4). Either way, everything they carried is lost.
- **Break away** (after clash 1 or 2): discard one item per living villager instead of taking their hit; the fight ends, nothing gained.
- **Shakedown** (Easy fights only): hand over 2 Food or one money item and walk on. No fight.
- **Loud weapons**: a fight with any loud weapon puts an Alarm token on the place: the next fight there is one row harder. A fight in a village, hamlet or on the plain closes its market.
- **Night** (Travel by Night, after moving): the soldiers' number and your ATK are both 1 lower. **A carried child**: the carrier has one hand and ATK −1; the child cannot be hit.
- **Noise**: searching a place again, a Fortune card at or under its earlier searches = soldiers (no spoils).

The Toll and the river

- **Toll**: each person draws a Fortune card, falls Sick on 5 or less. +1 child, elder, wounded or sick; +1 per Food short (max 3); +cold (1975 0, 76–77 +1, 78–79 +2); Hope 0 +2, 1–2 +1, 5–6 −1; healer −1; finished camp −1; warm items up to −2. Sick and taken again: dies.
- **Guard tokens**: when a key encounter is drawn and left, its guard token goes on the tile so the table sees where the keys are.
- **Keys**: every key is guarded, one step harder than its place (hard → deadly); a win recovers the next square of the story cloth. **River**: need all 9 squares (sewn at the start: a party of 6 has squares 1–2, 5 has 1–3, 4 has 1–4, 3 has 1–5; Short Trail 3 more), on any river place. A fallen carrier's squares go into the top 3 of that place's search deck. 1 Hope lets one person draw again at the current or when drowning. River Patrol: its own row of the Patrol table, no escape cards; up to 3 clashes; still standing = cross under fire (no Boatman). Each person: 1) the water: Fortune card 1–2 killed, 3–4 wounded (+4 under fire); 2) draw a River card, most end in the current check: swept on 13; monsoon +4, child/elder/sick/wounded +2, boat −6, raft −3, crossing place −3; 3) swept: drowned on 12; monsoon +3, vulnerable +2, line from far bank −2, raft/boat −2.
- **Non-swimmers**: swept away, they drown 2 worse unless they hold a float item. **Pairs**: two may walk the lane on one set of draws; a child must be paired. Swept away as a pair: both are.
- **Low water** (Spring, not monsoon): the current is 2 better. **The tributary** (lowlands to river, Summer or Fall): a Fortune card, on 1–2 the heaviest load loses an item.
- **Boat**: four seats a trip; a second trip meets the River Patrol again. **Washed up**: swept away and drawing 18 or more, you reach the Thai bank alone with nothing.

Player aid · side 2

CHAO FA · THE TRAIL

Soldiers · the Patrol table

The fight	1975–76 · living villagers						from 1977 · living villagers					
	1	2	3	4	5	6	1	2	3	4	5	6
Easy	1	1	2	4	6	9	1	3	5	9	13	19
Medium	1	2	3	5	7	10	2	4	6	10	14	20
Hard	5	6	7	9	11	14	6	8	10	14	18	24
Deadly	8	9	10	12	14	17	9	11	13	17	21	27
River Patrol	8	9	10	12	14	14	9	11	13	17	21	21

The row is the fight, the column is how many of you are living, the block is the year. That one number is the soldiers' ATK, DEF and HP alike; nothing is added. (Gentle: every number −3. Merciless: +3.)

Fights and noise

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- **2 · Clash**, up to 3 times: draw 1 Fortune card (1–4: soldiers +2 ATK; 17–20: party +2 ATK). You deal your ATK minus their number; they deal their number minus your DEF, **always at least 1**. You choose who is hit; Armor stops it first.
- **3 · The cost**: their damage reaches their number = you win and search here in safety (Easy 1, Medium 2, Hard 3). Still standing after 3 clashes = you break away with your wounds, nothing gained.
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- **Prisoner**: a villager who falls in a fight (not the river) draws a Fortune card: 1–10 killed, 11–20 taken prisoner (Ending 4). Either way, everything they carried is lost.
- **Break away** (after clash 1 or 2): discard one item per living villager instead of taking their hit; the fight ends, nothing gained.
- **Shakedown** (Easy fights only): hand over 2 Food or one money item and walk on. No fight.
- **Loud weapons**: a fight with any loud weapon puts an Alarm token on the place: the next fight there is one row harder. A fight in a village, hamlet or on the plain closes its market.
- **Night** (Travel by Night, after moving): the soldiers' number and your ATK are both 1 lower. **A carried child**: the carrier has one hand and ATK −1; the child cannot be hit.
- **Noise**: searching a place again, a Fortune card at or under its earlier searches = soldiers (no spoils).

The Toll and the river

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A season, actions and powers are on side 1.

Player aid · side 1

CHAO FA · A SEASON

1	2	3	4	5
Season card draw one, do what it says	**Travel?** before anyone acts; the season ends	**Actions** 2 each, in any order (1 in a Sweep)	**Winter** eat, the Toll, the council	**Time** move the marker one season

Actions · 1 Food (🍚) or free (✋); the whole season (⧖)

Search 🍚 1 Food
Draw the top card of this place's deck. Searched before? Draw a Fortune card first: earlier searches or less brings soldiers.

Travel ⧖ the whole season
Before anyone acts: the whole party moves to a known place next to it, draws a Fortune card against its Danger, gathers forage. The season ends.

Rest or nurse ✋ free
Nurse: the fever breaks on 11+ (6+ with medicine; always with Kong B, or Lee or Pa B nursing). Or rest: heal 1 wound (2 at a finished camp).

Side A power 📄 see the card
Once a season (Winter Clothes once a year). Side B traits are always on.

Scout 🍚 1 Food
Turn one hidden place next to the party face up.

Forage ✋ free
Take the Food the tile shows for this season, +1. A Fortune card of 1–3: spotted, an ambush.

Build a camp 🍚 1 Food
Two actions finish a hidden camp here: the Toll 1 better, resting heals 1 more.

Play a card or give an item ✋ free
Play a DEF or HP card for the next fight, or hand an item to someone in the party (free when it is found).

Waiting, trading and the end

Lay an ambush 🕒 limited
Once at each place: the next fight here, you fire first.

Trade ✋ free
Lao village, hamlet, road or ferry: any item for 3 Food. A Fortune card of 1–3: an informer, fight at the place's level.

Seek help 🕒 limited
Once a season: draw a Stranger and choose one of two answers together.

Cross the Mekong ⧖ the whole season
With all nine squares, from any river place: the River Patrol, then each person walks the river lane.

Cover tracks 🕒 limited
Once a season: searching here again counts 2 fewer earlier searches.

Share a meal 🍚 2 Food
Once a season: 2 Food for Hope +1.

Escape card ✋ free
When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it from your hand: the party slips away, no fight.

Soldiers, the Toll and the river are on side 2. Keep this card face up in front of you.

Player aid · side 1

CHAO FA · A SEASON

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Season card draw one, do what it says	**Travel?** before anyone acts; the season ends	**Actions** 2 each, in any order (1 in a Sweep)	**Winter** eat, the Toll, the council	**Time** move the marker one season

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Player aid · side 2

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Player aid · side 2

CHAO FA · THE TRAIL

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CHAO FA

The story cloth · paj ntaub dab neeg

Nine squares, each one stage of the escape. Print this mat at 100% (it is 7.5 in square) and lay the nine square cards on it as they are recovered; or cut the mat into its nine squares and use them as the pieces. All nine, laid out 1 to 9, earn the crossing.

SQUARES STILL TO FIND

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

move the cloth marker down one each time a square is sewn; at 0, the party may Cross

A party of 6 starts with squares 1 and 2 already sewn; 5 with 1 to 3; 4 with 1 to 4; 3 with 1 to 5. The squares are our own drawings in the style of the cloths first stitched in the Thai refugee camps, not copied from any real cloth.

1. The Village

1961 TO 1975 · BEFORE

Families farmed the mountain slopes. From 1961 the men were recruited into a secret army; by 1969 it counted about 39,000, and planes dropped rice to the hill airstrips when the fields could no longer be farmed.

2. The Last Planes

MAY 1975 · LEFT BEHIND

On 14 May 1975 about 2,500 officers and their families were flown out of Long Tieng. Most soldiers and their families were left at their posts and had to walk.

3. The Soldiers Come

1975 ONWARD · THE NEW GOVERNMENT

Many officers and officials were sent to re-education "seminars" in remote camps, where many were starved or worked to death. At the Hin Heup bridge, soldiers fired on Hmong marching toward Vientiane.

4. Into the Forest

1975 TO 1976 · PHOU BIA

Others went into the forest. Former soldiers joined the Chao Fa, and Phou Bia, the highest mountain in Laos, became their stronghold. Whole villages hid with them.

5. Hiding

1975 TO 1980 · IN THE JUNGLE

Families hid in the jungle with the fighters and moved on whenever the soldiers came close. One oral history speaks of more than 100,000 people in the jungles.

6. Fire from the Sky

1977 TO 1978 · THE OFFENSIVES

Vietnamese regiments were sent against Phou Bia, and thousands were killed or captured. Refugees told of "yellow rain" from aircraft; what it was is still disputed.

7. The Walk South

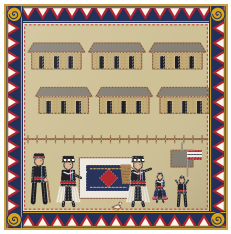
1975 TO 1980 · THE WAY OUT

Families walked for weeks toward the Mekong, carrying children and what they could. Up to a third of the Hmong of Laos left the country.

8. The Crossing

1975 TO 1992 · THE MEKONG

They crossed at night on bamboo floats, rafts or hired boats, and were shot at from the Lao bank. No one counted how many drowned. UNHCR counted 211,344 people from Laos reaching Thailand from 1975 to 1979.

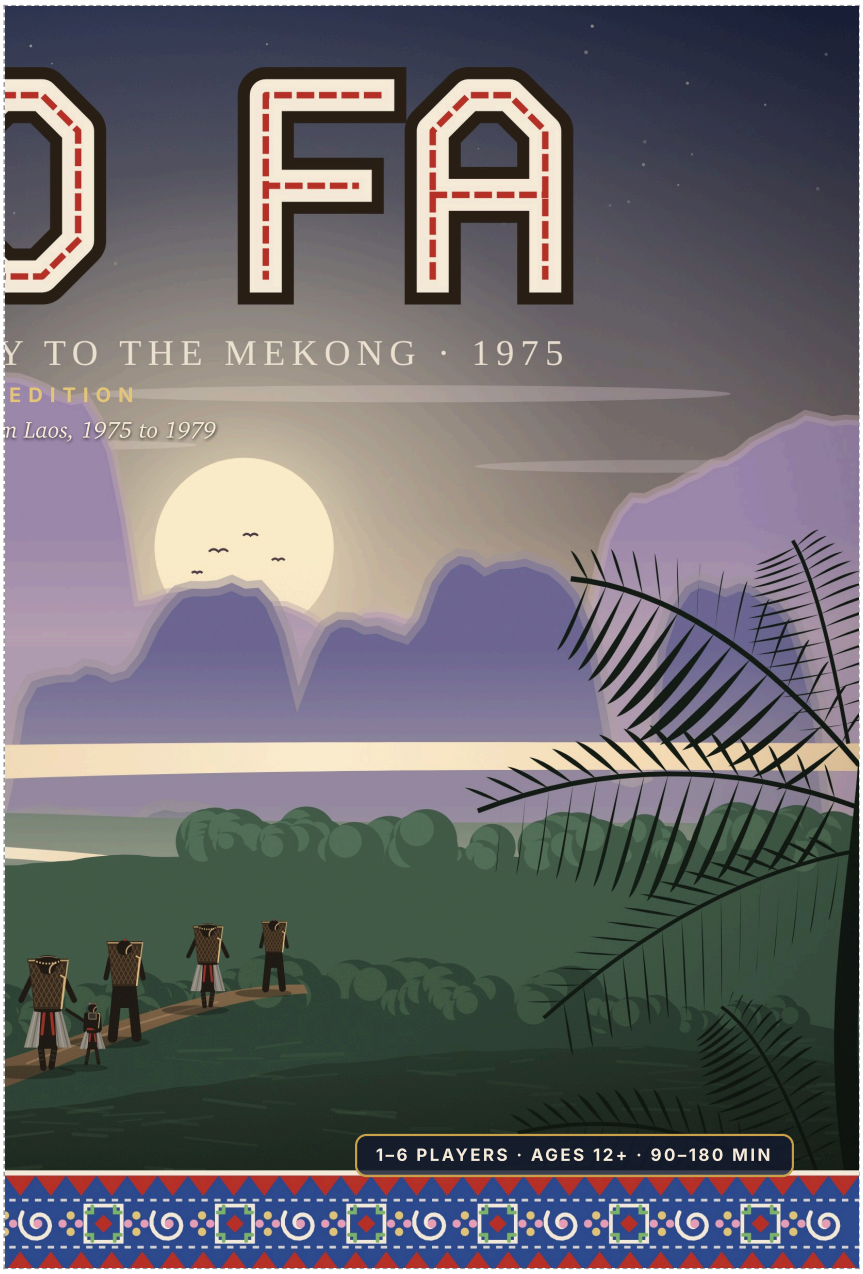


9. The Camp

1975 TO 1992 · BAN VINAI

Ban Vinai held 42,858 people at its peak, 90 percent of them Hmong, and families waited years for a country to take them. In the Thai camps they began to stitch story cloths like this one, so the story would not be lost.

CHAO FA · box · top, left half · cut on the dashed line; the two halves meet with no overlap, tape on the back, then wrap the box



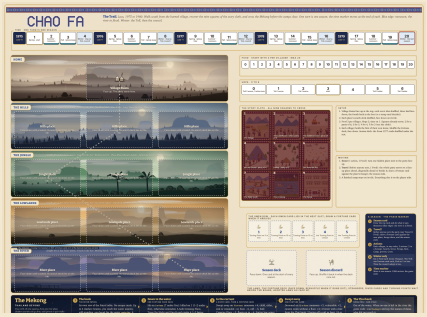
CHAO FA · box · top, right half · cut on the dashed line; the two halves meet with no overlap, tape on the back, then wrap the box

CHAO FA

THE TRAIL · A COOPERATIVE JOURNEY TO THE MEKONG

SECOND EDITION

Laos, 1975. It is 1975. Th
Americans. Your village is
place for food, tools and
squares of the story cloth
game for 1 to 6 players, b



THE BOARD

T

IN THE BOX

16 Villager cards · Side A on the front, Side B on the back, the clan and the family on each

249 Search cards · one deck for each of the 16 places

85 Season cards

13 Stranger cards

9 Story cloth squares · and the cloth mat

21 River cards

6 Turning Point cards

16 Ending and Voice cards

18 Law and reference cards

1 Board · 21 × 16 in, with the phase track, the Omen row and the Mekong lane

16 Place tiles · three places a row are laid, one goes back in the box

16 Standees

67 Tokens · Sick, Wound, Camp, squares, power discs, guard, ala markers

3 Setup and scenario cards · tw crossing

3 Symbol key cards

20 Fortune cards · numbered 1 t

6 Player aids

4 Fight trackers and Patrol cards

6 Family boards

1 Deck dividers, bag labels and i

2 Trail diary and family record ·

1 Rule Hike Winter reprinted fr

3 Rulebook, Companion and End

Card sleeves · standard poker si

1–6 PLAYERS · AGES 12+ · 90–180 MINUTES · COOPERATIVE CARD GAME

CHAO FA · box · back, left half · cut on the dashed line; the two halves meet with no overlap, tape on the back, then wrap the box

he war is over and the soldiers are coming for the families who fought beside the
s burning. Walk south through the hills, the jungle and the lowlands; search each
the people who can help; keep hope alive through five winters; recover the nine
; and cross the Mekong before the camps close. Chao Fa is a cooperative survival
ased on real-life stories. Most who set out will not reach the far bank.

HE CARDS

STANDEES AND TOKENS

, Armor, Ambush, fallen
rm, cache, planted field,

o historical trails and the late

o 20, the game's only chance

s

nsert diagram · set
oads
game
dings booklet
ze, 63 × 88 mm, if you sleeve

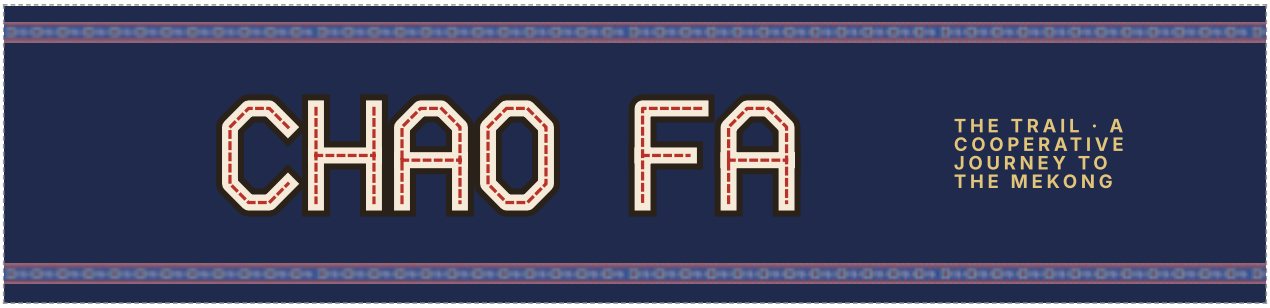
DEDICATION

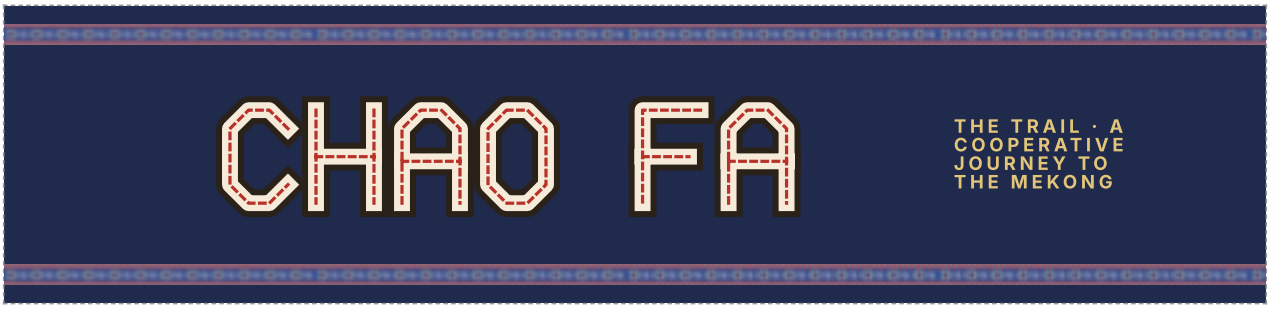
This game is dedicated to all the men and women who served in the Vietnam War; to the Hmong who served and were killed; to those who died in the jungles of Laos and those who are still there; to the CIA, to General Vang Pao, and to everyone who brought attention to this tragic chapter of history.

ABOUT THE HISTORY

The endings, the Voice cards and the companion book tell what really happened, based on true stories; disputed claims say so. All artwork is original to this game.

CHAO FA · box · back, right half · cut on the dashed line; the two halves meet with no overlap, tape on the back, then wrap the box





short sides (8.5 × 2 in) and the left half of long side 1

right half of long side 1, then long side 2 in two halves (11.5 × 2 in each, join with no overlap)

Fight tracker

CHAO FA · THREE STEPS

1 The soldiers' number

Read it once from the Patrol table (row: the fight · column: living villagers · face: the year). Put the **brass marker** on it. It is their ATK, DEF and HP alike; nothing is added.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

PARTY ATK | PARTY DEF | PARTY HP

Every living villager, their items and any DEF or HP card played. Dry-wipe pen or a token.

2 Clash, up to three times

1–4 · soldiers +2 ATK | 5–16 · even | 17–20 · party +2 ATK

FORTUNE CARD CLASH 1

You deal your ATK (+2 on 17–20) − their number. Ambush: you deal nothing this clash.

They deal their number (+2 on 1–4) − your DEF, **at least 1**.

HIT _____ armor first

FORTUNE CARD CLASH 2

You deal your ATK (+2 on 17–20) − their number.

They deal their number (+2 on 1–4) − your DEF, **at least 1**.

HIT _____ armor first

FORTUNE CARD CLASH 3

You deal your ATK (+2 on 17–20) − their number.

They deal their number (+2 on 1–4) − your DEF, **at least 1**.

HIT _____ armor first

3 The cost

Move the **second marker** up this strip as you deal damage. When it **reaches the brass marker**, the soldiers fall: search here in safety (Easy 1 · Medium 2 · Hard 3). Still standing after clash 3: break away with your wounds, nothing gained.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

Who is hit (if the table would rather not choose): Armor first, then the villager with the most HP, children last. After clash 1 or 2 the party may break away: discard one item per living villager, no hit, nothing gained. Someone who falls draws a Fortune card: 1–10 killed, 11–20 taken prisoner (Ending 4); their things are lost either way. The River Patrol: no escape cards; after 3 clashes you break for the water under fire.

Fight tracker

CHAO FA · THREE STEPS

1 The soldiers' number

Read it once from the Patrol table (row: the fight · column: living villagers · face: the year). Put the **brass marker** on it. It is their ATK, DEF and HP alike; nothing is added.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

PARTY ATK | PARTY DEF | PARTY HP

Every living villager, their items and any DEF or HP card played. Dry-wipe pen or a token.

2 Clash, up to three times

1–4 · soldiers +2 ATK | 5–16 · even | 17–20 · party +2 ATK

FORTUNE CARD CLASH 1

You deal your ATK (+2 on 17–20) − their number. Ambush: you deal nothing this clash.

They deal their number (+2 on 1–4) − your DEF, **at least 1**.

HIT _____ armor first

FORTUNE CARD CLASH 2

You deal your ATK (+2 on 17–20) − their number.

They deal their number (+2 on 1–4) − your DEF, **at least 1**.

HIT _____ armor first

FORTUNE CARD CLASH 3

You deal your ATK (+2 on 17–20) − their number.

They deal their number (+2 on 1–4) − your DEF, **at least 1**.

HIT _____ armor first

3 The cost

Move the **second marker** up this strip as you deal damage. When it **reaches the brass marker**, the soldiers fall: search here in safety (Easy 1 · Medium 2 · Hard 3). Still standing after clash 3: break away with your wounds, nothing gained.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

Who is hit (if the table would rather not choose): Armor first, then the villager with the most HP, children last. After clash 1 or 2 the party may break away: discard one item per living villager, no hit, nothing gained. Someone who falls draws a Fortune card: 1–10 killed, 11–20 taken prisoner (Ending 4); their things are lost either way. The River Patrol: no escape cards; after 3 clashes you break for the water under fire.

CHAO FA

FIGHT TRACKER

CHAO FA

FIGHT TRACKER

The Patrol table

CHAO FA · THE SOLDIERS' NUMBER

1975 and 1976

FACE 1 · PATHET LAO PATROLS AND VILLAGE MILITIA · FLIP IN SPRING 1977

LIVING VILLAGERS · SET A MARKER HERE, MOVE IT ONLY AT A DEATH: 1 2 3 4 5 6

THE FIGHT	1	2	3	4	5	6
EASY I	1	1	2	4	6	9
MEDIUM II	1	2	3	5	7	10
HARD III	5	6	7	9	11	14
DEADLY IIII	8	9	10	12	14	17
RIVER PATROL ~	8	9	10	12	14	14

The row is the fight, the column is how many of you are living. That one number is the soldiers' ATK, DEF and HP alike. Nothing is added. An Alarm token on the place: one row down. Easy fights are militia: hand over 2 Food or one money item and walk on. Gentle: every number −3. Merciless: +3.

Find the row colour, read the number under the marker. The River Patrol row is the crossing; its last two columns are the same.

The Patrol table

CHAO FA · THE SOLDIERS' NUMBER

1975 and 1976

FACE 1 · PATHET LAO PATROLS AND VILLAGE MILITIA · FLIP IN SPRING 1977

LIVING VILLAGERS · SET A MARKER HERE, MOVE IT ONLY AT A DEATH: 1 2 3 4 5 6

THE FIGHT	1	2	3	4	5	6
EASY I	1	1	2	4	6	9
MEDIUM II	1	2	3	5	7	10
HARD III	5	6	7	9	11	14
DEADLY IIII	8	9	10	12	14	17
RIVER PATROL ~	8	9	10	12	14	14

The row is the fight, the column is how many of you are living. That one number is the soldiers' ATK, DEF and HP alike. Nothing is added. An Alarm token on the place: one row down. Easy fights are militia: hand over 2 Food or one money item and walk on. Gentle: every number −3. Merciless: +3.

Find the row colour, read the number under the marker. The River Patrol row is the crossing; its last two columns are the same.

The Patrol table

CHAO FA · THE SOLDIERS' NUMBER

From 1977

FACE 2 · THE LAO PEOPLE'S ARMY AND VIETNAMESE UNITS · THE HUNT DOUBLES

LIVING VILLAGERS · SET A MARKER HERE, MOVE IT ONLY AT A DEATH

1	2	3	4	5	6

THE FIGHT	1	2	3	4	5	6
EASY I	1	3	5	9	13	19
MEDIUM II	2	4	6	10	14	20
HARD III	6	8	10	14	18	24
DEADLY IIII	9	11	13	17	21	27
RIVER PATROL ~	9	11	13	17	21	21

After the treaty with Vietnam in 1977, Vietnamese regiments joined the Lao army in the hills around Phou Bia, and the sweeps became a war. The numbers on this face are the other face's, doubled.

Find the row colour, read the number under the marker. The River Patrol row is the crossing; its last two columns are the same.

The Patrol table

CHAO FA · THE SOLDIERS' NUMBER

From 1977

FACE 2 · THE LAO PEOPLE'S ARMY AND VIETNAMESE UNITS · THE HUNT DOUBLES

LIVING VILLAGERS · SET A MARKER HERE, MOVE IT ONLY AT A DEATH

1	2	3	4	5	6

THE FIGHT	1	2	3	4	5	6
EASY I	1	3	5	9	13	19
MEDIUM II	2	4	6	10	14	20
HARD III	6	8	10	14	18	24
DEADLY IIII	9	11	13	17	21	27
RIVER PATROL ~	9	11	13	17	21	21

After the treaty with Vietnam in 1977, Vietnamese regiments joined the Lao army in the hills around Phou Bia, and the sweeps became a war. The numbers on this face are the other face's, doubled.

Find the row colour, read the number under the marker. The River Patrol row is the crossing; its last two columns are the same.

Family board

CHAO FA · ONE VILLAGER

LAY THE VILLAGER CARD HERE
SIDE A OR SIDE B FACE UP

HP LEFT
wounds move the cube down

0	1	2	3	4	5	6

SICK · 1 ACTION, NURSE OR DRAW FOR FEVER

HUNGRY · WENT SHORT AT THE WINTER MEAL

SIDE A POWER · READY

USED THIS SEASON · BACK AT THE NEXT

CARRY SLOTS · LAY EACH ITEM CARD ON ITS SLOT

HANDS · A RIFLE, BOW OR SPEAR TAKES BOTH; A KNIFE, MACHETE, AXE OR CANE ONE

BODY · JACKET, VEST, ARMOR

HEAD · HAT, HELMET

PACK · THE KAWM BASKET, 1 OF 3

PACK · 2 OF 3

PACK · 3 OF 3

SHARED · ANIMALS, BOATS, RAFT WOOD: NO SLOT

Too much? Hand an item on (1 action, free when it is found) or leave it. Armor on the body or head stops that much damage each fight; armored villagers stand in front.

VILLAGER · PLAYED BY

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9

SQUARES OF THE STORY CLOTH THIS VILLAGER CARRIES

Set the HP cube on the card's HP at the start. At 0 the villager dies. Each Spring everyone who ate heals 1; Rest heals 1 (2 at a finished camp).

Family board

CHAO FA · ONE VILLAGER

LAY THE VILLAGER CARD HERE
SIDE A OR SIDE B FACE UP

HP LEFT
wounds move the cube down

0	1	2	3	4	5	6

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BODY · JACKET, VEST, ARMOR

HEAD · HAT, HELMET

PACK · THE KAWM BASKET, 1 OF 3

PACK · 2 OF 3

PACK · 3 OF 3

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Family board

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BODY · JACKET, VEST, ARMOR

HEAD · HAT, HELMET

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PACK · 2 OF 3

PACK · 3 OF 3

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Too much? Hand an item on (1 action, free when it is found) or leave it. Armor on the body or head stops that much damage each fight; armored villagers stand in front.

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SIDE A OR SIDE B FACE UP

HP LEFT
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SQUARES OF THE STORY CLOTH THIS VILLAGER CARRIES

Set the HP cube on the card's HP at the start. At 0 the villager dies. Each Spring everyone who ate heals 1; Rest heals 1 (2 at a finished camp).

Village Ruins 19 CARDS

Village Ruins

Home · 19 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Swidden Fields 17 CARDS

Swidden Fields

The hills · 17 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Pine Ridge 14 CARDS

Pine Ridge

The hills · 14 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Long Tieng Airstrip 12 CARDS

Long Tieng Airstrip

The hills · 12 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Bamboo Forest 13 CARDS

Bamboo Forest

The jungle · 13 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle 17 CARDS

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle

The jungle · 17 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Limestone Caves 19 CARDS

Limestone Caves

The jungle · 19 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Lao Farm Village 23 CARDS

Lao Farm Village

The lowlands · 23 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Hin Heup Bridge 18 CARDS

Hin Heup Bridge

The lowlands · 18 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Nam Xan Valley 15 CARDS

Nam Xan Valley

The lowlands · 15 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

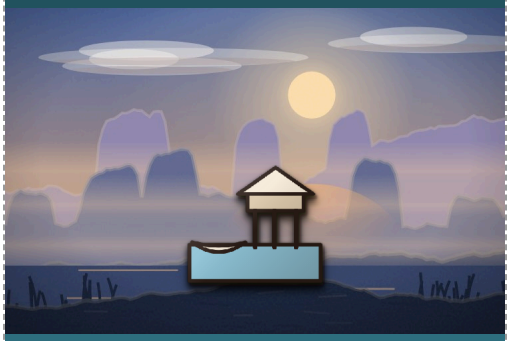
Mekong Reeds 15 CARDS

Mekong Reeds

The river · 15 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Fishing Hamlet 14 CARDS



Fishing Hamlet

The river · 14 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Tha Deua Ferry 12 CARDS

Tha Deua Ferry

The river · 12 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Plain of Jars 13 CARDS

Plain of Jars

The hills · 13 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

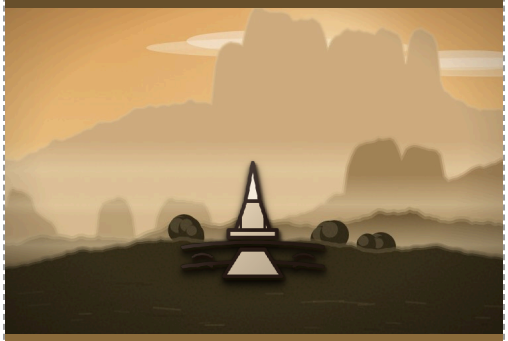
Phou Bia Slopes 14 CARDS

Phou Bia Slopes

The jungle · 14 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Vientiane Plain 14 CARDS



Vientiane Plain

The lowlands · 14 cards · search deck

Lies on its tile, face down. Shuffle before the game.

Season deck 85 CARDS

Season deck

One each season · 85 cards

Draw one at the start of every season. Reshuffle the discard when it runs out.

Fortune deck 20 CARDS, 1 TO 20

Fortune deck

Hmoov · the only chance · 20 cards, 1 to 20

Draw wherever the game asks for a check. Reshuffle when it runs out, not before.

Strangers 13 CARDS

Strangers

Seek help · 13 cards

Drawn with the Seek help action.

Laws 6 CARDS

Laws

Winter council · 6 cards

Each Winter the council draws 2 and may adopt one.

Turning Points 6 CARDS

Turning Points

When the omens come true · 6 cards

Shuffle, draw one, once a game.

River cards 21 CARDS

River cards

The crossing · 21 cards · 3 monsoon

Stays in the box until the river. One per person in the current.

Villagers 16 CARDS

Villagers

Side A · Side B · 16 cards

Chosen at setup with the family boards. A first party: Chai, Mai, Chao, Blong (the First Winter); for five add Tou; for six Kong. After your first game: Ka, Pa, Cheng, Lee.

Setup and reference 3 SETUP

Setup and reference

Trails · scenario · key · 3 setup · 3 key · 6 reference

Two historical trails, the Late Crossing, the symbol key and the reference cards.

Story cloth 9 SQUARES

Story cloth

Paj ntaub dab neeg · 9 squares · the mat

The squares sewn at the start go on the mat; the rest wait here.

Endings and Voices 2 ENDINGS

Endings and Voices

After the game · 2 endings · 14 voices · reference

Stays in the box until the game ends, with the Endings booklet.

CHAO FA · bag labels · label stock or paper and tape

Village Ruins
HOME · 19 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Swidden Fields
THE HILLS · 17 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Pine Ridge
THE HILLS · 14 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Long Tieng Airstrip
THE HILLS · 12 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Bamboo Forest
THE JUNGLE · 13 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle
THE JUNGLE · 17 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Limestone Caves
THE JUNGLE · 19 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Lao Farm Village
THE LOWLANDS · 23 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Hin Heup Bridge
THE LOWLANDS · 18 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Nam Xan Valley
THE LOWLANDS · 15 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Mekong Reeds
THE RIVER · 15 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Fishing Hamlet
THE RIVER · 14 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Tha Deua Ferry
THE RIVER · 12 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Plain of Jars
THE HILLS · 13 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Phou Bia Slopes
THE JUNGLE · 14 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Vientiane Plain
THE LOWLANDS · 14 CARDS · SEARCH DECK

Season deck
ONE EACH SEASON · 85 CARDS

Fortune deck
HMOOV · THE ONLY CHANCE · 20 CARDS, 1 TO 20

Strangers
SEEK HELP · 13 CARDS

Laws
WINTER COUNCIL · 6 CARDS

Turning Points
WHEN THE OMENS COME TRUE · 6 CARDS

River cards
THE CROSSING · 21 CARDS · 3 MONSOON

Villagers
SIDE A · SIDE B · 16 CARDS

Setup and reference
TRAILS · SCENARIO · KEY · 3 SETUP · 3 KEY · 6 REFERENCE

Story cloth
PAJ NTAUB DAB NEEG · 9 SQUARES · THE MAT

Endings and Voices
AFTER THE GAME · 2 ENDINGS · 14 VOICES · REFERENCE

Inside the box · where everything lives

Glue this sheet inside the lid. Decks stay behind their dividers (or in their bags), so setup is laying out the tiles, shuffling the search decks onto them, and taking the cards for your villagers. The two red zones stay in the box until the game asks for them.

Villagers and boards

16 villager cards, 6 family boards (on top of the lid line), the player aids, the fight tracker and the Patrol card.

Search decks · home, hills, jungle

Village Ruins · Swidden Fields · Pine Ridge · Long Tieng Airstrip · Bamboo Forest · Phou Khao Khouay Jungle · Limestone Caves, each behind its divider or in its bag.

Every season

Season deck · Fortune deck · Strangers · Laws · Turning Points.

Search decks · lowlands, river

Lao Farm Village · Hin Heup Bridge · Nam Xan Valley · Mekong Reeds · Fishing Hamlet · Tha Deua Ferry.

Until the river

River cards (3 monsoon cards apart).

The board, folded, and the tiles

Four board sheets or the mounted board; 13 place tiles; the story cloth mat and its 9 squares.

Standees and tokens

16 standees, tokens, markers, the HP cubes, the brass fight markers, the fallen-square tokens, dry-wipe pen.

The books

Rulebook · Companion · The First Winter · the diary pad and family record sheets.

Until the end

Endings booklet · Ending and Voice cards. Nobody opens these before the game is over.

Box inside: 11.25 × 8.25 in, 2 in deep.

Red: not needed until the river, or until the end.

Bags: one per search deck, labelled; the dividers sort them in a card tray instead.

The trail diary

CHAO FA · ONE LINE A SEASON

Few families wrote anything down on the trail; the story was told afterwards, in the camps, and stitched into cloth. Write it here as you go, one line a season: where you are, who is hurt, what you chose. At each Winter note the Food and Hope you went into the cold with. When the game ends, read the diary aloud before the Endings booklet.

THE FAMILY _____ PLAYERS _____ LEVEL _____ DATE PLAYED _____

1 · Spring 1975
NPLOOJ HLAV

2 · Summer 1975
LUB CAIJ NTUJ NAG

3 · Fall 1975
NPLOOJ ZEEG

4 · Winter 1975
NTUJ NO
FOOD ☐ HOPE ☐

5 · Spring 1976
NPLOOJ HLAV

6 · Summer 1976
LUB CAIJ NTUJ NAG

7 · Fall 1976
NPLOOJ ZEEG

8 · Winter 1976
NTUJ NO
FOOD ☐ HOPE ☐

9 · Spring 1977
NPLOOJ HLAV

10 · Summer 1977
LUB CAIJ NTUJ NAG

11 · Fall 1977
NPLOOJ ZEEG

12 · Winter 1977
NTUJ NO
FOOD ☐ HOPE ☐

13 · Spring 1978
NPLOOJ HLAV

14 · Summer 1978
LUB CAIJ NTUJ NAG

15 · Fall 1978
NPLOOJ ZEEG

16 · Winter 1978
NTUJ NO
FOOD ☐ HOPE ☐

17 · Spring 1979
NPLOOJ HLAV

18 · Summer 1979
LUB CAIJ NTUJ NAG

19 · Fall 1979
NPLOOJ ZEEG

20 · Winter 1979
NTUJ NO
FOOD ☐ HOPE ☐

A sheet for every game. The First Winter booklet writes the first four lines of its own game here.

The family record

Every family that reached the Thai camps was written into a register: names, village, who was missing. Keep this one during the game. When a villager falls, write when, where and how; when the game ends, write the ending number from the table below and read it in the Endings booklet (the villager and the number, for example Mai 7). Crossed? Draw a Fortune card: 1 to 10 reads ending 1, 11 to 20 reads ending 2.

THE FAMILY _____ SET OUT Spring 1975 from the Village Ruins ENDED _____

VILLAGER · CLAN · SIDE	WHAT BECAME OF THEM	SEASON AND YEAR	WHERE	LAWS ADOPTED · SQUARES CARRIED · WHAT THEY CARRIED THE WHOLE WAY	ENDING

The family tree. *Blong is Chai's father; Chai and Mai are married; Chao and Gao are their children; all of the Hang clan. Tou (Vang), Sheng (Lee), Chong (Xiong), Meng and Pa (Yang), Pao (Thao), Cheng (Her), Kong (Moua), Lee (Vue), Bao (Lor) and Ka (Cha) walk with them from the same village.* ***What we carried.*** *When the endings have been read, each player names one thing their villager carried the whole way and writes it in the fifth column.*

THE ENDINGS · THE SAME NUMBERS FOR EVERY VILLAGER

1 Crossed the Mekong	**2** Crossed the Mekong	**3** Still in Laos when the game ends	**4** Taken prisoner	**5** Killed by soldiers
6 Starved	**7** Died of sickness	**8** Killed by a bomb or a mine	**9** Drowned in the Mekong	**10** Shot trying to cross

Print one for each game, or laminate one and use a dry-wipe pen. The same table is on page 3 of the Endings booklet.

CHAO FA · THE PRINTED FIRST GAME

The First Winter

> *Spring 1975. The village burned in the night. Four of us walked out before the soldiers came back: Chai the Senglao, Mai from the fields, Chao who can run, and old Blong who knows the paths. We took what we could carry. Chai says we are going south, to the river, and that the story cloth will show us the way. I will tell it as it happened, so the children remember.*

This booklet plays the first four seasons for you, one rule at a time, with the same cards the app's Learn to play uses. Read a season, do what the box says, and read the diary line it leaves behind. After Winter 1975 you shuffle everything and go on alone. The rulebook is the reference; you will not need it until then.

Setting the table

1. **The map.** Village Ruins face up at the top. Lay the hills row face down, left to right: **Pine Ridge, Swidden Fields, Long Tieng Airstrip**. The jungle, lowlands and river rows are shuffled face down as usual.
2. **The family.** Chai, Mai, Chao and Blong, all on **Side A**, each on a family board. Each takes the first of their own items out of its search deck: Chai the **Soul Lock**, Mai the **Hoe**, Chao the **Slingshot**, Blong the **Cane**. Set each HP cube on the card's HP.
3. **Tracks.** Food **12**, Hope **3**, the time marker on season 1. Squares **1 to 4** of the story cloth on the mat (a party of four starts with four).
4. **The stacked decks.** Shuffle every search deck, then find these cards and put them on top **in this order, first card on top** (the rest of each deck stays shuffled beneath):

VILLAGE RUINS, TOP 6

1. Needles
2. Soldiers searching the ruins (Danger, easy)
3. French Silver Coins
4. Village Flintlock
5. Wood Axe
6. Ring

PINE RIDGE, TOP 8

1. Bow
2. A Hidden Path (Escape)
3. Nothing but pine needles
4. A tiger on the ridge (Danger, easy)
5. Pine-Resin Torch
6. Horse
7. Wild mushrooms and a bird: Food +1
8. A hunter's shelter: DEF +2

SEASON DECK, TOP 4

1. Food +1
2. Food +2
3. A Sweep Through the Hills (Time)
4. A Crying Child (Dilemma)

THE FORTUNE DECK, ALL 20, TOP FIRST

17	6	10	14	5	18	3	9	7	19
8	2	16	12	4	11	1	15	13	20

Red cards favour the soldiers in a fight, blue the party.

Put the fight tracker, the Patrol table card (face 1, 1975 and 1976, the marker on **4** living) and this booklet beside the board. Laws, Strangers, Turning Points and River cards stay in the box this game.

The one idea. Every season is the same three steps: draw a **Season card**, everyone takes **two actions** (Travel instead, before anyone acts), then the **end of the season**. In Winter the end of the season is where the game bites: everyone eats, the Toll comes, the council meets.

Season 1 · Spring 1975 · *nplooj hlav*

We hid in the ruins all morning. Chai went back for the things we had left behind.

Season card: turn the top card: **Food +1**. Move Food to 13. Discard it.

1. 🔍 **Search Chai** searches the village (pay 1 Food, now 12). The first card is the **Needles**: Chai keeps them (an item with a villager's name goes to that villager if they are alive; Bao is not with this family, so anyone may hold them. Lay them on a pack slot of his board).
2. 🔍 **Search Chai** searches again (Food 11). The village has been searched once, so **first draw a Fortune card for noise**: a **17**. Higher than 1, so no one hears. The card is **Soldiers searching the ruins**: an **Easy fight**, now.

The first fight, on the tracker. Step 1: the Patrol table, Easy row, column 4, face 1: the soldiers are **4**. Put the brass marker on 4. The party's cards and items add up to **13 ATK, 14 DEF, 6 HP**: write them in. Step 2, clash 1: draw a Fortune card: a **6**, an even clash. You deal 13 − 4 = **9**, more than 4: the soldiers fall. They deal 4 − 14, nothing, but **always at least 1**: give the wound to **Chai** (move his HP cube from 2 to 1). Step 3: won in one clash. Easy means **1 safe search**: take the next card that is not a Danger: the **French Silver Coins**, to Chai.

3. **Forage Mai** forages (free): the village gives 1 Food in Spring, +1 for working: **Food +2** (now 13). Draw a Fortune card for being spotted: a **10**, above 3, safe.
4. **Scout Mai** scouts (Food 12): turn the left-hand hills tile face up: **Pine Ridge**. The party can travel there next season.
5. 🔍 **Search Chao** searches (Food 11): noise draw **14**, safe; he finds the **Village Flintlock** (both hands). Searches again (Food 10): noise draw **5**, above 3, safe; the **Wood Axe**.
6. 🔍 **Search Blong** searches (Food 9): noise draw **18**; the **Ring**. Then **Rest or nurse** he **rests and tends Chai**: Chai's cube goes back to 2.

End of the season: nobody is sick, it is not Winter. Move the time marker to 2. *Diary line 1: "Spring 1975. The ruins. Soldiers found Chai in the ashes; we drove them off. Food 9."*

Season 2 · Summer 1975 · the rains

The rains came and the paths turned to mud. Blong said he knew an old road over the ridge, from before the war.

Season card: Food +2 (Food 11).

1. **Travel Travel**, before anyone acts: the whole party moves to **Pine Ridge**. Normally you draw a Fortune card against the tile's Danger (2): on 2 or less a patrol finds you. Not today: **Blong's Side A power, Old Road**, is a reaction: no Danger draw, and 1 more Food on the way. Blong's power token goes to **used**.
2. On the way you gather the ridge's Summer forage: 1, +1 for working, +1 from Blong: **Food +3**. The journey eats 1. Food **13**.

End of the season: travelling takes the whole season. Time marker to 3. *Diary line 2: "Summer 1975. Up the old road to Pine Ridge. Blong remembered every turn."*

What you learned. Searching is how you find everything, and every search after the first makes **noise**. Hard work **eats**: Search, Scout, Camp and Travel cost 1 Food. A **power** is used once a season; the family board shows whether it is ready.

Season 3 · Fall 1975 · *nplooj zeeg*

> *Soldiers came through the hills in a line, beating the grass. We lay under the leaves all day and did not speak.*

Season card: A Sweep Through the Hills, a Time card: this season everyone has **1 action** and the party cannot Travel.

1. 🔍 **Search Chai** searches the ridge (Food 12): the first search here, no noise draw. The **Bow** (both hands; give it to **Mai**, whose hands are free: handing on a found item is free).
2. **Forage Mai** forages: Fall on the ridge is 1, +1: **Food +2** (14). The spotting draw is a **3**: **spotted**. An **ambush**, Easy.

The second fight: an ambush. Soldiers 4 again (Easy, 4 living, face 1); the party is now **17 ATK, 16 DEF, 8 HP** (the Bow and the Flintlock count). **Ambush: they fire first**, so in clash 1 you deal nothing. Clash 1: Fortune **9**, even. They deal 4 − 16, at least 1: Chai takes it (cube to 1). Clash 2: Fortune **7**, even. You deal 17 − 4 = 13: the soldiers fall. They deal 1 again: Chai (he has nothing left to lose but his life, and 1 HP is still alive). Won in two clashes: **1 safe search**: **A Hidden Path**, an Escape card. Chai keeps it in hand: when soldiers find you, discard it and there is no fight.

3. ⛺ **Build a camp Chao** starts a camp (Food 13): the first of two actions. Lay a Camp token on the tile, half turned.
4. 🔍 **Search Blong** searches (Food 12): noise draw **19**, safe. **Nothing but pine needles**: discard it. The deck gets thinner.

End of the season. Time marker to 4, a Winter cell. *Diary line 3: "Fall 1975. The sweep. Mai was seen gathering; Chai took the bullets. Chao began a shelter."*

Season 4 · Winter 1975 · *ntuj no*

> *The cold came down off the ridge. A child in the next family would not stop crying, and the soldiers were on the path below.*

Season card: A Crying Child, a Dilemma. The party decides together before anyone acts. Choose **Hold the child and run**: Hope −1 (now 2), and draw a Fortune card: an **8**, 10 or less, so the soldiers come: a **Medium fight**.

The third fight. Medium row, column 4, face 1: the soldiers are **5**. Party 17 ATK, 16 DEF, 6 HP (Chai is on 1). Clash 1: Fortune **2**: **the soldiers' aim is true, +2**: they strike with 7. You deal 17 − 5 = 12: they fall. They deal 7 − 16, at least 1: give it to **Mai** (cube 2 to 1). Medium means **2 safe searches**: the **Pine-Resin Torch** and the **Horse** (the Horse is shared: no slot).

1. ⛺ **Build a camp Chao** finishes the camp (Food 11): turn the Camp token face up. The Toll is 1 better here and resting heals 1 more.
2. 🛏 **Rest or nurse Mai** rests and tends Chai: he heals **2** at the finished camp (cube back to 2: full).
3. 🔍 **Search Chai** searches (Food 10): noise draw **16**, safe. **A tiger on the ridge**: an Easy fight. Soldiers' number 4 (the table is used for animals too). Clash 1: Fortune **12**, even: 17 − 4 wins at once; 1 wound to Chai. 1 safe search: **Wild mushrooms and a bird, Food +1** (11).
4. 🛏 **Rest or nurse Blong** rests and tends Chai (heals 1). 🛏 **Rest or nurse Mai** rests (heals 1: full).
5. 🔍 **Search Chai** searches again (Food 10): noise draw **4**, above 3, safe. **A hunter's shelter, DEF +2**: into Chai's hand for a later fight.
6. 🛏 **Rest or nurse Chao** rests, 🛏 **Rest or nurse Blong** rests: nothing to heal, but Winter is no time to make noise.

The end of Winter: eat, the Toll, the council

1. **Eat.** Everyone eats 1 Food: 4 from the store, **Food 6**. Nobody goes hungry.
2. **The Toll.** Winter 1975 is the mildest: cold +0. Each villager draws a Fortune card and falls **Sick on 5 or less**, adjusted: +1 for a child (Chao) or an elder (Blong), −1 for the finished camp. In card order: Chai draws **11**, safe. Mai draws **1: Sick**. Put a Sick token in the box on her board: one action a season until she is nursed, and if the Toll takes her again she dies. Chao draws **15** (needed 5: safe), Blong **13** (needed 5: safe).
3. **The council.** Draw 2 laws: **Travel Light** (each person keeps at most 3 items; every Danger draw is 2 better) and **Council of Elders** (+1 Hope at every year end, but 1 Food is cooked for the council). Adopt one, or neither; it cannot be undone. The family in this diary chose Travel Light and left the Needles and the Coins under a stone.
4. Move the time marker to **5, Spring 1976**. Everyone who ate heals 1 wound in Spring.

Diary line 4: "Winter 1975. The cold took Mai. We ate the last of the rice. Chai says the river is four rows south and the soldiers will be twice as many next year."

Now shuffle everything and go on. Shuffle the Fortune deck and every search deck (keep the cards already drawn out), shuffle the Season deck, and put the Laws, Strangers and Turning Points beside the board. From here the game is yours: nurse Mai, scout the hills, find the keys that recover squares 5 to 9, and reach the river before the twentieth season. Keep writing the diary. When the game ends, the diary is read first, then the Endings booklet.

What the four seasons taught

A season is a Season card, two actions each (one if Sick; Travel instead, before anyone acts), then the end of the season. Winter adds eating, the Toll and the council.

Searching finds everything, and every search after the first draws for noise: earlier searches here or less brings soldiers. Spoils after a won fight are free and skip Danger cards.

A fight is one number from the Patrol table, up to three clashes with a Fortune card each, and the cost. Gunfire always gets through: at least 1 wound a clash. Armor stops it first.

Hard work eats. Search, Scout, Camp and Travel each cost 1 Food. Forage is free and brings Food in. In Winter everyone eats 1.

The Toll is a Fortune card per person at every Winter, Sick on 5 or less, worse for children, elders, the hungry, the wounded, the cold of the year and low Hope; better with a camp, a healer and warm things.

Keys and the cloth. Keys in the search decks recover the squares of the story cloth, each behind a fight one step harder than the place, or a price. With all nine, cross from any river place.

If the table disagrees with this booklet

The booklet is right only if the decks were stacked as page 1 says and the actions were taken in this order. If a draw comes out differently, you have skipped a draw or taken one too many: go back to the last matching line, or simply play on with the rules; the engine that checked this game would have done the same.

The same four seasons can be played on screen: the app's Learn to play uses this shuffle with the coach beside the table.

CHAO FA · START IN TWO MINUTES

Your first season

The table

1. **Board** on the table, Village Ruins face up at the top. Each row below: shuffle its four tiles, lay three face down, put one back.
2. **Search decks**: each place's deck shuffled, face down on its tile (the divider names it).
3. **Family boards**, one each: a villager card in the window, Side A up, the HP cube on the card's HP. Each villager takes the first of their own items from its deck.
4. **Tracks**: Food 3 per villager, Hope 3, the time marker on season 1, the phase marker on 1. Squares already sewn on the cloth mat: 2 for six villagers, 3 for five, 4 for four, 5 for three.
5. **Beside the board**: the Fortune deck shuffled face down, the Patrol table (face 1), the fight tracker, the Laws, Strangers, Turning Points and River cards in their dividers.

One season, read aloud

1. **Season card.** Turn the top card and do what it says. An Omen goes on the Omen row.
2. **Travel?** Before anyone acts, the party may move to a face-up place ahead (1 Food): a Fortune card against its Danger, then the season ends.
3. **Two actions each**: Search (1 Food), Scout (1 Food), Forage, Rest, Camp (1 Food), a Side A power, play a card.
4. **A fight**: one number from the Patrol table; up to three clashes with a Fortune card each; you choose who is hit.
5. **Winter only**: eat 1 Food each, then the Toll (a Fortune card each, Sick on 5 or less), then the council adopts a law.
6. **Time marker** forward one. After season 20 the game ends. The river needs all nine squares.

The goal. Recover the nine squares of the story cloth (keys in the search decks, each behind a fight or a price) and cross the Mekong from any river place before the end of 1979. Most who set out will not reach the far bank; the game is about who does, and how.

The four pages before this one play the first year for you, card by card. The rulebook has the rest; the symbol key cards explain every mark.

CHAO FA

THE TRAIL · THE ENDINGS

WHAT BECAME OF EACH VILLAGER

16 VILLAGERS 10 ENDINGS EACH FIND BY NUMBER

This game is dedicated to all the men and women who served in the Vietnam War; to the Hmong who served and were killed; to those who died in the jungles of Laos and those who are still there; to the CIA, to General Vang Pao, and to everyone who brought attention to this tragic chapter of history.

SECOND EDITION · THE ENDINGS BOOKLET · 160 ENDINGS, 10 FOR EVERY VILLAGER, FOUND BY NUMBER (2026)

CONTENTS

How to find an ending 3
The camps, and where they went 5
Chai 6
Tou 8
Mai 10
Chao 12
Gao 14
Sheng 16
Chong 18
Meng 20
Pao 22
Blong 24
Cheng 26
Kong 28
Lee 30
Bao 32
Ka 34
Pa 36

What this book is for

Open it when the game is over. For every villager it holds an ending for everything that can have happened to them, the same on either side of their card, each one different and each one drawn from the real-life stories of Hmong families, a countryless nation, who lived through these years. The first chapter shows how to find the right ending by its number; then come the villagers, one after another, in the order of their cards.

BEFORE YOU READ

How to find an ending

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
CROSSED THE MEKONG	CROSSED THE MEKONG	STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS	TAKEN PRISONER	KILLED BY SOLDIERS	STARVED	DIED OF SICKNESS	KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE	DROWNED IN THE MEKONG	SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Every villager in Chao Fa has an ending for everything that can happen to them: crossing the Mekong, being still alive in Laos when the time runs out, being taken prisoner, and the six ways the trail can kill. Each villager has 10 endings, 160 in all, and no two are alike. They are the same whichever side of the card the villager was played on. The villagers are invented, but every ending is drawn from the real-life stories of Hmong families who lived through these years.

Finding an ending

An ending is named by the villager and a number, for example **Mai 7**. The numbers mean the same thing for every villager, so the number alone tells the fate. Turn to the villager's pages (the table below) and read the ending with that number.

1. **What became of them?** Find the row in the table and read off the number. A death on the trail is read by its cause, the way the game told it: killed in a fight, starved, taken by sickness or the cold, or an old bomb or a mine. The river has its own rows for drowning and for being shot.
2. **If the villager crossed** there are two endings: **draw a Fortune card**, 1 to 10 reads ending 1, 11 to 20 reads ending 2. The app draws it for you and shows the same code.
3. **Read it aloud**, then the next villager. The family record below keeps track during the game.

ENDING	WHAT BECAME OF THE VILLAGER
1	Crossed the Mekong · Fortune 1–10
2	Crossed the Mekong · Fortune 11–20
3	Still in Laos when the game ends · also for going down to surrender
4	Taken prisoner
5	Killed by soldiers · wounds in a fight
6	Starved
7	Died of sickness · fever, the Winter Toll, the yellow rain
8	Killed by a bomb or a mine · an old bomb, a mine
9	Drowned in the Mekong · swept away, a raft or boat lost, the current
10	Shot trying to cross · at the bank or in the water

The villagers

VILLAGER	ENDINGS	PAGE
Chai · Senglao (Mayor) · Side B, Senglao in exile	1–10	6
Tou · Teacher · Side B, Teacher who reads Thai and Lao	1–10	8
Mai · Farmer · Side B, Rice farmer, mother of two	1–10	10
Chao · Kid · Side B, Kid, message runner	1–10	12
Gao · Kid · Side B, Kid, little mother	1–10	14
Sheng · Hunter · Side B, Crossbow hunter	1–10	16
Chong · Blacksmith · Side B, Raft builder	1–10	18
Meng · Shaman · Side B, Shaman who reads the bones	1–10	20
Pao · Farmer · Side B, Fisherman-farmer, strong swimmer	1–10	22
Blong · Elder · Side B, Elder who knows the old roads	1–10	24

Cheng · Soldier · Side B, SGU radio operator	1–10	26
Kong · Doctor · Side B, Medic trained at Sam Thong	1–10	28
Lee · Medicine Woman · Side B, Herbalist	1–10	30
Bao · Tailor · Side B, Tailor of warm clothes	1–10	32
Ka · Singer · Side B, Kwv txhiaj singer	1–10	34
Pa · Shaman · Side B, Shaman, soul caller	1–10	36

Family record

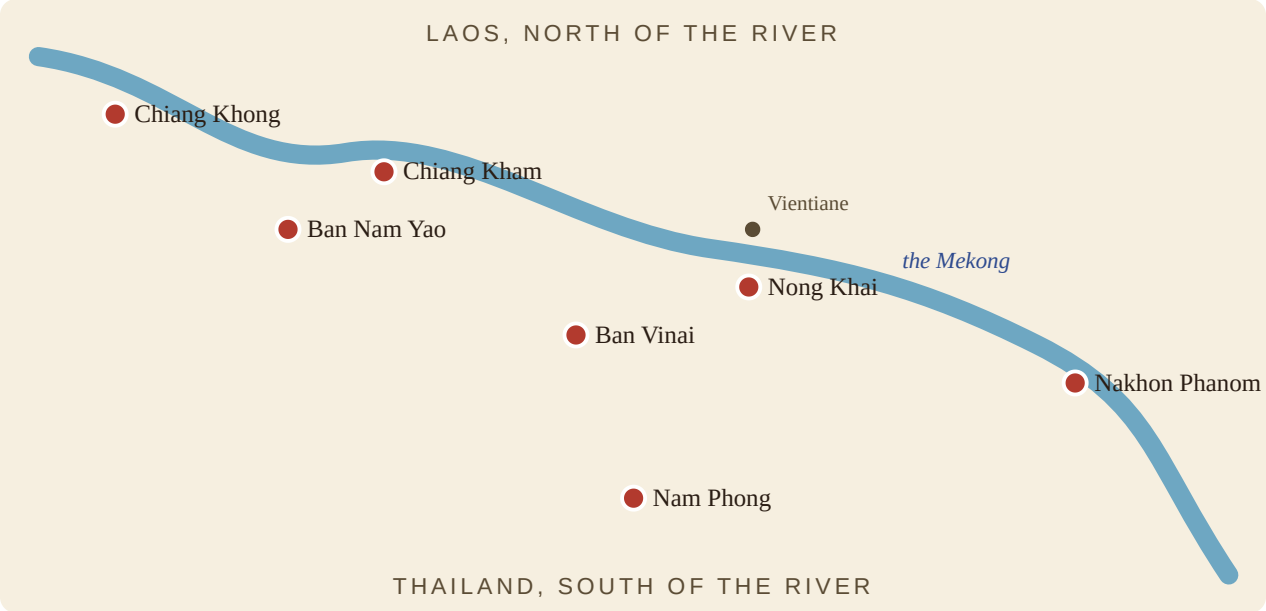
Fill this in as you play, so you know which ending to read for each villager. When a villager dies on the way, write when and how, for example: "Mai, Fall of 1977, starved in the bamboo forest: Mai 6."

VILLAGER	WHAT BECAME OF THEM	SEASON AND YEAR	WHERE	ENDING

THE FAR BANK

The camps, and where they went

Every crossed ending (1 and 2) ends on this bank. The camps are where the villagers' stories went on: a family that reached the water near Vientiane was taken to Nong Khai, one that crossed in Loei went to Ban Vinai, one that came down from Sayaboury to Nan.



Chiang Khong: the crossing from the north.

Ban Nam Yao: the camp in Nan, for families from Sayaboury.

Chiang Kham: the camp for the northern crossings.

Ban Vinai: the big Hmong camp, in Loei, where most families waited.

Nong Khai: the first camp, across from Vientiane.

Nam Phong: the earliest camp, inland, soon closed.

Nakhon Phanom: the camp downriver.

Where they went

The camps were a wait, for most families a long one: years of registration lines, of letters to relatives already abroad, of interviews with the officers of the countries that would take them, of being told no and trying again. From the camps the Hmong went to the United States, to France and French Guiana, to Australia, to Canada and to Argentina, in that order of numbers; many were resettled in cities that had never heard of Laos. Some stayed in the camps until they closed, and some were sent back across the river. A few of the endings in this book say which country a villager reached; most stop at the bank, because that is where the game stops, and the rest of the story belongs to the families who lived it.

The map is a sketch, not a survey: the river runs from the north-west to the south-east, and the camps lie along the Thai bank roughly where the families who crossed nearest to them were taken.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Chai

Senglao (Mayor); on Side B, Senglao in exile. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Chai 1 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Last Wave to St. Paul. Chai reached Ban Vinai in 1976 and was chosen to speak for his section, counting rations and settling disputes. He refused resettlement for years, saying a headman should not leave while his people waited. When Ban Vinai closed in the early 1990s he moved to Wat Tham Krabok, and in 2005 he flew to St. Paul with the last wave, past seventy. His son and his nephews, grown men raised in camps, took warehouse jobs and learned English late. One grandson dropped out of high school and drifted for years; a granddaughter became a nurse and translated at Chai's own appointments. Chai sat with the clan elders at New Year and funerals, and his grandchildren took him to the Capitol memorial, where he stood a long time. He died in St. Paul in 2019.

Chai 2 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Bringing the Families to Fresno. Chai crossed in 1975 and spent about a year in Nong Khai before his families were resettled, scattered across three states. He went to a small Midwestern town and cleaned a school at night for less than three dollars an hour. The winters and the scattering wore on everyone. In the early 1980s he called the families together by letter and proposed Fresno, where relatives lived. Over two years they moved and worked the fields. His daughter finished college and became a county social worker; his son left high school to farm and never went back. Chai sat as an elder at weddings and funerals across the valley, visited Laos in the late 1990s, and lived to bring great-grandchildren to the Lao Hmong American War Memorial in Courthouse Park.

Chai 3 — STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Seminar Without an End. When the escape failed, the new authorities came for village leaders first. Chai was taken to a re-education camp, told it would be a short seminar. He spent nearly seven years clearing fields and building roads. Released in the early 1980s, thin and quiet, he was settled in a lowland village and forbidden to travel. Relatives in Fresno sent letters and, later, money. He never crossed. He died in Laos in the late 1990s, and a grandson flew from California for the funeral.

Chai 4 — TAKEN PRISONER

Letters from the Roads. Soldiers stopped the group at a stream crossing, and Chai stepped forward and said he was the village leader. They took him and let the families go on. He was held in Camp 06 near Muang Et, repairing roads and digging irrigation ditches. Family visits were refused, but a cousin bribed a guard to pass him dried meat and a little medicine. He kept the wrapping cloth folded in his shirt. He was released in the 1980s, very thin, and settled in a lowland village under watch. Even there, neighbours came to him to settle disputes, and he did it quietly in the evenings. Later his son found a way across the Mekong for the family. They passed through Ban Vinai and were resettled in the United States. Chai kept that wrapping cloth until he died.

Chai 5 — KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Cave Above the Stream. In April 1977, the families Chai kept together were hiding in limestone caves between Luang Prabang and Vientiane, the entrances hung with branches. Soldiers found them at night. Gunfire and grenades echoed off the rock, and people fled down the stream in the dark. Chai held the cave mouth long enough for the women and children to get out. In the morning they came back for him. No qeej could be played so near the soldiers; an old man chanted the showing-the-way under his breath. Chai's daughter Gao, who escaped that night, later named the council her family still holds in Merced after the cave.

Chai 6 — STARVED

The Headman Ate Last. By January 1979 Chai's people had spent three months in a limestone cave in the Vang Vieng hills, too watched to plant. Each evening he measured the rice himself, one cup at a time, and took his own share last. Often there was nothing left for him, and when there was, he slipped it to the children. His wife scolded him; he said a headman eats last or he is no headman. He grew thin, then quiet, and died one cold night in his blanket. They buried him at the cave's mouth. His grandson, who crossed the next year, still tells the story in St. Paul each New Year.

Chai 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever by the Nam Ngum. The rains of 1976 found Chai's people camped in the Nam Ngum valley, under plastic sheets that never dried. Dysentery came through the camp. Chai kept walking from shelter to shelter with his notebook, counting who was sick and who had rice, until one morning he could not stand. He lay four days in a lean-to while his wife boiled bark tea and the rain drummed overhead. He died before dawn. A nephew who knew the funeral songs sang the showing-the-way chant in a low voice. The families chose Chai's eldest son to lead them. He kept the notebook and wrote his father's name at the top of a fresh page.

Chai 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Gap in the Dike. In the cold season of 1979 Chai brought his families down onto the Vientiane plain, where the paddies were dry and the dikes made paths a family could walk in the dark. The soldiers had learned that too. At a gap where the path crossed a ditch, Chai went through first, as he always did, to see that it was safe for the children. The mine was in the gap. The families could not stay; his eldest son covered him with his own jacket and led them on, and they crossed the river four nights later. In camp the council met without him for the first time. They left his seat empty, and his son spoke only after the elders had spoken.

Chai 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

The Bags of Air. Near Paksane, Chai's people went into the Mekong at night holding plastic bags tied full of air. Chai swam last, behind the slowest family, counting heads under his breath. Halfway across, one of the bags burst and a boy went under. Chai caught him and pushed him onto his own float. Then the current took him. On the Thai bank at first light his sons searched the shallows until the police came. In Ban Vinai his wife dried the household notebook page by page in the sun.

Chai 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Senglao Stood Up. Near Thadeua, Chai stood at the water's edge sending his households in one at a time, counting each off as it went. A flare went up while the last family was still on the bank. Chai pushed them down into the reeds and stood, so the soldiers would look at him. He fell where the mud met the water. In the dark that followed, the last family crossed. In Ban Vinai, his eldest son found his own name written at the top of the notebook's last page: the next senglao.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Tou

Teacher; on Side B, Teacher who reads Thai and Lao. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Tou 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

The Teacher Teaches Again. Tou reached Ban Vinai in 1977 and was teaching within a month, under a tin roof with no walls, the Hmong alphabet in the morning and arithmetic in the afternoon. In 1980 the family was resettled to St. Paul. He worked nights on a factory line and studied English by day through his first winter. By the end of the decade he was a bilingual aide in St. Paul schools, and later earned his teaching license. His son became a teacher too. His daughter left college after one year and works at a bank; she understands Hmong but answers in English, which hurt him more than he said. Tou taught Saturday Hmong classes for twenty years, visited Laos in 2005 to find his old school, and now reads to his grandchildren in both languages.

Tou 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Court Interpreter in St. Paul. Tou crossed in 1975 and spent a year in Nong Khai translating between Thai guards and Hmong families. He reached St. Paul in 1976, among the first Hmong there, and cleaned offices at night while a church sponsor drove him to English class. His English came quickly. By the late 1980s he interpreted in St. Paul courts and hospitals, careful with every word because he had seen what a wrong one could cost. His daughter became a lawyer. His son enlisted in the Army, served overseas and came home quieter, and the two found it hard to talk. Tou trained younger interpreters, kept a worn Thai-Lao dictionary on his desk until he retired, and went back to Vientiane in 2010 to read the street signs again.

Tou 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Clerk of the Chao Fa. After the failed crossing, Tou hid in the forest with relatives and joined the Chao Fa around Phou Bia. Because he could write, he kept their records and taught children between moves. When the Phou Bia strongholds came under attack in 1977-78, the camps scattered. Tou reached Thailand in 1980 and lived in Ban Vinai for over ten years before resettling in the United States in 1991. He rarely spoke of the forest years, but kept the records.

Tou 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Charcoal on a Board. Tou was captured on the trail with a notebook in his pocket, and that was enough. The soldiers said a man who could write had worked for the Americans. He was sent to Camp 04 near Muang Et. By day he cut logs and cleared brush. At night, by the fire, he taught younger prisoners to read, writing letters in charcoal on a flat board and wiping it with his sleeve when a guard came near. Food was short, and the men shared salt and wild greens. The government said in 1984 that the centres were closed, but Tou was still there. He was released in 1989 and settled near the Plain of Jars. He taught his grandchildren the same letters on the same kind of board, and they never knew why he laughed when they wiped it with their sleeves.

Tou 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Gathering Ferns at Dusk. In the wet season of 1976, Tou's group hid in the forest above the Vang Vieng road. Food ran short, and every afternoon the adults went out to gather fiddlehead ferns and dig for roots. Tou took the older pupils with him and named each plant as they picked it, as if it were a lesson. One evening soldiers waiting by a stream opened fire. Tou shouted for the children to scatter. They did, and all of them came back. He did not. His wife wrapped him in a blanket, and the group moved before dawn. In Ban Vinai, one of those pupils taught the same plant names to her own class.

Tou 6 STARVED

A Handful for Each Child. In the winter of 1978, Tou held school in a clearing in the Vang Vieng hills, scratching letters in the dirt. By then the families had almost no rice. Tou gave his share to the pupils who came with nothing, a handful each, saying children could not learn on empty stomachs. His wife begged him to eat. He grew so thin his shirt hung like a sack, and in February he died in his sleep. The families buried him at the clearing's edge. A boy he had taught crossed to Thailand and became a teacher in Ban Vinai. He opened his first class with Tou's name.

Tou 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Malaria in the Rains. In August 1976, Tou's group camped in the forest near Muang Fuang, waiting for the rains to ease. Mosquitoes came at dusk in clouds. Tou caught a fever that came and went, chills and then burning, for two weeks. Between fevers he translated a Lao radio broadcast for the others and drew a map of the river towns he knew. Then the fever came and did not leave. He died with his wife beside him. They had no qeej, so the group's elder sang the showing-the-way. His map survived in his wife's bundle, and the family used it to find the river two years later.

Tou 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

Iron in the Rice Field. In 1977 Tou's family came down from the hills to a hidden valley near the Plain of Jars, where an old field could be planted again. The ground was full of rusted war scrap. Tou had read the warning leaflets in Lao and knew what to fear, and he went first, probing the soil with a stick. His hoe struck a small round bomb half buried in the earth. The family did not plant that field. Instead they moved on, carrying him. In Ban Vinai, his daughter learned to read Thai from the camp schoolbooks so she could do what her father had done, reading for others.

Tou 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Three Pupils Reached the Bank. Tou had taught three of his oldest pupils to swim in a forest stream, practising each evening for a month. On a dark night they went into the Mekong below Sanakham, holding plastic bags tied full of air. The cold water took his strength halfway. He kept calling to the children to kick, until they could no longer hear him. All three reached the Thai bank. In Ban Vinai his wife held a funeral without a body, and the three pupils burned joss paper beside his empty sleeping mat.

Tou 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Long Enough. Near Paksane, Tou went down to the water first, as he always did, to speak to anyone waiting there. A patrol was waiting. He called out to them in Lao, calmly, the way he had at every checkpoint, and for a moment no one moved. Then a soldier fired. Behind him, while every eye was on him, his family slipped from the reeds into the river and reached Thailand. In Ban Vinai his son said his father had talked one last time, long enough.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Mai

Farmer; on Side B, Rice farmer, mother of two. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Mai 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Rented Acres Near Fresno. Mai spent four years in Ban Vinai, growing greens beside the longhouse and sewing story cloths that traders bought for sale abroad. In 1981 the family was resettled to Fresno. She and her husband picked fruit by the bin and took English classes neither could keep up with. Within a few years they rented a few acres and grew long beans, bitter melon and lemongrass, selling first from a folding table, then at farmers' markets. Their eldest son left high school to work the farm and later ran it. Their daughter studied pharmacy and works in a hospital, the first in the family with a degree. Mai cooked for New Year every year, went back to Laos in 2003 to see her sister, and still plants mustard greens along the fence from seed she carried in a cloth pouch.

Mai 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Strawberries in Merced. Mai crossed in 1979 and spent seven years in Thai camps, the last of them in Chiang Kham, growing vegetables in a strip along the fence. In 1986 the family was resettled to Merced, California. She and her husband picked tomatoes, then rented two acres and grew strawberries, working before dawn under plastic tunnels. Mai never learned to drive, so her eldest daughter drove her to the market at sixteen. One son struggled in school and joined a gang for a time, then came back to work the farm. A daughter became a pharmacist. Mai's mother stayed in Laos, and they spoke only twice more, by phone. Mai still keeps a garden behind the house.

Mai 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Still in Xieng Khouang. After the escape failed, Mai and her husband lived two years in the forest, moving with the seasons. In 1978 they came down and were settled in a government village, where they were made to farm a second plot for the cooperative. They stayed. Mai raised five children in Laos and lived to be an old woman. In the 2000s a nephew from St. Paul came to visit, bringing photographs of cousins she had never met, and she cooked for him until he could eat no more.

Mai 4 TAKEN PRISONER

A Plot for the State. Mai was caught with her basket of food when soldiers stopped her group on the trail. She was a farmer with no papers, so she and her children were sent to the Plain of Jars with other captured families. There they joined an agricultural cooperative under government control. Mai was given a plot for the cooperative and a small one for her own family. She worked both, and she knew which roots and greens grew wild along the paddy edges, so her children rarely went to bed hungry. She saved seed from every harvest in gourds hung from the roof. Officials came often to count and record. Mai stayed all her life, raised her children there, and at New Year she cooked enough for the neighbours whose gardens had failed.

Mai 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Gathering for Two Children. Mai fed her two small children by foraging. In the cold season of 1977, near the Vang Vieng hills, she spent long days digging wild yams and gathering greens while her husband watched the children. Soldiers found the women gathering by a stream. Mai ran the wrong way and was shot. The other women brought back her basket. Her husband raised the children alone, and the family held a funeral for her when they reached the camp, calling her soul home. Her son, grown, says his mother's basket was the last thing she carried for them.

Mai 6 STARVED

Rice Water for the Children. By the cold season of 1977, Mai's family had been in the forest near the Nam Ngum for a year. She cooked thin rice water for the children and drank only what was left in the pot. When there was no rice, she boiled leaves and gave the children the broth. Her husband found her once eating bark. She grew weak and slow, then caught a cough she could not throw off. She died in January. Her husband led the children across the river that spring. In Merced, her youngest son keeps a sack of rice in the pantry at all times and says he cannot sleep if it runs low.

Mai 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

The Sickness at the Stream. Late in the rains of 1976, Mai's family camped beside a stream in the Vang Vieng hills, where they could hide but could not plant. The water was the only water. First the baby fell sick with dysentery, then Mai, who had nursed him day and night. The baby recovered. Mai did not. She died in a shelter of banana leaves while her husband held her hand. No qeej player was with them; her husband's uncle sang the showing-the-way chant, telling her to follow the road back to the place where her birth shirt was buried. Her husband raised the children alone and never remarried.

Mai 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Field Her Husband Cleared. In 1976 Mai went back to the field her husband had cleared on a slope near Muang Cha, because her children had to eat. The slope had been bombed during the war, and rusted metal lay among the stumps. Mai burned the brush and began hoeing the ground for rice. Her hoe struck something buried. Her neighbors heard the blast from the valley. Her children were in the village with their grandmother. The family held the funeral in the village, with qeej and drums. Her son later worked with a group clearing old bombs in Laos, to make the ground safe for others.

Mai 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Seed Gourds, Dry. The family crossed below Pak Lay on a raft of banana stems lashed with vine, too small for five. Mai slipped into the water to lighten it and swam beside, one hand on the stems, pushing. Halfway over, the raft turned in an eddy and her hand came away. Her husband saw her once against the Thai lights. She was never found. On the Thai bank the children opened her basket: rice, salt and her seed gourds, still dry. Her daughter in Fresno still plants from that line of seed.

Mai 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Her Back to the Shore. The family reached the reeds at night with a hired guide. Mai went first with the youngest on her back, feeling for the mud with her feet. A flare went up on the Lao bank and soldiers fired at the water's edge. Mai turned her back to the shore to cover the boy and was hit. Her husband carried the child the rest of the way. The boy was unhurt. In Ban Vinai a txiv neeb called his frightened soul back, and the family held Mai's funeral.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Chao

Kid; on Side B, Kid, message runner. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Chao 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Nurse on the East Side. Chao was ten when his family reached Ban Vinai in 1978, and he spent a year there learning letters in the camp school. In 1979 they were resettled to St. Paul. He was placed in third grade with children half his size and learned English from cartoons and a patient teacher. His father cleaned floors at a downtown bank. In high school Chao translated for his parents at clinics, which is why he became a nurse; he worked twenty-five years at a St. Paul hospital, often called when an elderly Hmong patient would not speak. His son became an engineer; his daughter struggled with depression in college and took years to finish. Chao took his mother to New Year every year, visited Laos with her in 2010, and now babysits his grandchildren.

Chao 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Snowfall in Wausau. Chao was eleven when his family crossed in 1979 and spent a year in Nong Khai camp, in tarp tents that flooded every time it rained. In 1980 they were resettled to Wausau, Wisconsin. Snow fell the first week. Chao learned English fast and translated for his parents everywhere. Some classmates were friendly; others threw stones and shouted that the Hmong should go home. He fought back, then learned not to. He became a social worker for the county, the job he had done unpaid since age eleven. His sister Gao never liked the cold and moved to Fresno. In 2016 Chao brought his father to the unveiling of the Hmong-Lao veterans memorial in Wausau.

Chao 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Grown in the Forest. Chao's family was turned back and fled into the forest near Phou Bia. He grew up there, moving camp every few weeks, without school or a clinic. As a young man he joined the remaining Chao Fa groups and stayed after most others had surrendered or crossed. He married in the forest. People of his generation are still hiding there, now with grandchildren.

Chao 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Raised in the Cooperative. Chao was a small boy when soldiers caught him on the trail, separated from his parents in the noise of the fight. He was sent with other captured children and women to a resettlement village on the Plain of Jars. An older couple in the cooperative took him in and raised him with their own grandchildren. He herded buffalo, went to the village school and learned to read Lao. He never stopped asking about his parents. When he was grown, a trader brought a letter from Ban Vinai: his mother and father were alive and had crossed the river. They were later resettled in the United States. In the 1990s his mother flew back to Laos to see him. She brought him an embroidered collar she had sewn the year he was lost.

Chao 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Night in the Cave. In April 1977, Chao's family was sleeping in a limestone cave between Luang Prabang and Vientiane, with several other families. The entrance was hung with branches, and the cooking fire was kept small. Soldiers came in the night. In the noise and dark, Chao's father got the little ones out, but Chao, who was ten, had run back for his younger cousin. Both were lost. The families buried the children together the next evening, in a clearing below the cave. His father sang the showing-the-way chant for both. His mother kept his slingshot. In St. Paul, decades later, she gave it to her first grandson and told him whose it had been.

Chao 6 STARVED

Waiting for Grandfather. Chao's family would not leave the forest near Phou Bia without his grandfather, who was too sick to walk. So they stayed, through the dry season of 1978 and into the rains. The rice ran out, then the corn. They ate leaves and banana stems and whatever small fish Chao could catch in the stream. His grandfather died in May. By then Chao, ten, was thin as a stick, and a cough settled in his chest. He died a month later. The family crossed the river in October. In Ban Vinai, his father held one funeral for both, with qeej, though he could not afford a cow.

Chao 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

The Fever in the Rains. Chao was eight in the wet season of 1976, when his family hid in the forest near the Nam Ngum. Everything was damp: blankets, rice, the ground they slept on. A fever went through the children. Chao had it for a week, burning and then shivering, while his mother kept a wet cloth on his forehead and sang to him. He seemed to get better, and then one night he did not wake. His father carved a small wooden top for him to take along. The elder sang the showing-the-way chant. His mother crossed with his embroidered collar sewn inside her own jacket, and wore that jacket at every New Year for the rest of her life.

Chao 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Bright Thing in the Grass. In the dry season of 1977 Chao's family crossed the bombed hills of Xieng Khouang, where the old fields were pocked with craters and every child had been told never to touch the small round bombs. Chao, nine, ran ahead as he always did. At a crater's edge he saw one half out of the earth, grey and round as a fruit, and he reached for it to show his father. His father heard the sound from the path. They wrapped him in his mother's skirt and buried him beside the crater, and his father spoke the words that show a soul the way home. His mother kept his slingshot. In St. Paul, years later, she would not let her grandchildren pick up anything from the ground in a park.

Chao 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Two Plastic Bags. The family swam the Mekong below Vientiane at night. Chao, nine, floated between two plastic bags full of air that his father had tied under his arms. Halfway across, one bag tore on a snag, and the current carried him off into the dark. He called his father once. His father dove again and again until his mother pulled him back. Chao was not found. In Nong Khai camp the elders sang the showing-the-way for him, and his mother kept his embroidered hat for the rest of her life.

Chao 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Path He Scouted. The family reached the water's edge near Sanakham before moonrise. Chao, ten, had scouted the path down through the reeds himself. As they stepped into the river, soldiers on the bank fired toward the sound, and Chao fell in the shallows. His father carried him across in his arms, but the boy was gone before they reached Thailand. Two Thai farmers helped dig a grave above the bank. In Minneapolis his mother sewed his hat's pattern into every grandchild's New Year collar.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Gao

Kid; on Side B, Kid, little mother. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Gao 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Snow in Sheboygan. Gao crossed in 1976 and spent a year in the Nong Khai camp, on the Hmong side where there was no electricity, carrying water and learning Thai letters from a volunteer. Late in 1977 a Lutheran congregation sponsored the family to Sheboygan, Wisconsin. Her mother cleaned motel rooms on the lake road, and Gao started second grade at eight with no English, in snow up to her knees. She worked twenty years on the line at the Kohler plant, then ran the garden plots the city set aside for Hmong families by the river. Her son joined the Army and served two tours overseas; he came home quieter, and she learned to sit with him the way she sat with old soldiers. Her daughter left college, then went back at thirty and became a social worker. In 2006 Gao walked her mother to the Deland Park memorial. She now has six grandchildren.

Gao 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

The Merced Classroom. Gao's family spent two years in Ban Vinai, where she went to the camp school and her mother sewed story cloths to sell to aid workers. A cousin sponsored them to Merced, California, in 1980. Her father picked crops and studied English at night until his eyes gave out. At eleven Gao read the welfare letters aloud at the kitchen table. She finished college and taught English to newcomers' children for twenty-five years; in 2005 the last families from Wat Tham Krabok arrived and their children sat in her room. Her elder son became a pharmacist. Her younger son ran with a gang in the late 1990s, spent a year in juvenile hall, and now counsels teenagers for the county. Gao sits on the New Year committee and took her mother back to Laos in 2012.

Gao 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

The Cassette Letters. When the group scattered, Gao stayed behind with her grandmother. For years they moved through the forest with other families, planting small hidden fields. In the early 1980s they came down to a lowland village, and Gao grew up there, married and raised five children. She never crossed. In the 1990s a cassette tape arrived from cousins in California, full of greetings and old songs, and she recorded one back. She first saw them again in 2008, when they visited with gifts and photographs. She told them she did not regret staying, only the parting.

Gao 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Raised by the Cooperative. Gao was eight when the soldiers stopped her group on the trail. Her parents had gone ahead to scout the path, and they never came back for her. She was sent with other captured families to a cooperative on the Plain of Jars, where an older widow took her in. She carried water, weeded the rice and learned Lao at the village school. Each evening she said her parents' names quietly so she would not forget them. She married a quiet man from the cooperative and kept her mother's silver necklace sewn inside a pillow. In 1996 a letter came through a cousin in Vientiane. Her parents had crossed the river and were living in Wisconsin. They came back two years later. Her mother knew her at once, by her calm way of standing still.

Gao 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Back of the Cave. In the spring of 1977 Gao's group hid in caves in the limestone hills between Luang Prabang and Vientiane. A crying baby could give everyone away, so the mothers gave the smallest a little opium on the tongue, and Gao slept with her baby cousin inside her blouse. Soldiers attacked the caves before dawn. Gao pressed herself over the baby against the back wall. When the shooting stopped, his mother found the boy alive and warm beneath her. The survivors left before light, with no time for a funeral. In Ban Vinai an elder chanted the showing-the-way for her. That cousin, now a grandfather in Saint Paul, tells the story every New Year so his grandchildren know whose life they carry.

Gao 6 STARVED

A Winter Underground. When the offensive reached Phou Bia late in 1978, Gao's family and four others hid in a limestone cave and lived there through the cold months. The fire was kept to embers so the smoke would not show, and water dripped from the ceiling day and night. They went out only after dark, to dig roots and glean the last corn from abandoned fields. Gao gave her share of corn gruel to her grandmother more than once and said she was not hungry. In January she grew too weak to climb to the cave mouth. She died there, and they buried her under the overhang. Her grandmother lived to reach Ban Vinai and asked for a soul-release rite to be held for Gao, a year late.

Gao 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever in the Rains. In the rains of 1977 Gao's family sheltered under banana-leaf roofs on the slopes below Phou Bia, moving camp whenever smoke from soldiers' fires showed in the valley. Gao caught a fever that came back every second afternoon and shook her until her teeth knocked. There was no medicine. Her grandmother boiled bitter bark and called Gao's soul at dawn with the family's last hen, singing her name toward the trees. On the ninth day Gao fell asleep and did not wake. Her father buried her on a ridge, without the qeej, because the sound would carry. Her mother kept the collar Gao had embroidered herself, crooked stitches and all, and forty years later in Minnesota asked to be buried with it.

Gao 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

A Round Thing in the Grass. In the dry season of 1976 Gao's family walked south across the hills of Xieng Khouang, where years of bombing had left the old fields full of rusted metal. Every child had been warned never to touch the small round bombs. Gao was gathering firewood at the edge of a burned clearing when her stick turned one over. Her uncle heard the sound from the trail. The family could not stay. They wrapped her in her mother's skirt and buried her under a stand of bamboo, and her father spoke the words that show a soul the way back to the ancestors. In Ban Vinai her mother sewed a story cloth of the walk, with one small girl carrying sticks, a little apart from the rest.

Gao 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

The Raft in the Dark. She was on a raft of banana trunks, holding her grandmother's hand, when the raft struck a sunken tree and broke apart in the dark. Her grandmother came up alone. When a patrol light swept the water, the family stayed silent, as Gao had always helped them do. They searched the Thai sandbars for two days. In Ban Vinai the family held her funeral with qeej and laid her silver neck ring where she should have been.

Gao 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Quiet Child to the Last. Gao was holding her grandmother's hand in the shallows when soldiers on the bank saw the raft being pushed out and fired into the dark. She fell into the water without a sound. Her father lifted her onto the raft and would not leave her, and the family brought her across. They buried her near the Nong Khai camp, with the qeej for one night. Her grandmother kept the little pouch Gao had sewn, with three river stones still inside.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Sheng

Hunter; on Side B, Crossbow hunter. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Sheng 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Deer Season in Wausau. Sheng reached Ban Vinai in 1979 and spent a year there making paj ntaub with other women while her husband, a former soldier, recovered from fever. A Catholic parish sponsored them to Wausau, Wisconsin, in 1980. She worked nights at a cheese plant and went to English class in the mornings, half asleep. The first winter frightened her more than the war had. Each November she bought a deer licence and walked the county forest with her sons, and the venison went to New Year feasts and widows with no hunter. Her eldest son dropped out of high school and worked forty years in a paper mill; her daughter became a teacher. Her husband died in 2014. In 2016 she stood at the new veterans memorial at the courthouse for him. Her grandsons still hunt with her rifle.

Sheng 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Grouse in Ontario. Sheng's family crossed in 1979 and spent a year in Ban Vinai, where she wove baskets for trade and waited for a sponsor. Canada accepted them in 1980, one of a small number of Hmong families sent there, and placed them in a city in Ontario where the nearest Hmong household was an hour's drive away. Her husband worked in a plastics factory; Sheng sewed at a coat factory and learned English from a church volunteer. In the autumns she hunted grouse and deer with a licensed rifle, and the meat went to the few Hmong families nearby. Her daughter became a high school teacher. Her son moved to Minnesota to live among other Hmong and married there. Sheng stayed, saying the forest was big enough.

Sheng 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Hunter for the Hidden. Sheng stayed in the mountains when the escape failed and hunted for families hiding near Phou Bia. When the army pushed into the massif in 1977 and 1978, her group kept moving, eating roots in the dry months. She crossed the Mekong at last in 1983 with a small group of women and children and spent years in Thai camps. In 1992 she reached the United States. She never hunted again, saying she had done enough of it to stay alive. Her granddaughter recorded her story for a school project.

Sheng 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Rifle on the Trail. Sheng was caught with a rifle in her hands, and that changed everything. The soldiers did not believe a woman carried it only for hunting. She was sent to a seminar camp in Houaphan, known only by its number, near Muang Xamteu. The officers called it a school. She cut logs, dug irrigation ditches and repaired roads in the rain. When the rice was cut, she set snares at the edge of the work site and shared the birds with the women in her hut. Family visits were refused. She was released in 1984 and walked home to find her husband had remarried, believing her dead. She settled near her sister instead, raised pigs and never touched a gun again.

Sheng 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Her Snares at Dawn. In the rainy season of 1978 Sheng's family hid in the forest on the flanks of Phou Bia, moving camp every few weeks. She went out at first light to check her snares and dig wild yams, because she knew the ground better than any of the men. One morning, crossing a stream, she walked into a patrol. The camp heard two shots. Her husband found her that evening and carried her back. They buried her the same night with her knife and her bag of snares beside her, and he spoke the words that show the way back to the ancestors. He raised their sons alone, in Ban Vinai and later in Wisconsin. When the eldest bought his first hunting licence, his father gave him her knife.

Sheng 6 STARVED

Too Close to Light a Fire. In the dry season of 1978 Sheng's group was hiding in the Vang Vieng hills, too close to patrols to hunt with a gun or light a fire by day. The game had moved off, and they lived on wild yams. Sheng knew the bitter kind had to be sliced and soaked in running water for days, but the group kept moving and the soaking was cut short. She always tasted each batch first, to judge it for the children. One night she fell ill with cramps and dizziness and died before morning. The children who had eaten after her were only sick. Her brother made sure every batch after that soaked the full time, and later taught her daughter which roots to dig and which to leave.

Sheng 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

The Fever Took the Hunter. In the rains of 1977 Sheng's family hid on the slopes below Phou Bia, and she went out each dawn to her snares. The fever came with the mosquitoes, shaking her every second day. On the good days she still walked her lines and brought back squirrels and once a barking deer; on the bad days her husband walked them for her and came back with nothing. By the fifth week she could not stand. She told her nephew where every snare was set before she slept. She died before dawn. There was no qeej, so her brother chanted the showing-the-way under his breath. The nephew ran her snares until the family left for the river, and in Ban Vinai he fed them the same way.

Sheng 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

Off the Guide's Line. Late in 1979 Sheng's family took the long western route through the hills of Xayaboury, and she hunted as they walked and kept the family fed. On the fifth day, crossing a dry streambed, a small child wandered off the trodden path toward a bird in the stones, and Sheng stepped out to lift her back. The mine took Sheng, and the child was thrown clear, frightened but whole. The group buried her quickly in a clearing, and her brother tied a strip of red cloth to a tree so the place could be found again. It never was. The family reached Sob Tuang camp in January. Each New Year her husband still burns spirit money for her.

Sheng 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Pushing from Behind. She swam behind the bamboo raft her husband had lashed together in the reeds, pushing it toward Thailand while her sons clung to the poles. In the middle the current swung the raft into a sunken tree, and she was pulled under its branches. Her husband felt her hands leave the raft. The boys reached the Thai bank at dawn. In Nong Khai camp the family held her funeral with qeej and laid her knife where she should have been.

Sheng 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

A Hunter's Ears. Sheng heard the patrol before anyone else, as she always did, and stood up in the shallows to wave the others on. The soldiers on the bank fired at the movement. She went down in the shallows while her husband and sons were already pushing off on the raft, and he could not go back. On the Thai bank they listened all night. In Ban Vinai the family held her funeral with her hunting bag laid out, and her husband told everyone she had bought them the minutes they needed.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Chong

Blacksmith; on Side B, Raft builder. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Chong 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Knives from Leaf Springs. In Ban Vinai, Chong built a forge from scrap and spent two years mending pots and making knives for the camp. A church sponsored his family to Sheboygan, Wisconsin, in 1978. He worked in a metal shop grinding castings for $2.90 an hour and went to English class at night, though he spoke little. In his garage he built a forge from a brake drum and turned old truck leaf springs into Hmong knives, sickles and hoes; neighbours with gardens bought them, then Hmong families from Wausau and Milwaukee. His eldest son became an engineer at a manufacturer. His daughter left school at seventeen to marry, then went back years later to become a nurse. At New Year Chong gave a knife to every boy who had turned twelve. When he died, his grandson kept the anvil and still makes two knives each winter.

Chong 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Abuelo at the New Year. Chong's family crossed in 1978 and lived two years in Ban Vinai, where he mended pots at a scrap forge. When Argentina offered places to a small group of Hmong families, Chong, tired of waiting for an American sponsor, said yes. They were placed in a farming town in the north, where the soil was red and the summers hot and wet. Some families soon left for France or the United States. Chong stayed, mending ploughs and gates for neighbours and learning Spanish slowly. His wife grew vegetables and sold them in the town market. His daughter became a schoolteacher; his son moved to French Guiana and farmed there. Chong's grandchildren speak Spanish first and Hmong second, and call him Abuelo at the New Year.

Chong 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Seminar Years. Chong stayed. Because he had repaired rifles for soldiers during the war, he was sent to a re-education camp, where he did hard labour clearing land and breaking rock. He was released in the mid-1980s and returned to a lowland village, where he forged tools for the cooperative. He never tried to leave. Two of his sons crossed into Thailand and later reached the United States, and in the 1990s they began sending money and photographs. He died in Laos in 2007. His sons flew back for the funeral and heard the qeej played for him.

Chong 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Tools for the Guards. Soldiers caught Chong on the trail with his hammer and tongs in his pack. Someone told them he had fixed rifles for the army, and he was sent north to a seminar camp near Muang Et. He was told a seminar could last thirty days or thirty years. The guards soon learned his skill and made him mend axes, hoes and road tools. It kept his hands busy, but the rice was thin. He wrote short letters that were never answered, since visits were refused. In the third winter the rice ran shorter still, and Chong fell ill with fever. He died in the spring. A fellow prisoner later reached Thailand and told his sons where he lay.

Chong 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Ladder He Built. When the offensive reached Phou Bia late in 1978, Chong's family and five others took shelter in a limestone cave above a stream. He had made a ladder of bamboo and rattan to reach it and pulled it up every night. One night soldiers found the path anyway and fired into the cave mouth. Chong held the entrance while the others climbed down a narrow chimney at the back that he had found weeks before. He was killed at the mouth. His wife and children escaped through the back. They reached the river a month later and crossed on a raft his nephew lashed the way Chong had taught him. In the Nong Khai camp his widow held the funeral with qeej.

Chong 6 STARVED

Hoes from a Truck Spring. Chong's family stayed in the hills west of Phou Bia through 1976 and planted corn and hill rice in a clearing under tall trees. Chong forged the hoes himself from an old truck spring. In the harvest month soldiers found the field and burned it, with the granary beside it. That winter the family lived on cassava from an abandoned garden, bamboo shoots, and whatever Chong could get by trading his knives. He ate least, saying a smith needed less than a growing child. By spring his legs and face were swollen. He died in April and was buried with his hammer. His wife and children reached Ban Vinai in 1978, and his son still has the hammer in Milwaukee.

Chong 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Bad Water. In the wet season of 1977 Chong's family was hiding with forty others in the forest above the Nam Ngum, drinking from a stream that ran past too many camps. Dysentery went through the group. Chong nursed his wife and daughter through it, boiling water whenever smoke was safe, and then he fell ill himself. He kept mending digging tools by hand until the day he could not sit up. He died within a week. There was no qeej player in the group, so an old man chanted the showing-the-way over him through the night, and they buried him with his tongs. His wife carried the tongs to Thailand. His daughter, a public health nurse in Minnesota, teaches safe water to newly arrived families.

Chong 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

Steel from the Old Field. Chong had always made his blades from scrap, and the hills of Xieng Khouang were full of it. On the walk south in the cool season of 1976 the family's tools were wearing out, so he stopped at an old bombed field to take steel from a broken casing. Something small and round lay underneath it, and it went off when he moved the casing. His eldest son, twenty steps away, was not hurt. The family wrapped Chong in a blanket and buried him on the hillside at dusk; a cousin chanted the way back to the ancestors, and his son laid the hammer beside him. The son learned the trade again in Ban Vinai, and in Wisconsin he became a welder who never touches metal he cannot name.

Chong 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Iron Rings on the Rope. Chong's family crossed below Paksane holding bundles of bamboo, tied together by a rope. Chong had forged an iron ring for each child's float so the rope could not slip. Midstream a snag dragged at the line, and he cut himself free so it would not pull the children under. The current took him. The family reached Thailand at dawn, every ring still holding. His body was never found. In Ban Vinai they held his funeral, and his daughter wears one ring on a chain.

Chong 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Armor in the Shallows. Chong's group reached the bank near Pak Lay after midnight. He was wearing the last bamboo armor he had made, and he stood in the shallows holding the floats steady while the others climbed on. A patrol came along the shore with lights. He was shot there, knee-deep in the shallows, and the armor did not stop it. The floats drifted clear, and his wife and children reached the Thai bank. They never learned what was done with his body. In Ban Vinai a cousin led his funeral.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Meng

Shaman; on Side B, Shaman who reads the bones. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Meng 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Gong in the Apartment. Meng spent a year in Ban Vinai, where he held healing rites almost every night. A cousin sponsored his family to Merced, California, in 1980. He went to English class for six months and quit, and the family lived on welfare and his wife's piece-work sewing. He was the only txiv neeb for several apartment blocks, and a landlord complained about the gong more than once. His elder son became a nurse and often stood between doctors and his father, explaining each to the other. His younger son joined a church and stopped coming to the rites, and for years they did not speak of it. Later a Merced hospital began letting shamans perform brief ceremonies at bedsides, and Meng was among those who went. He trained his nephew to keep the altar.

Meng 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Nights of the Qeej. Meng spent five years in Ban Vinai, where he held more funerals than he could count and waited while sponsors fell through. He reached Wausau, Wisconsin, in 1984 and worked as a janitor at a school, a job he kept until he was sixty-five. He led healing rites and New Year soul-calling for dozens of families, and he worked with a funeral home that let the qeej play through the night. He learned to explain the rites to coroners and nurses. His daughter became a social worker; his son left high school, joined the Army, and came home steadier. In 2016 Meng blessed the ground where the veterans memorial was raised at the courthouse. His son now keeps the altar and the shaman's tools, and the grandchildren carry the incense.

Meng 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Still on the Mountain. Meng stayed with the families who went up toward Phou Bia, and they relied on him for healing when there was no medicine. He lived through the offensives of 1977 and 1978 and kept moving with a small group in the forest for years. He died there of illness in the 1990s and was buried by people who could not hold a full funeral. Some of the families he served are still in hiding today, without schools or clinics, and reports of attacks on them continued into 2025. They still speak of him.

Meng 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Healing in the Dark. Meng was caught on the trail with his shaman's rattle and finger bells. A village official said he had held ceremonies for soldiers, and he was sent to a seminar camp in Houaphan near Muang Et. The officers called old beliefs superstition, and rituals were forbidden. Meng cut logs by day. At night, when a man lay sick and frightened, Meng whispered the soul calling beside him, using a thread pulled from his own shirt. In 1979 news passed among the prisoners that Touby Lyfoung had died in Camp 01 at Sop Hao. Some said malaria, some a guard. Meng did not say what he thought. He was released in the 1980s and lived quietly with his daughter until he died.

Meng 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Crossing Route 13. In January 1978 Meng's group had to cross Route 13, the main road north of Vientiane, to reach the plain and the river. They waited all day in the elephant grass for their guide and crossed at dusk. A patrol on the road opened fire. Meng was shot as he helped an old woman down the embankment. His elder son dragged him back into the grass, where he died before midnight. They buried him beside a stream, and before they moved on his son tied a white string on each living relative's wrist, as his father had done for them so many times. In Ban Vinai a txiv neeb held his funeral with qeej. His sons still argue over whether they should have waited.

Meng 6 STARVED

The Plane Before the Harvest. In 1978 Meng's village, hiding in the forest above the Nam Ngum, risked planting one field of rice in a hollow screened by trees. A week before harvest a plane passed low, and two days later soldiers came and burned the field and the granary. The families scattered. That winter they lived on wild leaves, bamboo shoots and a little corn. Meng held healing rites for the sick on an empty stomach and grew weaker every month. He died in February, wrapped in his shaman's cloth, and his wife sang the old mourning words over him. A year later his elder son held a full funeral in Ban Vinai with a borrowed qeej, and in Saint Paul he still keeps his father's altar.

Meng 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever Among the Sick. In the rains of 1976 Meng was the only txiv neeb among the families hiding in the forest near Phou Bia, and nearly every night someone called him to a sick child. He held healing rites with a cloth over his face and the rattle in his hand, calling lost souls back to bodies burning with fever. In August the fever took him too. His wife and his nephew nursed him in a lean-to for nine days, and he died at dawn. With soldiers close, there was no proper funeral; an elder chanted the showing-the-way in a whisper. In the Nong Khai camp his elder son held the full rites. The son became a nurse in California and keeps his father's rattle on a high shelf.

Meng 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Dry Field. In the hot season of 1979 Meng's family came down from the hills to the plain near Vientiane, where mines had been laid along the escape trails. Meng read the bones the night before and said the path along the paddy dikes was clear. In the morning, cutting across a dry field to avoid a village, his son's wife stumbled, and Meng pulled her back and stepped where she had been. The mine took him. The family buried him quickly at the edge of the field, and his eldest son spoke the words that show the way. In Ban Vinai they held the funeral properly. His sons always defended the old man's bones: he had read the paddy path, not the field.

Meng 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Untied from Her. Meng could not swim. He crossed holding two sealed bamboo tubes, roped to his wife on hers. Midstream his float split and filled. He untied the rope from his own waist so he would not drag her down, and the current took him. She reached the Thai bank at dawn and searched the sandbars for three days. In Ban Vinai a txiv neeb of another clan called his soul and held the funeral with qeej and drum. His wife never let anyone tie a rope to her again.

Meng 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Calling the Children Close. Meng's group reached the bank below Paksane after midnight. Before they went in, Meng shook his rattle very softly and called the children's souls to stay close inside their bodies for the crossing. A patrol came up the bank as the first floats went out. Meng was shot in the reeds, the rattle still in his hand. His elder son pulled the floats into the dark. In Nong Khai the family held his funeral with his rattle and horns in his place, and the son tied strings on every child who had crossed.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Pao

Farmer; on Side B, Fisherman-farmer, strong swimmer. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Pao 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Cucumbers Under Bedsheets. Pao spent a year in Ban Vinai, growing squash along the camp fence and waiting for a sponsor. In 1977 a Lutheran church brought the family to Denver. He swept a warehouse for $2.50 an hour, studied English two evenings a week, and learned that corn planted in April could freeze. By the third spring he rented a plot outside the city and covered his cucumbers with bedsheets on cold nights. His eldest son left high school at sixteen to work, then earned his diploma at twenty-five and became a diesel mechanic. His daughter became a nurse. Pao stayed in Colorado when cousins moved to Minnesota. In 1995 he stood at the back when Golden declared a Lao-Hmong Recognition Day. He visited his old village once, in 2006, and came home saying the hills had grown smaller.

Pao 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Chicken Houses in Arkansas. Pao reached Ban Vinai in 1979 and waited six years. His children went to the camp school, and he planted gourds along the fence and traded them at the gate. In 1985 the family flew to the United States. A cousin found him contract work in Arkansas raising chickens: thousands of birds in long metal houses, fed and watered on a strict schedule. It was farming, and he understood it. His two daughters finished college; one teaches fourth grade, the other is an accountant. His son struggled, fell in with older boys, spent a year in county jail, and came home to work the chicken houses beside him. Pao paid off the land in eleven years. When his knees gave out in 2012 he sold the farm and moved to a Minnesota suburb, where he grows bitter melon and leads his clan's New Year meal.

Pao 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Learning the New Ways. After the escape failed, Pao led what was left of the family back down the mountain. In 1976 officials moved them to a lowland village near the road, where they were told to learn the new ways of life and farm a plot for the government. Pao kept quiet and grew rice. In 1979 his two sons slipped away with a large group bound for Thailand. Pao stayed with his wife, whose leg was bad. Letters came from America years apart. He died in the village in 2003, and his neighbours buried him.

Pao 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Rice for the Cooperative. The soldiers caught Pao on the trail with a basket of maize seed on his back. They did not shoot him. They walked him and his wife down to a lowland resettlement village, and in 1976 the family was moved again, to a cooperative on the Plain of Jars. Pao was given a plot and a quota. He burned and cleared new fields as he always had, but the rice went to the cooperative store and came back to him by the cup. Officials came to the meetings and watched who was missing. He kept the seed basket on a nail by the door. His sons grew up speaking Lao at school. Pao died in the cooperative, and his sons played the qeej for him on borrowed pipes.

Pao 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Shells on the Maize Ridge. In the dry season of 1977, with the offensive closing on Phou Bia, Pao went back up to his abandoned field to cut the last ears of maize. He had planted that slope himself, and he would not let the soldiers have it. The first shells came over the ridge while he was still bent in the rows, and the dry stalks hid nothing. His brother found him at dusk and carried him down to the gully where the family waited. There was no qeej; they could not risk the sound. His brother whispered the showing-the-way chant over him by the light of a resin torch, and the next morning the family walked west carrying a basket of the maize he had cut.

Pao 6 STARVED

The Hunger Sickness. Through the dry season of 1978 Pao's family hid in a ravine in the Vang Vieng hills, too close to a new army post to light a fire by day. The rice had gone in the first month. They lived on cassava dug from an abandoned garden and bamboo shoots, with no salt and no meat, and Pao did the digging. By the hot season his legs had swollen to the knee and then his face, the hunger sickness the old people knew by name. He kept walking to the garden until he could not stand, and died in his sleep before the rains. His wife sang a kwv txhiaj for him at the fire, very low, and the children she brought to Ban Vinai remembered that song all their lives.

Pao 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever on the Reservoir. In the rains of 1977 Pao's family hid in the bamboo along the shore of the Nam Ngum reservoir, where he could fish at dawn and feed the others. The mosquitoes came at dusk in clouds. One by one the family took the fever, and Pao went on wading out with his net while it shook him. In August it would not let him go. His wife boiled bark and sat with him for four nights. They buried him in the bamboo, and his son, twelve that year, took over the dawn fishing until the family left for the Mekong. In Ban Vinai a txiv neeb called the souls of the whole family together so that none would follow Pao away.

Pao 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Bomblet in the Furrow. In the Vang Vieng hills in the spring of 1978, Pao cleared a hidden patch under the trees to plant cassava cuttings, far from any path the soldiers used. On the second morning his hoe rang against something round and rusted, a bomblet left from the bombing years. His wife heard the sound from the stream. They buried him beside the patch he had cleared, and his sons covered the grave with leaves so no patrol would find it. The cassava came up anyway. In Minnesota, decades later, his eldest son would not let his grandchildren dig in the garden until he had walked the rows himself, slowly, looking at the ground.

Pao 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Back for One More. Pao had already crossed the Mekong four times that night, towing children from three families on a float of banana stems. On the fifth trip he brought over his wife, who could not swim, and left her in the Thai shallows. Then he turned back for his brother's youngest. Halfway out his strength was gone and the current took him. His brother brought the child across at dawn. The family held his funeral in Ban Vinai, and the child he went back for carried the spirit money.

Pao 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Last Push Off. The family waited in the mud until the moon set. Pao was the last on the bank, pushing the raft with his wife and youngest son into deep water, when a light swung across the reeds and soldiers fired from the shore. He fell face down in the mud of the bank. His wife saw him go down and could only hold the boy and let the current take them. They reached Thailand at first light. In Ban Vinai his brother, who had crossed a week earlier, held his funeral, and the youngest son lit the first spirit money.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Blong

Elder; on Side B, Elder who knows the old roads. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Blong 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

The Elder Everyone Fetched. Blong waited three years in Ban Vinai before his youngest son found a sponsor, and reached Minneapolis in February 1980 in rubber sandals. His son worked nights at a meat plant in South St. Paul. Blong went to English class for one winter and learned 'thank you' and his bus number. What he knew was harder to find: the order of a funeral, the words of a marriage negotiation, which clans could marry. Families drove across the Twin Cities to fetch him. His grandchildren grew up between two languages. One grandson dropped out and was in a gang for a while; Blong sat with him every evening until he went back to school, and he is now a youth counsellor. A granddaughter became a teacher. Blong sat by the drum at three-day funerals in rented halls until he died in 1997, at eighty-six.

Blong 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

The Old Man of Ban Vinai. Blong crossed at sixty-four and reached Ban Vinai in 1976. He never left Thailand. When his sons filled in resettlement forms, he refused to sign: he would not die where no one knew the way back to the ancestors. His youngest son stayed with him while the others went to Minnesota. In the camp's mud lanes Blong settled disputes over bride price and borrowed pigs, and he chanted the song that guides the dead at funerals for younger men. His grandchildren learned Thai and English at the camp school. He died in 1984 and was buried outside the camp. His son left for St. Paul a year later with his father's pipe. Of the grandchildren raised in Ban Vinai, one became a lawyer in St. Paul; another never finished school and drives a truck. Both keep his photograph above their New Year altar.

Blong 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Too Old to Hide. When the group turned back, Blong told his sons he was too old to live in the forest. He went home to the village, where officials mostly left an old man alone. His sons went into the forest near Phou Bia. Blong kept a small garden, performed weddings when asked, and waited. One son came out of the forest in 1980 to see him once, then crossed into Thailand. Blong died in 1986. The village buried him with qeej, and his grandson in America heard of it a year later, in a letter.

Blong 4 TAKEN PRISONER

The Old Man's Garden. Blong could not run when the soldiers came up the trail, so he sat down on a rock and waited. They took him and his daughter-in-law and her children to a resettlement village in the lowlands. An old man was not much use to the cooperative, so he was set to minding children and drying tobacco. Younger men went to meetings; Blong sat at the back and said nothing. People still came to him at night to ask about weddings, debts and which spirits were angry, and he answered them quietly. From a man selling salt he heard which of the old officers had died in the camps, and said their names once, quietly, so the children would hear them. Blong lived out his life in the village under watch. When he died, the village found enough pipes for a qeej.

Blong 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Night at the Caves. In the dry season of 1977 the family was hiding with other households in limestone caves in the hills between Luang Prabang and Vientiane. Blong slept near the mouth, because old men wake easily and he wanted to hear anyone coming. Soldiers came in the dark. He shouted the alarm and the families at the back fled through a second opening into the trees. Blong did not come out. His widow carried his burial clothes across the Mekong two years later, and in Ban Vinai the family laid them on the bier and played the qeej for three days. His grandsons still say his shout is the reason they are alive.

Blong 6 STARVED

A Grandfather's Share. In the cold season of 1979, in the Vang Vieng hills, the family's last rice was a few handfuls in a cloth. Blong told his daughter-in-law that old men need little food, and he poured his share into the children's bowls every evening. He spent the days telling the grandchildren the names of their ancestors, seven generations back, until they could say them without him. In January he did not wake. His sons buried him in his good jacket, and the eldest chanted the way back for his soul. When the family reached Thailand, the grandchildren were the ones who recited the ancestors' names for the camp clerk.

Blong 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Dysentery in the Long Rains. In the wet season of 1977, the family sheltered in a ravine below Phou Bia while Blong waited for the patrols to thin before choosing a road. The stream they drank from was fouled by the camp above it. The children fell sick first, then Blong. He was seventy and could not hold down water. He spent his last lucid days drawing the route in the mud for his grandsons with a stick: the ridge, the salt spring, the ford. He died in September. The family followed his drawing the next dry season. In Ban Vinai a qeej player played for him, and his grandson redrew the route on paper for his own sons.

Blong 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Old Road Was Mined. In the cold season of 1979 Blong led the family south by a trail he had walked in the 1960s, a ridge path that no patrol was supposed to know. Two days from the river they found fresh cuttings across it, a sign that soldiers had been there. Blong went ahead alone to look. The mine was under the leaves at a bend he remembered. His grandsons heard the sound and found him, and then went back and found another way down through the bamboo, slower, as he had taught them. They crossed four nights later. In Sob Tuang camp the eldest grandson held the funeral rites with his grandfather's walking stick laid in his place.

Blong 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

His Road Began at the River. Blong could not swim, and he would not let anyone tie him to a son. He held a float of bamboo with two grandsons, telling them stories in a low voice to keep them calm. In the strongest current the float turned over. The boys came up holding the bamboo; their grandfather did not. In Ban Vinai his eldest son chanted the showing-the-way song Blong had taught him, beginning from the middle of the Mekong, because that is where his father's road home now started.

Blong 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

An Elder Goes Last. Blong stayed on the bank to see every family into the water, because an elder goes last. He was stepping into the shallows himself when soldiers fired from the dark behind them. He fell in the shallows. His son, already swimming with a child, heard him call out once, the word for go. They went. In Ban Vinai the family held his funeral through three nights, and every family he had seen into the river came to sit by the drum.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Cheng

Soldier; on Side B, SGU radio operator. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Cheng 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

A Stone at Arlington. Cheng spent four years in Ban Vinai and reached Minneapolis in 1980. He ran a stamping press at a plant in Northeast Minneapolis and studied English in a church basement. He woke shouting some nights, and his children learned not to touch him when he slept. His eldest son left high school and drifted for years; his daughter finished law school and represents tenants in court. In May 1997 Cheng rode overnight to Washington with other veterans for the dedication of a stone at Arlington, the first time the U.S. recognised the secret army on its own ground. In 2000 Congress waived the English requirement for SGU veterans, and he became a citizen soon after. In 2008 he went back to Laos and found the hill where his unit had camped. He hosts the clan New Year in his garage.

Cheng 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

The Repair Shop. Cheng spent a year in Ban Vinai and reached Minneapolis in February 1980. He washed dishes for $3.10 an hour, then repaired televisions for a shop owner amazed that a refugee knew circuits. By 1988 he had his own repair shop, with a back room where old soldiers drank tea. On weekends he read the news in Hmong on a community radio hour for elders who could not read English. His daughter became an electrical engineer. His son dropped out of college, worked in the shop for ten years, and now runs a phone repair business from it. Cheng's wife never learned English, and the grandchildren barely speak Hmong; Sunday dinners are quiet. In 2015 he went back to Laos once, as a tourist, and did not try to see Long Tieng. In July 2026 he enrolled for Minnesota's SGU veteran certificate and brought his old radio codebook to show the clerk.

Cheng 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Born in the Forest. Cheng went back into the forest around Phou Bia with the Chao Fa. He fought through the offensives of 1977 and 1978 and stayed on after most fighters had crossed to Thailand. He married in the forest, and his children were born there and never saw a school or a clinic. They moved camp whenever soldiers came near. Cheng died of fever in the late 1990s. His grandchildren are still among the families hiding around the mountain. In 2025 human-rights groups were still reporting attacks on them, which the government denies.

Cheng 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Released in the Eighties. Cheng fired his last cartridge on the trail and was taken alive. The soldiers knew a fighter when they saw one. He was sent to Camp 05 near Muang Xamteu with other men who had served with the Americans. For years he cut logs, repaired roads and dug irrigation ditches, and he wrote confessions that were never judged good enough. When rice was cut, the men shared what they had. He kept a spoon he had carved from a shell casing. Family visits were refused. In 1984 the government said the re-education centres had closed, but Cheng was held longer, and he was released in the late 1980s. He went home to his wife, who had waited, and farmed under watch until he died.

Cheng 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Rear of the Line. In the cold season of 1978 the group came down from the hills toward the Vang Vieng road, more than two hundred people in a single file. Cheng walked last with his old carbine, because he was the one who had fought. At a stream crossing a patrol fired on the tail of the line. Cheng fired back from the rocks until the women and children were over the ridge, and then the firing stopped. His brother went back that night and could not find him. In Ban Vinai the family held the funeral without his body. His son keeps a single cartridge case his brother picked up at the stream, on the shelf beside the New Year altar.

Cheng 6 STARVED

Too Weak to Carry the Rifle. For two years after 1975 Cheng fought and hid in the forest north of Vang Vieng, and for two years the family ate what the forest gave. In the hot season of 1979 they started for the river. Cheng, who had once carried a radio, a rifle and a wounded friend down a mountain, could not carry his own pack. He walked until his knees gave way on the fourth day and asked his brother to take the family on. They left rice and water by him. They reached Ban Vinai a month later, and his brother told the story at every New Year afterward, always ending with the same words: he did not ask us to stay.

Cheng 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever After the Offensive. Cheng survived the 1977 fighting around Phou Bia without a wound, and the family thought him lucky. In the rains that followed they hid in a valley where the mosquitoes never stopped. He took the fever in July, shook with it for a week, seemed to recover, and then took it again. The pills he had saved from the army were long gone. He died in a lean-to of banana leaves while his wife held water to his mouth. His brother and two other veterans played no qeej, for fear of the sound, but sang the showing-the-way chant together under their breath. Two years later his wife carried his army photograph to Thailand.

Cheng 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

He Knew the Patrols. In the cold season of 1979 Cheng led the family south toward the river by the timetable he had worked out from months of watching the patrols. He knew when they slept and which trails they used. What he did not know was that the soldiers had mined a footpath the week before. He stepped off the path to let his children pass, and the mine was there. His wife took the children on, because he had told her a hundred times never to stop. They reached Ban Vinai a month later. In the camp a qeej player led his funeral with only his hat on the bier. In Minneapolis, years later, his wife still cooked his favourite dish every New Year.

Cheng 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

He Let Go of the Float. Cheng had never learned to swim. He held the back of the bamboo float with both hands while his brother pulled from the front. Halfway across, a neighbour's float came apart beside them, and her grandmother went under. Cheng let go to catch her, pushed her onto the bamboo beside his children, and could not reach the float again in the dark current. His brother dived for him twice. The float came ashore on the Thai sandbars. In Ban Vinai the old woman sat beside his widow through the whole funeral.

Cheng 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Last Man on the Bank. Cheng had taken the rear, as he always did, watching the trail while the others went down into the water. The soldiers came along the bank with a light. Cheng stood in the open at the water's edge and fired back, and they shot him there. His last act was to push his son's hand off his shirt and into his brother's. The floats drifted out into the dark and reached Thailand. In Ban Vinai his son, who was six, wore his father's army belt at the funeral.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Kong

Doctor; on Side B, Medic trained at Sam Thong. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Kong 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Night Shift Nurse. Kong reached Nong Khai camp in 1975 and worked unpaid at the clinic, cleaning wounds and helping women in labour as he had at Sam Thong. In 1976 a church sponsored the family to St. Paul. His training counted for nothing there. He took a nursing-assistant course and worked nights at a nursing home for a few dollars an hour, studying English on the bus. At forty he passed his nursing exams on the third try, and for twenty years Hmong families asked for him at the hospital. His eldest son opened a grocery store on the East Side. His second son never settled after high school and fought depression for years before finding work as a welder. His daughter became a social worker. In retirement Kong checks blood pressure at clan gatherings and visited the hill where Sam Thong hospital once stood.

Kong 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

The Clinic Behind the Fence. Kong crossed in 1978 and spent fourteen years in Ban Vinai, working as a medic in the camp's health services as he had in the wards at Sam Thong. He delivered babies, and his own children grew up there, learning to read in the camp school. When the camp closed he came to a Minneapolis suburb at forty-five, too old to start again in medicine. He drove a delivery van. His children arrived as teenagers: his eldest daughter finished high school at twenty, went to college, and teaches English to new immigrants; his son, who could not catch up, works in a meatpacking plant and supports his own family. On weekends Kong visited old soldiers with his blood-pressure cuff. In 2023 he volunteered for the SGU wellness program, sitting with veterans who had never spoken of their nightmares.

Kong 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Five Years of Seminar. Kong was arrested in 1976 because he had treated soldiers, and sent to a re-education camp. For five years he cleared land and built roads, and he treated fellow prisoners with whatever grew near the camp. When he was released in 1981 he was watched too closely to flee. The district put him to work in a small dispensary. He married again, raised children who went to school in Lao, and never crossed. In 2009 a nephew from Minnesota found him, and they sat a whole afternoon together, saying little.

Kong 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Medicine in the Seminar. Kong was caught on the trail kneeling beside a wounded man. The soldiers knew he was a doctor who had treated soldiers, and he was sent to Camp 04 near Muang Et. In the camp he worked on the roads like everyone else, but at night he treated other prisoners in secret, boiling bark and setting bones with bamboo splints. When a guard brought him a sick child, he treated the child too, and after that a little medicine came to him. He gave most of it away. Rice was short, and his own health went slowly. In the third rainy season he fell ill with dysentery and died. The men he had treated buried him and said his name for years afterward.

Kong 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Wounded at the Stream. In the hot season of 1978 Kong was kneeling at a stream in the Vang Vieng hills, washing a shrapnel wound in a girl's leg, when a patrol came around the bend. The families foraging upstream scattered into the bamboo. Kong put himself between the soldiers and the girl. The girl was carried off by her uncle and lived; Kong did not. That evening the families gathered at the new camp and could not play the qeej, so his wife sang a kwv txhiaj for him in a whisper. The girl went to Ban Vinai, then to Fresno, and has worked for forty years as a medical interpreter.

Kong 6 STARVED

He Ate Last. In the hills above the Nam Ngum in the winter of 1978, Kong measured the family's food as he had once measured doses at Sam Thong: so much for the children, so much for the nursing mother, so much for the sick. He measured himself last and least. By February he could not walk to the stream. He knew what was happening to his body and said so plainly to his wife, so she would not be frightened. He died in March. She carried his notes to Ban Vinai, where a txiv neeb called her children's souls back from fear. His granddaughter became a nutritionist in Wisconsin.

Kong 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

The Sickness in the Camp. In the rains of 1976 more than a hundred people were hiding in a valley below Phou Bia, and the dysentery came through them like a fire. Kong had no medicine left, only what he knew: boil the water, keep the sick apart, give salt and rice water by the spoonful. He went from shelter to shelter for three weeks, sleeping in snatches, and then he fell sick himself. He died in early August. Most of the children he had nursed lived. A txiv neeb from another clan led his funeral, and families who had never been his relatives played the qeej for him through the night, which no one in the valley had dared to do for months.

Kong 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Last Patient on the Path. In the hot season of 1979 Kong's group walked toward the plain near Vientiane behind a guide who knew the paddy paths. A child ahead of Kong stumbled off the line and screamed; nothing happened, but the guide shouted at everyone to stand still. Kong went forward to look at the child's ankle, because that was what he did. The mine was under his foot. The guide would not let anyone go to him. They left him where he lay with his canvas bag beside him, and his nephew carried his medic's manual the rest of the way. In Ban Vinai the family held his funeral with the bag on the bier. His nephew, a nurse in Minnesota, still has the manual, with the dust of that path in its spine.

Kong 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

He Held Up the Bag. Kong could not swim. He held the edge of an inner tube with one hand and his medical bag above the water with the other, because the bag was everything he could still do for people. When a wave from somewhere upstream rocked the tube, he let go of the tube, not the bag. His nephew found the bag floating and pulled it in, and searched the dark water until Kong's wife made him stop. In Ban Vinai the family held his funeral with the bag on the bier.

Kong 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

He Tested the Current. Kong had insisted on going into the water first, holding the rope, to test the current before the children came in. He was waist deep and turning to wave them in when soldiers on the bank fired. He was shot where he stood, waist deep, and the families scattered back into the reeds. They crossed two nights later, upstream. In Ban Vinai his widow sewed the night into a story cloth, a man in the river with his arm raised. She never sold it.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Lee

Medicine Woman; on Side B, Herbalist. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Lee 1 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Herbs on a Windowsill. Lee reached Ban Vinai in 1976 with a bag of dried roots and cuttings wrapped in wet bark. She planted them behind her shelter and treated fevers and new mothers alongside the camp clinic while the family waited three years for a sponsor. In 1979 a Catholic parish brought them to Providence, Rhode Island. Her son swept a jewellery factory floor; Lee packed eggs at a farm outside the city and learned enough English in a church basement class to ride the bus. Nothing she knew survived a New England winter, so she kept pots on every windowsill. Her granddaughter became a pharmacist; one grandson left high school and drifted for years before he trained as a welder. In old age Lee went back to Laos once, in 2005, to gather seed from the hills, and came home with nothing the border would let through.

Lee 2 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

The Soup for New Mothers. Lee and her son's family crossed in 1979 and spent a year in Ban Vinai, where her granddaughter started school in a bamboo classroom. In 1980 a Lutheran congregation sponsored them to the Detroit area. Her son worked a loading dock and studied English at night; Lee minded the children through a winter that frightened all of them. She turned the narrow backyard into a garden. Soon, when a Hmong baby was born anywhere in Michigan, someone drove to Lee's house for the herbs that go in the month-long postpartum chicken soup. Her granddaughter became a labour-and-delivery nurse and brought her colleagues to meet her. Her son never fully recovered from the war and drank for years. Lee lived to ninety, still giving advice by telephone.

Lee 3 — STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Letters on Cassette. When the escape failed, Lee went back toward home. Her family was moved to a lowland village under government watch and made to farm in common. She treated neighbours with her herbs, quietly, because healers who also called spirits drew attention. Her children who had crossed earlier sent cassette tapes from America, and she recorded answers on the same tapes: news of births, which plants were flowering, which relatives had died. She never left Laos. A grandson from Sacramento visited in the late 1990s and found her still gathering roots on the hillside.

Lee 4 — TAKEN PRISONER

Bark Under the Bunk. When the soldiers took Lee on the trail, someone told them she had nursed wounded fighters, so she was not sent to a village. She was marched north to a numbered camp in Houaphan. The prisoners cut logs and dug irrigation ditches, and the rice was thin. Lee scrounged as she always had. She picked leaves along the work paths, dried them under her bunk, and brewed them at night for men with fever or the flux. A guard saw her once and said nothing. In 1989 she was among those released from Houaphan. She walked into her daughter's lowland village with a cloth bag of seeds and roots, and spent her last years treating neighbours for coughs and burns.

Lee 5 — KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Shells at Phou Bia. In 1977 the families hiding below Phou Bia lived under constant pressure from Vietnamese and Lao troops. One afternoon Lee was pounding bark in a wooden mortar when the shells began to fall. She pushed the children toward the gully and went back for the toddler asleep in the shelter. She did not come back out. When the shelling stopped, her husband found her with the child unhurt beneath her. There was no time for a funeral; they left that night. In Ban Vinai a txiv neeb called the child's frightened soul back, and the family held Lee's rites with her clothes.

Lee 6 — STARVED

Her Share of Rice. By the cool season of 1977 the family's rice was carried in a single bamboo tube. Lee measured it out each evening in the Vang Vieng hills: a little for each grandchild, a little for the nursing mother, nothing for herself. She said the old did not need much. She ate boiled leaves and banana stem, and taught the children which shoots were safe. Her legs swelled, then her face. One morning she did not wake from beside the fire. Her son held the funeral in camp with a borrowed qeej, and every year at New Year her grandchildren put the first spoonful of rice in a bowl for her.

Lee 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Bark Tea for the Flux. In the rains of 1978 the family camped under bamboo above the Nam Xan, moving every few weeks. Half the camp had the bloody flux. Lee boiled bark over a smoky fire, carried the tea from shelter to shelter, and washed the sick with water hauled up from the stream. When the cramps took her too she kept dosing the others until she could not stand. She died on the fourth night, with rain drumming on the leaves. Her son buried her on the slope, and an old man spoke the showing-the-way words softly, without a qeej. Her daughter carried the blackened bark pot to Ban Vinai and kept it for the rest of her life.

Lee 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Old Field. In the dry season of 1977 the family hid in the Vang Vieng hills, and Lee went out to an abandoned field to dig for roots. The ground there was pocked with old craters, grown over with grass. Her hoe struck something round and rusted, and it went off. Her son found her at the edge of the clearing with the hoe beside her. They could not stay to mourn; he tied a thread to his wrist, burned a little incense and said her name to the hills. Years later in Minnesota her granddaughter read about the bombs still lying in Laotian fields, and every year she sent money to those who clear them.

Lee 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

The Tube Came Ashore. Lee crossed with a sealed bamboo tube of medicine tied around her waist, because she would not leave it behind. The current was stronger than anyone had said, and when the raft tipped in the dark she went under and did not come up. At first light her son walked the Thai bank and found only the tube, caught in tree roots, still sealed. In Ban Vinai the family held her funeral with her clothes in her place, and the dry bark inside it broke three fevers that winter.

Lee 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Last One on the Bank. Lee had stopped to pull a woman out of the mud, and so she was the last one still on the bank when the soldiers fired. Her son was already in the water with his daughter on his back and could not turn round. The current carried them over. From the Thai side they watched torches moving on the Lao bank until dawn. In Nong Khai camp a neighbour chanted the words that show the soul its way, and her son tied a white string on his daughter's wrist.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Bao

Tailor; on Side B, Tailor of warm clothes. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Bao 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Cloths for Sale. In Ban Vinai, Bao and other women began sewing a new kind of paj ntaub: story cloths, with soldiers, burning villages and people wading the Mekong in tiny stitches. Traders and relief workers bought them, and the money paid for meat and soap during the four years the family waited. In 1981 they were resettled in La Crosse, Wisconsin. Her husband worked nights cleaning a hospital; Bao took in alterations at her kitchen table, then opened a small shop. Her eldest daughter finished college and became a lawyer; her second son left school at sixteen and took years to find his way. Bao sewed every grandchild's New Year clothes. In 2019 she went to the dedication of the Hmong-Lao veterans memorial at Veterans Freedom Park, where her brother's name was read.

Bao 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Quilts for a Michigan Winter. Bao reached Ban Vinai in 1978 and spent a year there sewing for families who had walked out in rags. In 1979 a church sponsored them to Michigan. Nobody had warned them about the winter. Volunteers brought donated coats; Bao took the extras apart and resewed them to fit Hmong children. She worked in a hotel laundry and went to English class on Saturdays. Within a few years she was quilting for the neighbourhood from thrift-store fabric, and later sold quilts with paj ntaub borders at craft fairs. Of her five children, one became a social worker and one an auto engineer; one son was in a gang as a teenager and later spoke at schools about leaving it. Her grandchildren still sleep under her quilts.

Bao 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Seven Years Near Phou Bia. Turned back before the river, Bao's family joined others hiding in the forests around Phou Bia. They moved camp often, farmed small hidden plots and lost people to hunger and to the attacks of 1977 and 1978. Bao cut up her good clothes for children's shirts. In 1982 a guide led her group to the Mekong and they crossed on rafts. In Ban Vinai she sewed story cloths for sale like the other women, but hers showed the forest, not the river. She reached Wisconsin in 1987.

Bao 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Patches for the Plain. The soldiers who caught Bao on the trail took her sewing bundle and then, after looking through it, gave it back. She was sent with other captured civilians to the Plain of Jars and placed in a farming cooperative under government control. Cloth was scarce, so the cooperative made her its tailor. She patched work shirts, cut down old army trousers for children, and sewed cadre jackets when an official needed one for a meeting. She was paid in rice and was watched like everyone else. She married a widower there and raised his children with her own. She never left Laos. When New Year was allowed she still stitched the old patterns into collars, small, where nobody would think to look.

Bao 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Ambush Near the Road. In the cool season of 1976 Bao's group had to cross Route 13, where troops were hunting for the men who ambushed convoys. They waited in the elephant grass until dark, then went over in small bunches. Shots came out of the trees on the far side. Bao was carrying her sewing bundle and the youngest on her hip; the child was pulled clear, and she was not. Her husband led the family on that night. In Ban Vinai they held her funeral with a set of her clothes while a qeej played. Her eldest daughter kept the bundle of half-cut collars, and sewed one into every New Year outfit after that.

Bao 6 STARVED

Cloth for Rice. In the spring of 1978 Bao's family hid in the hills west of Vang Vieng, and the rice was gone. Bao did what she could: at night she walked down to the Lao farms with her paj ntaub folded in a cloth and traded a collar or a skirt panel for a basket of rice, the work of a year for a week of meals. When the last panel was gone she traded her silver, and then there was nothing. She filled the children's bowls first and said she had eaten while cooking. She died in the hot months before the rains, and her husband washed her and dressed her in the one skirt she had refused to sell. Her eldest daughter later sewed the family's story cloth with a mother at a Lao door, a bundle in her arms.

Bao 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Sewing in the Fever. In the rains of 1977 Bao's family sheltered under banana leaves in the Vang Vieng hills, and dysentery went through the camp. Bao nursed the children with rice water and kept sewing between their fits, cutting down an army blanket into jackets for the cold months she knew were coming. When the cramps took her she worked by feel, lying down. She finished the last jacket two days before she died. Her sister washed her and dressed her in her best paj ntaub, and an old man chanted the showing-the-way softly, without a qeej. Every child in the group wore one of those jackets through the winter in the hills, and her daughter kept hers folded in a chest in Michigan for fifty years.

Bao 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

A Hut by the Road. In the cold season of 1979 Bao's family sheltered for a night in an empty hut at the edge of a lowland village, a day's walk from the river. The people had fled, and the soldiers who came after them had left something behind. Bao went in first, to spread the children's bedding, and lifted a mat that had been laid over the floor. The blast took her and spared the children, who were still outside with their father. There was no time for more than a few words and a bowl of rice left on the step. In Ban Nam Yao camp her husband held the rites with her clothes. Their daughter still wears a jacket Bao cut down from an army blanket on that walk.

Bao 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

The Dry Bundle. Bao tied the children's winter clothes in a plastic sheet on her head and swam behind the raft with one hand on it. Midway an eddy spun the raft and tore her grip away. Her son called for her across the black water until the others made him stop. Two days later Thai villagers found the bundle in the shallows downstream, the clothes inside still dry, and a camp worker brought it to Ban Vinai. Her sister wore Bao's own jacket from it at the funeral.

Bao 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

A Jacket Sewn Too Big. Bao stayed on the bank to tie the last child onto the raft, in a jacket she had sewn too big so it would last. The soldiers came out of the trees and fired as the raft pushed off, and she dropped in the shallows. Her husband held the raft and the children and kicked for Thailand. They reached the far bank without her. At the funeral in Nong Khai camp the qeej played all night, and the boy wore that jacket through two winters until it fit him.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Ka

Singer; on Side B, Kwv txhiaj singer. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Ka 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Songs on Tape. Ka was known in Ban Vinai for her kwv txhiaj, the long sung poems about orphans, lost homes and courting. In her four years there she sang at New Year, and someone recorded her on a borrowed cassette player; copies reached America before she did. In 1980 her family was resettled in Sacramento. She worked in a garment shop, then a school cafeteria, and studied English at an adult school. Her husband, a former soldier, could find only seasonal farm work and grew quiet. Of their children, one became a public-health nurse and another a Sacramento police officer; one daughter married at sixteen and finished school later as an adult. Ka kept singing at weddings and New Year, and in old age a granddaughter put her songs online so relatives in Laos and Minnesota could hear them.

Ka 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Night Songs in Ontario. On the walk Ka sang low at night so the children would sleep. In Ban Vinai she sang for the sick and the grieving and married a young widower. When resettlement came in 1979 the couple chose Canada, where only a few Hmong families were being settled. A church in southern Ontario sponsored them; she worked on a factory line for twenty years and learned English on the job. Because she was one of the few singers in the province, families phoned her to sing at weddings and New Year. Her stepson became a high-school teacher; her own daughter studied engineering; her youngest son, lonely as the only Hmong boy in his class, left home young and came back years later. In retirement Ka taught kwv txhiaj to teenage girls, explaining each old word before they sang it back.

Ka 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Still in Laos. Ka's group was turned back and she returned to the hills, then to a resettlement village where the family was registered and watched. She married there and raised six children. She sang at New Year when it was allowed, but never the songs about the war. Her cousins in America sent money and, after 2000, visited. Ka never crossed and never wanted to by then. She still lives in Laos, and young relatives from Wisconsin record her singing on their phones when they visit.

Ka 4 TAKEN PRISONER

A Song Across the River. Ka was caught on the trail and sent with other captured civilians to a resettlement village near Xieng Khouang town. She farmed in common and kept her voice low. The officials liked songs about work and the new country, and she learned a few. At night, for the women, she sang the old ones. She married there and had a son. In the late 1980s her husband's brother came with a guide, and the family left in the rains. They walked by night because escapees were caught or shot on those routes. They crossed the Mekong holding on to bamboo. In Ban Vinai Ka sang at New Year, and the family was later resettled in the United States, where she sang at weddings.

Ka 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Ambush at the Stream. In the dry season of 1978 Ka went out with the other young women to gather leaves and dig cassava along a stream below Phou Bia. They worked quietly, because soldiers watched the water. Someone stepped on a dry branch. The firing came from across the stream, and the women scattered into the bamboo. Ka did not come back. Her mother and sister found her the next day and buried her where she lay. There was no qeej, only her mother's voice saying the showing-the-way words. Her sister sang Ka's songs to herself for the rest of the walk, so as not to forget them.

Ka 6 STARVED

The Burned Rice. In 1977 Ka's family farmed a hidden plot in the Vang Vieng hills. Just before harvest the soldiers found it and burned the standing rice. For the rest of the year they lived on what the forest gave: shoots, bitter leaves, small fish from the streams. Ka sang the children to sleep so they would not cry with hunger. Her husband came back from foraging one evening to find her too weak to lift her head. She died that week. With no qeej player in the group, her husband chanted what he remembered. Her son, a teacher in Fresno, still hums the songs she sang over those empty bowls.

Ka 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever Under the Mountain. In the rains of 1978 Ka's family hid in bamboo shelters on the slopes below Phou Bia. Mosquitoes whined all night. Ka caught a fever that came and went every two days; she sang to the children through the good days and shook under every blanket on the bad ones. There was no medicine, only bark tea. She died in the ninth week, so thin her silver rings slid off her fingers. Her husband buried her on a slope facing east, and an uncle chanted the showing-the-way. Her daughter kept the rings and wore them on a string around her neck through the camp years.

Ka 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Ground Under the Fire. In early 1977 Ka's family camped by an old field near the plain, where the hills drop toward Vientiane. It was cold at night, and Ka scraped a hollow in the earth and built a fire for her mother and sister. She did not know that a small bomb from the war lay buried just beneath it. When the heat reached it, it went off. Her sister was burned but lived. They buried Ka at the edge of the field, and her mother wept the old mourning song. Years later, in Michigan, her sister would not let her grandchildren build a campfire without first digging the ground by hand.

Ka 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Singing Out Over the Water. Ka could swim a little, so she went in last, to watch the children ahead. The river was high and brown and full of drifting wood. Halfway over she called to them in her singing voice, the way she gathered them at night, and then her voice stopped. Thai fishermen found her downstream two days later and buried her on their bank. Her husband was allowed to visit the grave once, and sang over it the only song he knew.

Ka 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Last Down the Bank. Ka was the last down the bank, carrying the pot and the blanket, when a flashlight found her. Soldiers fired from the path above and she fell among the reeds. She had told the others to go first, and they had. Her husband turned back; their son, clinging to the float, screamed for him, and he came. In Ban Vinai he would not let anyone say her name for a year. Then at New Year he asked a woman from their village to sing Ka's songs, and listened with his eyes closed.

ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Pa

Shaman; on Side B, Shaman, soul caller. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Pa 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

The Gong in Detroit. Pa crossed in 1978 with her shaman's tools wrapped in a blanket: the rattle-ring, the finger bells and the split horns. In Ban Vinai she performed ua neeb for families frightened by the crossing while they all waited for sponsors. In 1979 her family was resettled near Detroit. Her son worked in a parts plant; Pa learned a little English and set up her altar in a rented living room. On weekends families drove from across Michigan for her, the gong sounding through thin walls; after one complaint she warned the neighbours in advance. Her son became a doctor and sometimes sent patients' families to her; her daughter converted to Christianity, and for years they barely spoke. In 2008 Pa returned to Laos to perform rites at her parents' graves, then came home to her grandchildren.

Pa 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Fourteen Years of Funerals. Pa reached Ban Vinai in 1979 and stayed until it closed in the early 1990s. In a camp of tens of thousands she called back souls frightened loose by the war and the river, and led rites for those who had died on the way, often without bodies. Her children went to the camp schools, learned some Thai and English, and waited. In 1993 the family flew to Sacramento. Pa was over sixty and never worked outside the home; her son started on an assembly line at $5 an hour. She performed hu plig in his garage and led funerals at the funeral homes Hmong families rented. One grandson became a social worker; another struggled in school and was later in prison, and she called his soul each time he came home. When she died in 2011, three people she had trained led her funeral.

Pa 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Under Phou Bia. When the crossing failed, Pa went back into the forest with the Chao Fa families near Phou Bia. For years she was their shaman, performing rites quietly because the gong could carry. Many in her group crossed to Thailand after the offensives of 1977 and 1978; Pa would not leave the sick. Relatives in America heard of her through travellers into the 1990s, then nothing. Groups of Hmong were still reported hiding in that jungle in 2006 and in 2025. Her family does not know if she lived among them.

Pa 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Finger Bells in a Rice Sack. Pa was caught on the trail and sent with other captured families to a resettlement village near Xieng Khouang town. Officials there called her rites superstition and forbade the gong. Pa kept her finger bells wrapped in a rice sack and did her healing at night, with the door shut and the rattle muffled in cloth. Neighbours came to her quietly when a child would not stop crying. In the mid 1980s her son found a guide. Pa left with the bells and her shaman's horn and walked by night, because escapees were often caught on that route. They crossed the Mekong in the dark. In Ban Vinai she set up her altar again, and later called souls in a garage in California.

Pa 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Cave at Night. In the cool season of 1977 Pa's family sheltered with others in a cave in the limestone hills between Vang Vieng and the Nam Ngum. They had left their rooster behind so its crowing would not give them away. Soldiers attacked the cave in the night. Pa was at the back with the sick, and she would not leave them. When it was over her son found her beside her shaman's bench, her finger bells still in her hand. With no other shaman in the group, an old man said the showing-the-way words over incense. Her son carried her tools to Thailand wrapped in a blanket and never let them out of his house.

Pa 6 STARVED

Rice for the Grandchildren. In the cool season of 1977 Pa's family hid in the hills near Vang Vieng with almost nothing left. Pa had performed rites for the sick in exchange for rice all her life, and now there was no rice to give. She made the grandchildren eat first and told them the spirits would feed her. She ate leaves and drank hot water. Her son saw her shrinking and said nothing. She died in her sleep before the new year. A neighbour said the showing-the-way. Her son carried her tools to Ban Vinai, and in his house in Detroit the grandchildren still set out rice for her at New Year.

Pa 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever in the Wet Season. In the rains of 1978 Pa's group sheltered under bark roofs on the wooded slopes below Phou Bia. Fever went through the camp. Pa called soul after soul, sitting before her makeshift altar through the night, and when the shaking fever took her too she kept calling until she could not lift the rattle. She died before dawn. With no other shaman among them, her daughter, who had followed her to every funeral as a girl, said as much of the showing-the-way as she knew. In the camp at Ban Vinai a shaman from her clan held the proper rites, and her daughter remembered the words she had not.

Pa 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Shortcut. In the cold season of 1979 Pa's group followed a guide along a footpath toward the Mekong, and Pa, slow with age, fell behind. A young man took her a shorter way across a dry streambed to catch the others up. The guide had not brought them that way for a reason. The mine took Pa and spared the young man, who carried her finger bells to the river. Her son said her name on the path and left a cup of rice and a stick of incense. In Sob Tuang camp another shaman led her rites with a rooster and a set of her clothes, and her son later told his own children that she had shown the dead the way for forty years.

Pa 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Back Onto the Float. Pa crossed on a moonlit night, sharing a float of four bamboo poles with her daughter. Halfway over, the girl's grip failed and she slid off. Pa let go to reach her, pushed her back onto the float, and could not catch it again in the current. The daughter reached the Thai bank at first light. In Ban Vinai a shaman called the girl's frightened soul back with a rooster, and the family held Pa's funeral with her clothes and her finger bells.

Pa 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Calling the Children First. At every crossing point Pa stopped at the water's edge to call the children's souls, so none would stay behind on the Lao side afraid. She was doing it when the patrol saw her. They fired from the bank, and she fell in the mud with the rattle-ring in her hand. Her son dragged the children into the water. In Ban Vinai a shaman led her rites. Her son, who became a shaman in Wisconsin, begins every crossing of his own by calling the children first.